A PETRO-ORESTEIA

BURIED FURIES

The Mad Max Saga as Petro-Oresteia: Combustion, Vengeance, and the Eumenidean Imagination in the Cinema of George Miller and Byron Kennedy, 1979–2024

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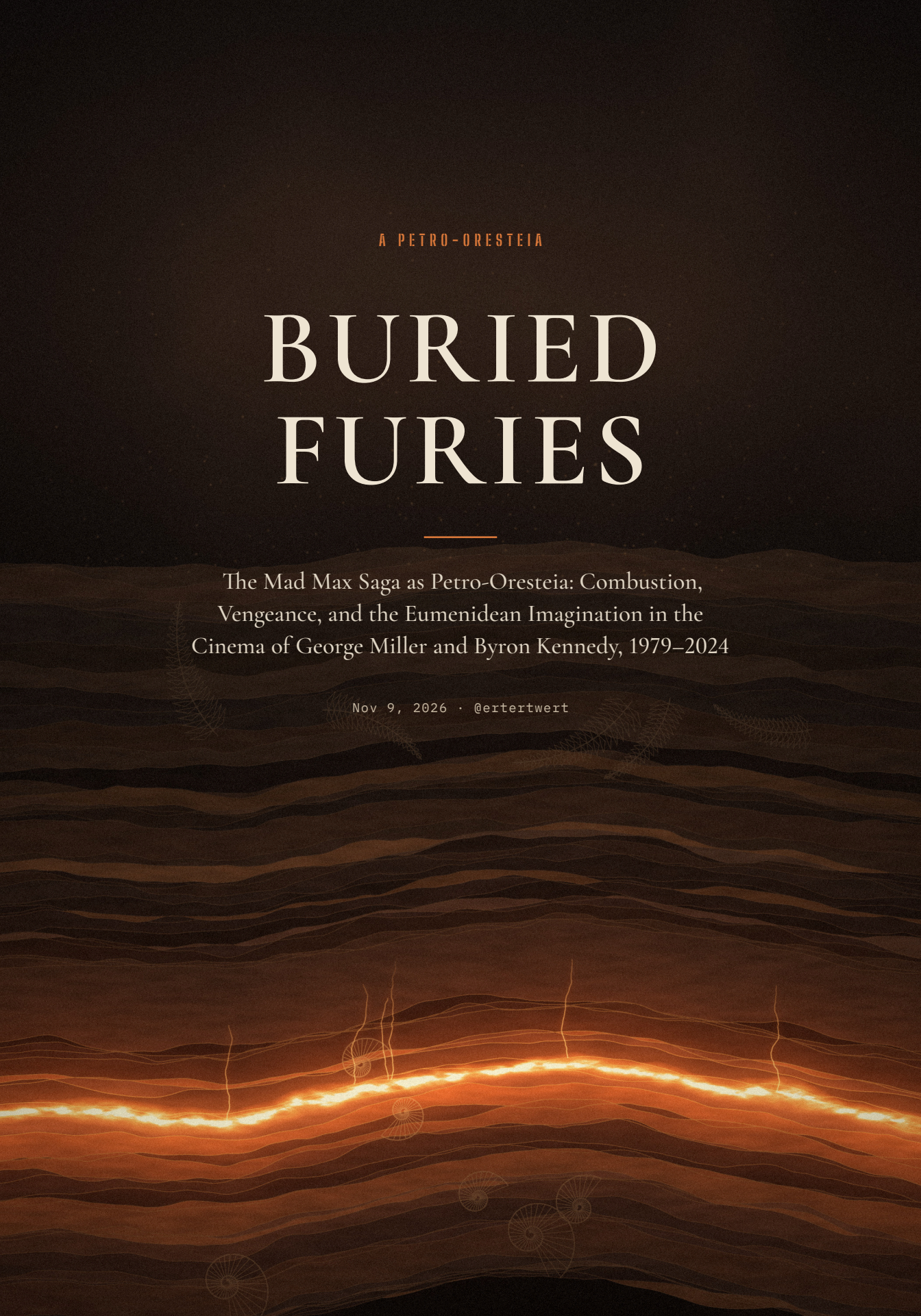
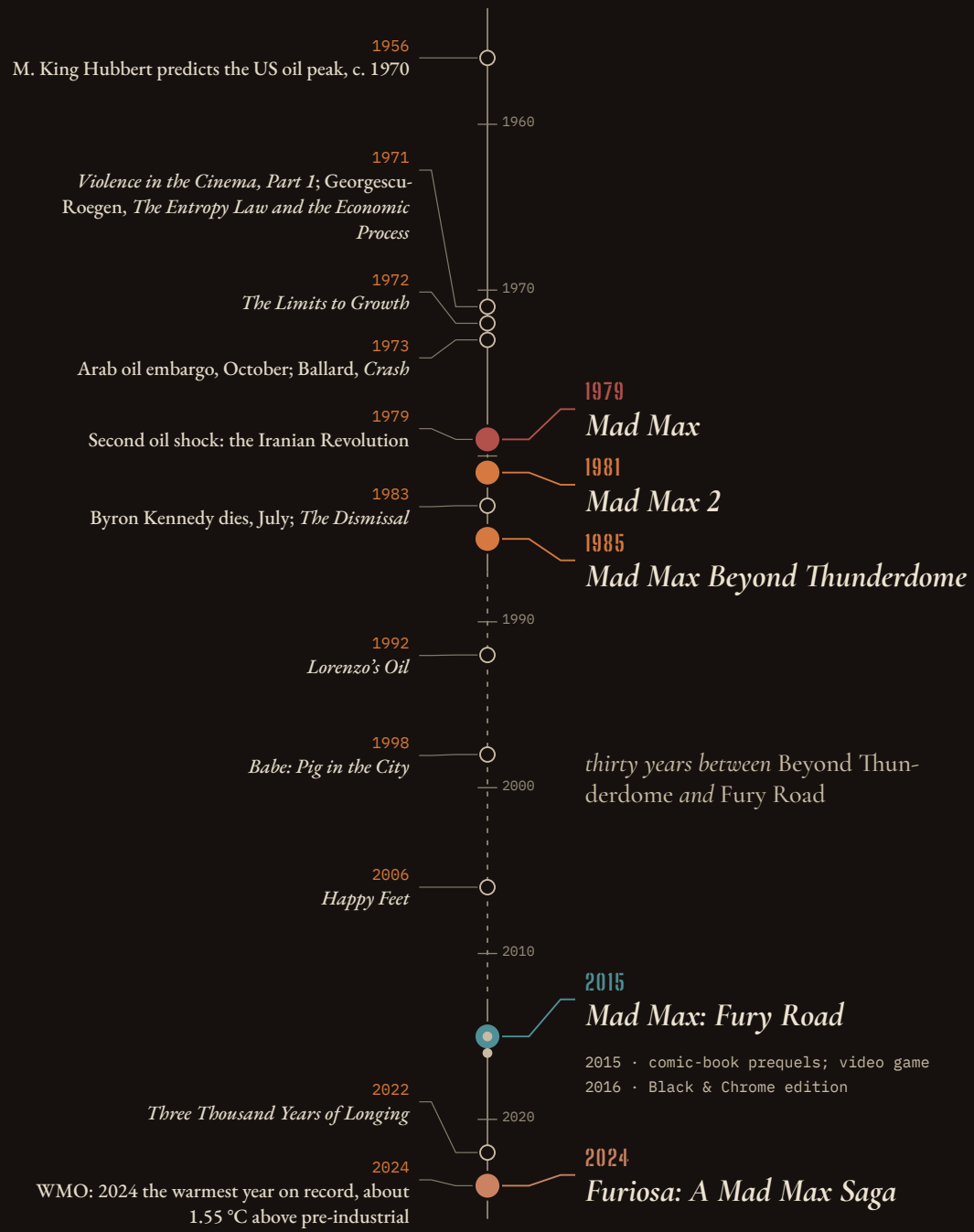


THE SAGA AND ITS CONTEXTS

1956 – 2024



Abstract

THIS THESIS ARGUES that the Mad Max saga—*Mad Max* (1979), *Mad Max 2* (1981), *Mad Max Beyond Thunderdome* (1985), *Mad Max: Fury Road* (2015), and *Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga* (2024)—constitutes the most sustained mythopoetic rewriting of Aeschylus's *Oresteia* produced in the age of fossil combustion, and that its forty-five-year development articulates a coherent, though never programmatically declared, philosophy of energy, justice, and narrative. Conceived by George Miller, a physician whose clinical formation coincided with the historic peak of the Australian road toll, and Byron Kennedy, a self-taught technician of the moving image, in the interval between the first oil shock of 1973 and the second of 1979, the cycle is read here as a *petro-Oresteia*: a mythic apparatus in which the unburied dead of geological time—the Carboniferous forests and Mesozoic plankton combusted as coal and petroleum—return as the Erinyes of modernity, and in which the exhaustion of fuel, the exhaustion of law, and the exhaustion of narrative are staged as a single convergent catastrophe.

Against the prevailing interpretive paradigms—the Campbellian monomyth that Miller himself retrospectively embraced, the Hobbesian state of nature reflexively invoked by journalistic criticism, and the petrocultural readings advanced by the energy humanities—the thesis contends that the Wasteland is neither pre-legal nor merely post-industrial but *post-nomic*: the afterlife of a legal and energetic order that has consumed its own foundations. Five analytical instruments are developed to anatomise this condition. The *Erinyic economy* names the structural isomorphism between combustion and vengeance as regimes of irreversible expenditure, theorised through Bataille's general economy, Georgescu-Roegen's entropic bioeconomics, and Benjamin's critique of mythic violence. *Chthonopolitics* designates a sovereignty founded upon control of what lies beneath—aquifer, oil seam, ore body—and is elaborated through Wittfogel's hydraulic despotism, Schmitt's nomos of the earth, Mitchell's carbon democracy, and Heidegger's standing-reserve. The *pharmakos-witness* reconceives Max Rockatansky not as hero or anti-hero but as the Levitical and Girardian scapegoat whose serial expulsion founds communities he is constitutively unable to join, and as the *martys*—the witness—who refuses the martyrdom his antagonists crave. *Kinetic liturgy* describes Miller's "pure cinema" of motion as

ritual rather than spectacle: the chase as a liturgical form through which mythic time is re-actualised. The *Eumenidean turn*, finally, names the saga's culminating conversion of fury into fertility—of the petro-chthonic into the humic-chthonic, of combustion into germination—which re-stages Aeschylus's settlement while inverting the Apollonian embryology upon which that settlement, and a long tradition of Western legal patriarchy, was founded.

Methodologically, the thesis practises a comparative mythography grounded in Lévi-Strauss's doctrine of mythic variance, Warburg's inquiry into the afterlife of antiquity, and Barthes's analysis of myth as depoliticised speech, and it distinguishes rigorously among documented influence, contextual convergence, and structural homology. It reads the saga alongside the Epic of Gilgamesh, Exodus, the Grail romances, the *Poetic Edda*, Ibn Khaldun, Vico, Henry Adams, T. S. Eliot, J. G. Ballard, Ursula K. Le Guin, Octavia E. Butler, Frank Herbert, Hayao Miyazaki, and Cormac McCarthy, and situates it within the Australian visual and literary traditions—Sidney Nolan, Patrick White, Nevil Shute—from which its antipodean apocalypse descends. It concludes that the saga's ethical horizon is not the apotheosis of a hero but the burial of the Furies: the return of the chthonic powers to the ground, honoured rather than consumed, as the precondition of any habitable future.

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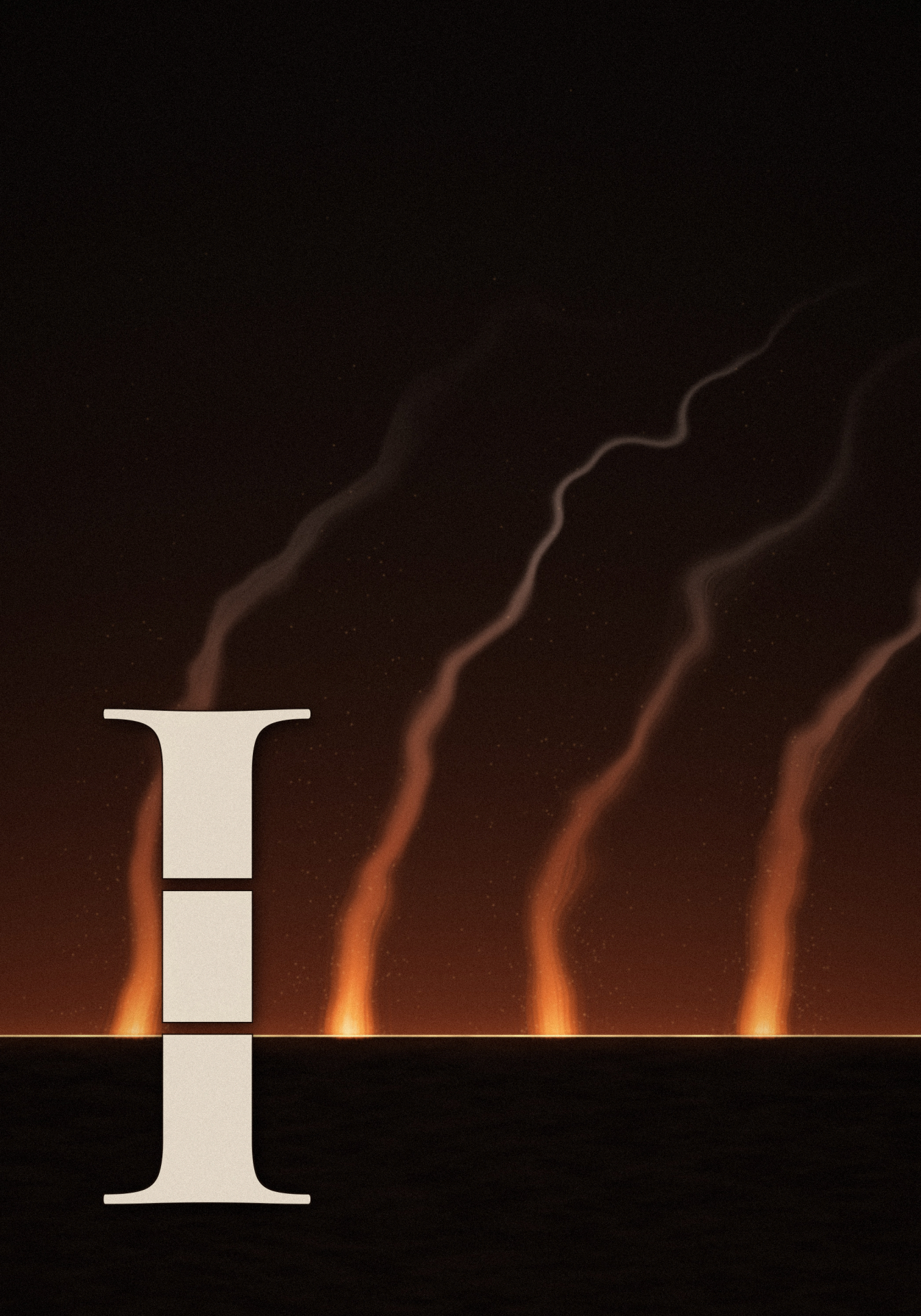


CHAPTER ONE

Exhaust, Exhaustion, Replenishment

Prolegomena to a Petro-Oresteia

1.1 The Inaugural Problem: A Mythology Without a Scripture

Few bodies of popular cinema have been so persistently called mythic and so rarely interrogated as myth. Since the international reception of *Mad Max* in 1979, critical and journalistic commentary has reached for the lexicon of legend almost by reflex—the road warrior, the lone avenger, the knight errant of the bitumen—while leaving largely unexamined the prior questions of what kind of mythology the saga constitutes, what cultural work it performs, and upon which antecedent mythic systems it draws, deliberately or otherwise. Much of that lexicon was furnished by the filmmakers themselves. George Miller's frequently rehearsed account of the first film's global reception—the discovery that Japanese audiences received Max as a masterless samurai, Scandinavian audiences as a solitary Norse warrior, and French audiences as the gunfighter of the American western transposed to the highways of an antipodean near-future—led him, on his own testimony, to Joseph Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949), and thence to a deliberate mythologisation of the sequels. The monomyth thereby became not merely an interpretive lens subsequently applied to the saga but one of its compositional principles, and its prominence in the critical literature is in part an artefact of authorial self-description.

This thesis begins from the conviction that the inherited framework is at once indispensable and insufficient. It is indispensable because the saga is insistently, even

obsessively, mythopoetic. Every film after the first is narrated, framed, or epigraphically sealed as legend: by the aged Feral Kid whose voice-over in *Mad Max 2* (1981) recollects "the man we called Max"; by the Tell, the ritual oral history recited by the Lost Tribe of *Mad Max Beyond Thunderdome* (1985); by the aphorism attributed to "the First History Man" that seals *Mad Max: Fury Road* (2015); and by the History Man of *Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga* (2024), an archivist whose body is inscribed with the remnants of a vanished civilisation's knowledge. No comparable corpus of action cinema thematises its own mythogenesis—the process by which catastrophe becomes story, story becomes legend, and legend becomes law—with such persistence. Yet the monomyth is insufficient, because its universalising architecture, which locates the meaning of all heroic narrative in a single psycho-spiritual itinerary of separation, initiation, and return, is structurally incapable of registering what is most historically specific and philosophically radical in the cycle: its staging of an energetic catastrophe as the matrix of every other catastrophe; its sustained meditation on the exhaustion of law; its progressive dethronement of the very hero whom the monomyth exists to consecrate; and its culminating substitution of a collective, female, and agricultural mythos of replenishment for a solitary, male, and combustive mythos of conquest. The monomyth explains why Max Rockatansky resembles every hero. It cannot explain why the saga, across four and a half decades, labours so persistently to render him unnecessary.

Here, then, is the inaugural problem: the Mad Max saga is a mythology without a scripture, a cycle of variants in search of the myth that would make sense of them. Its own narrators concede as much. The Feral Kid's prologue is a fragmentary recollection of a catastrophe whose causes are "long forgotten"; the Tell is a cargo-cult liturgy whose referents its reciters no longer understand; and the History Man of *Furiosa* offers, at the climax of his own chronicle, competing versions of a single event and declines to adjudicate among them. The saga knows itself to be a story told by survivors who no longer possess the text of their own origin. It is this absence—the missing scripture behind the legend—that the present thesis proposes to supply, not by inventing a source the films do not possess, but by identifying the ancient narrative of which, it will be argued, the saga is the most sustained modern variant.

That narrative is the *Oresteia* of Aeschylus, produced at the City Dionysia of 458 BCE: the oldest surviving dramatic account of a community's passage from the self-perpetuating logic of blood-vengeance to the institution of law, and the founding myth, for the Western tradition, of how the energies of fury may be converted into the foundations of a polity. The claim is not genetic. Nothing in the documentary record suggests that Miller or Kennedy set out to adapt Aeschylus, and nothing in the argument that follows depends upon their having done so. The claim is homo-

logical, in the sense that comparative mythography from Claude Lévi-Strauss to Wendy Doniger has given that term: the trilogy and the saga are variants of a single deep problem—how a community ruined by retaliation may transmute fury into order, at what cost, and at whose expense—articulated under radically different material conditions. What the saga adds to the Aeschylean problem, and what justifies the neologism that gives this thesis its subtitle, is the specific historical condition of fossil modernity, in which the energies requiring conversion are not merely psychic or social but geological. The Mad Max saga is a *petro-Oresteia*: a tragedy of retaliation whose Furies are the unburied dead of deep time, raised from beneath the earth as fuel and returned to the air as fire.

Corpus, Authorship, and the Dual Signature 1.2

The primary corpus comprises five feature films whose credits record a shifting constellation of collaborators around a single constant. *Mad Max* was directed by Miller and produced by Byron Kennedy from a screenplay by Miller and the journalist James McCausland, on a story by Miller and Kennedy. *Mad Max 2*—released in North America as *The Road Warrior*—was written by Terry Hayes, Miller, and Brian Hannant. *Mad Max Beyond Thunderdome* was co-directed by Miller and the theatre director George Ogilvie from a screenplay by Hayes and Miller, and is dedicated to Kennedy, who had died in a helicopter accident in New South Wales in July 1983. *Fury Road* was written by Miller with the British comics artist Brendan McCarthy and the actor and dramatist Nico Lathouris; *Furiosa* by Miller and Lathouris. To these five the thesis adds, as secondary corpus, the paratexts through which the saga has been extended and reframed—the monochrome "Black & Chrome" edition of *Fury Road* (2016), the comic-book prequels published under DC's Vertigo imprint in 2015, and the open-world video game developed by Avalanche Studios in the same year—and, as a body of authorial commentary, the films of Miller's career outside the saga, which return with remarkable consistency to the problems the saga dramatises.

The question of authorship is not ancillary to the argument but constitutive of it. The thesis takes seriously the formula by which the saga is commonly attributed—created by George Miller and Byron Kennedy—even though Kennedy's direct participation ended with the second film. It does so not from sentimental fidelity to a collaborator lost young, but because the Miller–Kennedy partnership furnishes, at the level of biography, a figure for the problematic that the saga elaborates at the level of myth. Miller trained in medicine at the University of New South Wales

and practised as a resident at St Vincent's Hospital in Sydney, where the emergency treatment of road trauma constituted, by his own account, a formative education in the vulnerability of flesh to machines. Kennedy, a largely self-taught technician of the moving image, brought to the partnership an engineer's intimacy with the apparatus and a passion for engines and flight that would ultimately cost him his life. The saga's dual signature thus inscribes the encounter of the clinic and the workshop: of the physician who repairs the body and the technician who builds the machine. That the saga's central visual and conceptual preoccupation is precisely the interface between body and machine—the crushed chassis and the crushed limb, the engine fetishised as a god and the body harvested as fuel, Furiosa's mechanical forearm and the captive Max strapped as a living blood-reservoir to the prow of a war car—suggests that the partnership's founding asymmetry became the films' founding obsession. Michel Foucault's argument in "What Is an Author?" (1969) that the author-function designates not a person but a principle of grouping, a site at which a discourse's unity is posited, licenses the thesis to treat "Miller–Kennedy" as the name of a problematic rather than of two biographical individuals, and to trace that problematic's persistence after Kennedy's death in the production house —Kennedy Miller, later Kennedy Miller Mitchell—that continued to bear his name.

The partnership's first collaboration offers a precise emblem of what was to come. *Violence in the Cinema, Part 1* (1971), a short satire made after the two men met at a summer film workshop at the University of Melbourne, presents a lecturer delivering a sober disquisition on screen violence while subjected, without interruption to his discourse, to escalating and absurd physical violence. The joke is reflexive and prophetic. It stages the incommensurability between the discourse that would analyse violence and the violence that exceeds every discourse—an incommensurability the saga would explore for half a century—and it already locates the body as the surface upon which representation and its limits are inscribed. The future physician-director and his engineer-producer began, that is, by theorising the spectacle they would go on to perfect.

Miller's films outside the saga constitute a body of authorial commentary to which the thesis returns throughout. *Lorenzo's Oil* (1992), a medical drama concerning parents who seek, against institutional scepticism, a remedy for their son's degenerative disease, makes oil the substance of cure rather than catastrophe—a pharmacological inversion whose resonance with the saga's economy of combustion is examined in Chapter Six. *Babe: Pig in the City* (1998) restages the saga's urban dystopia as fable, and *Happy Feet* (2006) extends its ecological concern to the depletion of the seas. Most significant is *Three Thousand Years of Longing* (2022), adapted from A. S. Byatt's novella *The Djinn in the Nightingale's Eye* (1994), whose

protagonist is a narratologist—a professional scholar of story—and whose subject is the function of narrative in human survival. That Miller should have made, between *Fury Road* and *Furiosa*, a film whose explicit theme is the anthropological necessity of myth confirms that the saga's self-reflexive concern with mythogenesis is programmatic rather than incidental. To these may be added the Kennedy Miller television miniseries of the 1980s, beginning with *The Dismissal* (1983), a dramatisation of the constitutional crisis of November 1975 in which the Governor-General dismissed an elected government: a production attesting, beyond the saga, to the house's preoccupation with the fragility of legitimate authority.

A final preliminary concerns the saga's notorious discontinuities. Max's age, history, and appearance vary between films without explanation; the V8 Interceptor destroyed in *Mad Max 2* reappears in *Fury Road*; the chronology of the collapse is never stabilised; and Miller has resisted characterising *Fury Road* as either sequel or reboot. The thesis treats these discontinuities not as lapses of franchise management but as the formal signature of the saga's mode of existence. They are the marks of variant transmission—the means by which a legend, retold by different tellers to different audiences, accumulates incompatible versions without ceasing to be one legend. Section 1.8 develops the methodological consequences of this claim.

The Triple Exhaustion 1.3

The title of this chapter names three senses of exhaustion whose convergence, it will be argued, constitutes the philosophical core of the saga. The first is the most literal. *Exhaust* is the residue of combustion: the gas expelled once fuel has surrendered its energy to motion, the material trace of an irreversible transformation. The saga's sensorium is saturated with it. The films are composed of smoke, dust, heat-shimmer, and fume; their soundtracks are dominated by the roar of the expelled; and their iconography returns repeatedly to figures of contaminated breath. Immortan Joe, the sovereign of *Fury Road*, cannot breathe unaided the air his order has produced, and wears a respirator moulded into a skeletal grin; his War Boys spray their mouths with chrome before the suicidal acts that will, they believe, deliver them to Valhalla, inhaling the very vapour of the machine they worship; and the film's central set-piece is a toxic storm, a cyclone of sand, lightning, and wreckage that may be read as the cumulative exhaust of a civilisation returned to it as weather. Exhaust, in the saga, is never merely atmospheric. It is the visible form of combustion's irreversibility—the proof, hanging in the air, that what has been burned cannot be unburned.

The second sense is *depletion*: the using-up of a finite stock. The saga was conceived in the decade in which the finitude of fossil energy entered the political imagination of the industrial world with the force of revelation. M. King Hubbert's prediction (1956) that conventional oil production in the contiguous United States would peak around 1970 was borne out almost to the year; the Club of Rome's *The Limits to Growth* (Meadows et al. 1972) modelled a global trajectory of overshoot and collapse; and the Arab oil embargo of October 1973, followed in 1979 by the supply shock attending the Iranian Revolution, converted these abstractions into queues, rationing, and violence at the bowser. McCausland later recalled that the screenplay drew upon the conduct of motorists during the 1973 crisis—the readiness of ordinary drivers to fight for fuel—and the prologue of *Mad Max 2* makes the connection explicit, narrating the collapse of the old world as a war between two "warrior tribes" over the fuel upon which everything had come to depend. The deepest theoretical articulation of depletion in this period came, however, not from geologists or systems modellers but from the Romanian-American economist Nicholas Georgescu-Roegen, whose *The Entropy Law and the Economic Process* (1971) argued that the economic process, far from being the self-renewing circular flow of neoclassical theory, is an entropic process that irreversibly transforms valuable low-entropy matter and energy into valueless high-entropy waste. Combustion is the paradigm of this transformation.

Georgescu-Roegen was not the first to bring the Second Law of Thermodynamics to bear upon human history. Henry Adams, in "The Rule of Phase Applied to History" (1909) and *A Letter to American Teachers of History* (1910), had already proposed that civilisation was subject to the universal dissipation of mechanical energy that William Thomson had formulated in 1852, and had prophesied a terminal phase in which the acceleration of human command over force would issue in exhaustion. The saga's Wasteland is the landscape of that prophecy: a world approaching thermodynamic uniformity, its differences levelled into dune and salt pan, its stored energies dispersed as heat. The salt flats across which the fugitives of *Fury Road* contemplate a crossing of one hundred and sixty days are entropy made geography—a surface without gradients, without life, and without destination. That salt is also, in the biblical imagination, the substance of the curse of sterility—Abimelech sows the razed Shechem with it (Judges 9:45), and Lot's wife, looking back, becomes a pillar of it (Genesis 19:26)—acquires in Chapter Five a decisive significance: it is upon the salt that the fugitives look back, and are not petrified but turned toward life.

The third sense is formal and reflexive. In "The Literature of Exhaustion" (1967), John Barth described the "used-upness" of certain forms and the predicament of

the belated artist confronted with an inheritance of exhausted conventions; in "The Literature of Replenishment" (1980), published in the interval between the first two Mad Max films, he described how such exhaustion might be converted into renewed vitality through the knowing recombination of inherited forms. The saga is, from its inception, a cinema of exhausted genres. *Mad Max* appeared at the terminus of the revisionist western, whose twilight had already been declared by Sam Peckinpah and Robert Altman; it absorbed the biker film from *The Wild One* (1953) to the Australian *Stone* (1974); it inherited the chase film from Buster Keaton and the samurai film from Akira Kurosawa; and *Beyond Thunderdome* would add the peplum, the gladiatorial spectacle, and the boys' adventure fable. Its mode of composition is what Lévi-Strauss, in *The Savage Mind* (1962), called *bricolage*: the work of the bricoleur who makes do with whatever is at hand, a finite and heterogeneous repertoire of fragments left over from earlier constructions, and whose procedure characterised, for Lévi-Strauss, the operation of mythical thought itself. Here the extradiegetic and the diegetic coincide with uncanny precision. The Wasteland's material culture *is* bricolage. The vehicles of *Fury Road* are assembled from the salvaged carcasses of the industrial century—the Gigahorse from two stacked Cadillacs on monstrous wheels, the Doof Wagon from a mobile wall of amplifiers and drums, the War Rig from the hybridised remains of tractor and tanker—exactly as the films themselves are assembled from the salvaged carcasses of exhausted genres. The saga is mythical thought made metal.

The three exhaustions converge. A cinema that stages the depletion of fuel and the dissolution of law is itself built from the remains of used-up forms, and its trajectory—from the exhaustion of the first trilogy to the formal and ethical replenishment of *Fury Road* and *Furiosa*—recapitulates Barth's own movement from diagnosis to remedy. Against exhaustion in all three senses the saga progressively discovers a counter-principle that this thesis calls *replenishment*, figured through a recurrent set of vital substances: water, milk, blood, seed, and story. Luce Irigaray's argument in "The 'Mechanics' of Fluids" (1977) that Western rationality has privileged the solid over the fluid, and has associated the latter with a feminine it can neither theorise nor contain, illuminates the saga's late economy with startling exactness. *Fury Road* is organised around the control of fluids—"guzzoline," "Aqua Cola," mother's milk, the transfused blood of the War Boys—and its climax is the release of a hoarded fluid upon a thirsting multitude: the passage from an economy of combustion, in which stored energy is burned and lost, to an economy of circulation, in which vital substance flows and returns.

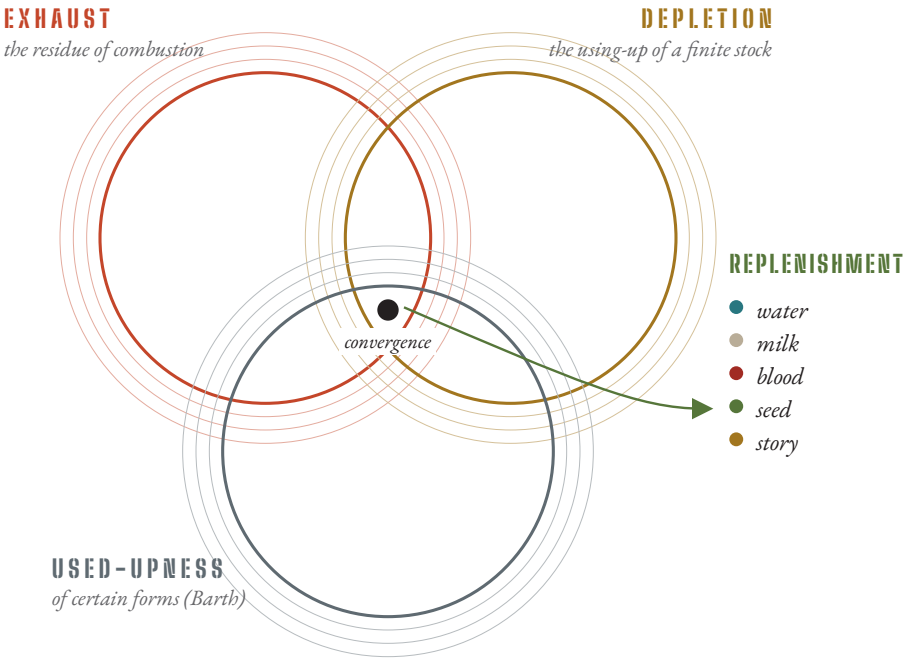


FIG. 1 The triple exhaustion and its counter-principle (§ 1.3).

1.4 The Oresteian Homology

The *Oresteia* is the West's founding drama of the passage from vengeance to law. Its first play, *Agamemnon*, depicts the return of the victorious king from Troy and his murder by his wife Clytemnestra, who avenges the sacrifice of their daughter Iphigenia, offered by Agamemnon to secure the winds for the fleet; the murder discharges one obligation of blood only to incur another, for the house of Atreus labours under a hereditary curse reaching back to Atreus's own cannibal banquet. In *The Libation Bearers*, Agamemnon's son Orestes returns from exile at Apollo's command and kills his mother, whereupon the Erinyes—the Furies, ancient daughters of Night, avengers of kin-murder and above all of matricide—rise to pursue him, visible at first only to his maddened eyes. In *The Eumenides*, Orestes, purified at Delphi but still hounded, flees to Athens, where Athena convenes a court of citizens upon the hill of Ares to try him. Apollo defends; the Furies prosecute; the jurors divide equally; and Athena, who declares herself born of no mother and for the male in all things save marriage, casts the vote that acquits. The Furies threaten in their rage to drip venom upon the land and blight it with sterility. Athena persuades them instead to accept honour and a dwelling beneath the earth of Athens, whence, transformed into the *Semnai Theai*, the August Goddesses, they will bless the city's soil, its flocks, and

its marriages with fertility. The trilogy ends in a torchlit procession conducting the former Furies to their subterranean home.

The trilogy poses, with unequalled clarity, the problem that the Mad Max saga poses in the idiom of fossil modernity. Vengeance is a self-perpetuating process: each act of retribution generates a new obligation of retribution, and the chain cannot terminate from within. Its termination requires a transformation of the very energies that sustain it—not their abolition, which Athena never attempts, but their conversion: their redirection from the destruction of the community to its sustenance, their installation beneath the polity as its foundation rather than above it as its curse. The Furies are not defeated in the *Eumenides*. They are buried, honoured, and repurposed. The energy of fury becomes the energy of fertility.

This structure has served, since the nineteenth century, as a privileged site for theorising the origins of law, property, and patriarchy. Johann Jakob Bachofen's *Das Mutterrecht* (1861) read the trilogy as the dramatic record of a world-historical transition from mother-right to father-right; Friedrich Engels, adopting Bachofen's reading in *The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* (1884), discerned in that transition "the world historical defeat of the female sex"; and George Thomson's *Aeschylus and Athens* (1941) reconstructed the trilogy's embeddedness in the social struggles of the Athenian polis. Twentieth-century feminist classical scholarship transformed the terms of the inquiry. Froma Zeitlin's "The Dynamics of Misogyny" (1978) demonstrated that the trilogy does not record but *constructs* the myth of a matriarchal past in order to legitimate its overthrow, making the defeat of the female the precondition of civic order. Luce Irigaray, reversing Freud's location of the origin of culture in a primal patricide, argued that Western culture is founded upon a matricide—the murder of Clytemnestra—whose consequences it has never ceased to repress. Simon Goldhill's *Language, Sexuality, Narrative: The Oresteia* (1984) showed, moreover, that the trilogy's legal settlement depends upon the control of signification itself: upon the victory of one discourse of kinship over another.

The pivot of that victory is a single passage of the *Eumenides* (657–61) in which Apollo, defending Orestes, argues that the mother is not the true parent of the child but merely the nurse of the newly sown embryo; the begetter is the male, and the mother preserves his seed as a stranger keeps faith with a stranger. Athena, sprung from the head of Zeus without the shelter of a womb, is offered as living proof. This is the Apollonian embryology, and upon it the Eumenidean settlement—and, as Zeitlin and Irigaray argue, a long tradition of Western legal patriarchy—is founded.

The homology with the saga may now be stated in schematic form, with the caveat that schematism is a heuristic rather than a hermeneutic, and that the films are

to be read not as allegories to be decoded but as variants to be compared. *Mad Max* (1979) compresses the matter of *Agamemnon* and *The Libation Bearers* into a single vendetta. Its plot is a chain of retaliation of strictly Atreid form: the fiery death of the Nightrider—a name that, in the saga's onomastic lottery, recalls the Night of whom Aeschylus's Furies are born—summons the Toecutter's gang to avenge him; their vengeance consumes Max's partner Jim Goose and then Max's wife and infant son; and Max's counter-vengeance consumes them in turn, leaving him at the film's close an Orestes who has executed justice and been driven mad by it. The institution of law that ought to interrupt this chain—the Main Force Patrol, headquartered in the derelict "Halls of Justice"—is, like the Argos to which Agamemnon returns, already rotten from within, its officers scarcely distinguishable in violence from the gangs they pursue. *Mad Max 2* and *Beyond Thunderdome* stage the wanderings of the polluted suppliant: Max, like Orestes between Delphi and Athens, passes through a series of communities that offer provisional sanctuary, rites of purification, and the possibility of reintegration, none of which takes. *Fury Road* and *Furiosa*, finally, are the saga's *Eumenides*. The Fury herself—Furiosa, whose name declares her lineage—becomes the protagonist; the city is refounded; the hoarded waters are released; and the energies of vengeance are converted, with great difficulty and at great cost, into the energies of fertility.

The homology, however, is not an identity, and it is in the saga's divergences from Aeschylus that its originality lies. Two are decisive. The first is a *splitting*. In the *Oresteia*, the polluted avenger and the avenging Furies are antagonists, pursued and pursuer, and their conflict can be resolved only by a third party, the goddess and her court. In the saga, the Oresteian drama is distributed across two figures who become allies. Max is the haunted Orestes, pursued in *Fury Road* by hallucinated Furies—the faces of those he failed to save, above all the child Glory—and never acquitted; Furiosa is the Fury in the process of transformation, a creature of vengeance seeking, in the phrase that titles her own film's final chapter, a way "beyond vengeance." When the two ride together upon the War Rig, Orestes and Erinys form a single fugitive alliance against a sovereign who is himself the culmination of the curse. The second divergence is an *inversion*. The *Eumenides* founds its city upon the Apollonian embryology and the domestication of the female powers. *Fury Road* confronts that embryology in its most grotesque literalisation—Immortan Joe's proprietary claim upon the wombs of his captive "breeders" and upon the child one of them carries—and its Furies refuse it. "We are not things," the Wives inscribe upon the walls of the vault from which they have fled; "our babies will not be warlords." The city is refounded not by a motherless goddess on behalf of the father but by the Fury and the Many Mothers against him. The saga retains Aeschylus's conversion of fury

THE ORESTEIAN HOMOLOGY

Aeschylus and the saga

AESCHYLUS

Agamemnon

→

SAGA VARIANT

Mad Max (1979), first movement

SHARED PROBLEM

A house of law already rotten; a chain of retaliation inherited rather than chosen

DECISIVE DIVERGENCE

The curse is social, not dynastic: the feud belongs to an entire order

AESCHYLUS

The Libation Bearers

→

SAGA VARIANT

Mad Max (1979), revenge movement

SHARED PROBLEM

The avenger's justice indistinguishable from crime; madness its price

DECISIVE DIVERGENCE

No god commands the deed; Max acts without Apollo

AESCHYLUS

Eumenides, *pursuit and purification*

→

SAGA VARIANT

Mad Max 2; *Beyond Thunderdome*

SHARED PROBLEM

The polluted suppliant seeks cleansing among strangers

DECISIVE DIVERGENCE

Purification never takes; the suppliant is expelled as scapegoat

AESCHYLUS

Eumenides, *trial and settlement*

→

SAGA VARIANT

Fury Road; *Furiosa*

SHARED PROBLEM

Fury converted into fertility; the city re-founded

DECISIVE DIVERGENCE

Orestes and the Fury become allies; the Apollonian embryology is refused

FIG. 2 The Oresteian homology: Aeschylus's trilogy and its variants in the saga (§ 1.4).

into fertility and reverses the gender of its settlement. It is, in this precise sense, a counter-*Eumenides*.

It would be idle to rest any part of this argument upon the biographical datum that Miller was born in Chinchilla, Queensland, in 1945, into a family of Greek migrants—his father from the island of Kythera—and equally idle to ignore it. The mythic inheritance of the Greek-Australian diaspora is not evidence of influence; it is a condition of plausibility. Nor is the parallel between the saga's historical moment and Aeschylus's own without interest. The *Oresteia* was produced in 458 BCE, some four years after the reforms of Ephialtes had stripped the ancient Council of the Areopagus of most of its powers, leaving it chiefly the jurisdiction over homicide that the *Eumenides* represents Athena as founding, and not long after Ephialtes himself had been assassinated. The trilogy is thus a mythic intervention in a constitutional crisis: an attempt to re-ground a contested institution in the deep time of myth. The Mad Max saga, conceived in the decade of the oil shocks and completed in the decade of the climate emergency, is likewise a mythic intervention in a crisis of foundations—not of a single polity, but of the energetic order upon which every modern polity rests.

1.5 The Chthonic Hypothesis: Fossil Fuel as Buried Fury

What justifies the prefix of *petro-Oresteia* is not merely the saga's concern with oil but a deeper correspondence between the substance of fossil energy and the mythic substance of the Furies. The Erinyes are chthonic powers. In Hesiod's *Theogony* (185) they spring from the blood of the castrated Ouranos as it falls upon Gaia, the Earth; in Aeschylus they are daughters of Night who dwell beneath the earth, hunters who track their quarry by the scent of spilt blood, and avengers whose characteristic punishment is the blight of sterility—the withering of crops, the barrenness of wombs, the dying of the land. They are, in short, the powers of the underworld turned against the world above.

Fossil fuels are, with a literalness that the industrial imagination has laboured to forget, the remains of the ancient dead. Coal is the compressed residue of the swamp forests of the Carboniferous; petroleum derives predominantly from the remains of marine plankton and algae buried in oxygen-starved sediments and slowly cooked by geothermal heat into hydrocarbon. The ecologist Jeffrey Dukes (2003) estimated that a single US gallon of petrol represents the transformed remains of some ninety metric tonnes of ancient plant matter, and that the fossil fuels burned by humanity in a single year of the late 1990s corresponded to roughly four centuries' worth of

the planet's present plant productivity. To burn fossil fuel is to exhume the dead of deep time and consume them in fire: to raise the chthonic and turn it loose upon the air. The combustion economy is, in mythic terms, a vast necromancy.

The correspondence deepens when one recalls the distinction—schematic, but heuristically powerful—that classical scholarship long drew between Olympian and chthonic sacrifice. Offerings to the gods of the sky were typically slaughtered, cooked, and shared in a communal feast, the smoke of the burned portions rising to the gods while the meat sustained the human community; offerings to the powers below were often burned entire—the holocaust, from *holokautein*, "to burn whole"—or poured into pits, consumed without remainder and without return to the community of the living. Recent scholarship has rightly complicated the rigidity of this opposition (Scullion 1994; Ekroth 2002), but its conceptual polarity remains instructive. The combustion of fossil fuel is a chthonic holocaust: a total burning of the subterranean dead from which nothing returns to the community but heat, motion, and exhaust. It is, in the language of Georges Bataille that Chapter Four develops, an expenditure without reserve.

Yet the Greek underworld was never merely a realm of extraction and death. Its lord was also called Plouton, "the wealthy one," and Plato's *Cratylus* (403a) derives the name from the wealth that rises from the earth below. That wealth was double: the mineral wealth of the mine and the agricultural wealth of the furrow. The same chthonic realm that received the dead sent up the grain; the same Persephone who reigned as queen of the dead returned each spring as the maiden of the harvest. The underworld was ambivalent, and its ambivalence is the hinge upon which the present thesis turns. Two chthonic modes are therefore distinguished. The *petro-chthonic* names the relation to the subterranean as a reservoir to be extracted and consumed: the oil seam, the aquifer pumped toward exhaustion, the ore body mined for lead. The *humic-chthonic* names the relation to the subterranean as a matrix of regeneration: soil, compost, seed, the living dark in which the dead become the food of the living. Donna Haraway's proposal in *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) that the epoch named Anthropocene might better be named the *Chthulucene*—an age of entangled, multispecies becoming rooted in earthly, tentacular, and composting powers—and her insistence that we are compost rather than posthuman articulate the humic-chthonic with programmatic force.

The Mad Max saga, it will be argued, is structured by the struggle between these two relations to the underworld. Its sovereigns are petro-chthonic. Immortan Joe's Citadel is raised above an aquifer whose water he pumps and rations; his allied fiefdoms of Gastown and the Bullet Farm refine fuel and smelt lead from the ground; Aunty Entity's Bartertown runs on methane drawn from an Underworld of pig-

	PETRO-CHTHONIC	HUMIC-CHTHONIC
RELATION TO THE UNDERWORLD	A reservoir to be extracted	A matrix of regeneration
CHARACTERISTIC SUBSTANCES	Oil, pumped aquifer water, lead ore, methane	Soil, seed, compost, milk, released water
SACRIFICIAL ANALOGUE	Holocaust: total burning, nothing returned	Burial and harvest: the dead become food
TEMPORAL MODE	Irreversible expenditure (entropy)	Cyclical return (germination)
SOVEREIGN FIGURES IN THE SAGA	The Humungus, Aunty Entity, Immortan Joe, Dementus	The Vuvalini, the Keeper of the Seeds, Furiosa
MYTHIC EMBLEM	The Erinyes unleashed	The *Semnai Theai* installed beneath the city

FIG. 3 Petro-chthonic and humic-chthonic: the ambivalent underworld on which the argument turns (§ 1.5).

shit; and the compound of *Mad Max 2* is a refinery besieged for its crude. Against them the saga gradually assembles the humic-chthonic: the Keeper of the Seeds and her pouch of seeds carried out of a land gone sour; the Green Place remembered and lost; the peach stone that the young Furiosa carries out of her stolen childhood; and, at the close of *Furiosa*, the body of the warlord Dementus made the living compost of a fruit tree. The saga's central dramatic question—"Who killed the world?", as the Wives' graffito demands—receives, in this light, a mythic answer: the world was killed by those who raised the chthonic powers and burned them. Its central ethical question—how the world might be restored—receives an answer that is Aeschylean in its deepest structure: the Furies must be returned to the ground, honoured rather than consumed, so that they may bless the soil rather than blight it. The contemporary climate movement's injunction to leave fossil fuels in the ground is, in this reading, a demand for a new Eumenidean settlement.

Five Analytical Instruments 1.6

The argument is conducted through five concepts developed in the course of the thesis. They are introduced here in compressed form and elaborated in the chapters that follow; each names a structure that the films articulate in images and motion before any theory articulated it in words.

The Erinyic Economy 1.6.1

The first concept names a structural isomorphism between combustion and vengeance that the saga exploits from its first film to its last. Both are processes in which a stored quantity—the chemical energy of fossil carbon, the accumulated grievance of injured kin—is converted into heat and motion by an irreversible transformation. Both are self-propagating: combustion sustains itself so long as fuel and oxygen remain, and vengeance regenerates the conditions of its own renewal so long as there are kin to avenge and enemies to provoke. Both terminate only in exhaustion or through an intervention from outside the process. And both, in thermodynamic terms, are entropic: they degrade concentrated value into dispersed waste, leaving behind ash, exhaust, and bodies. Sadi Carnot's *Réflexions sur la puissance motrice du feu* (1824), the founding text of thermodynamics, whose title names the motive power of fire, could serve as the saga's subtitle. The Erinyic economy is the political economy of the motive power of fire.

The saga renders the isomorphism literal through the equation of blood and fuel. The War Boys of *Fury Road*, their bodies failing from the condition they call the half-

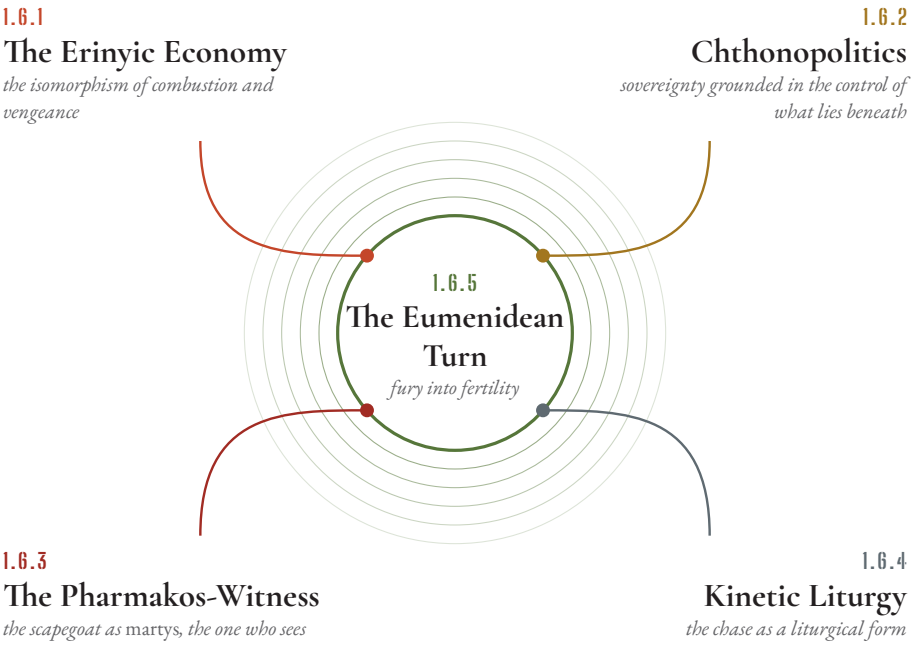


FIG. 4 The five analytical instruments, oriented toward the Eumenidean turn (§ 1.6).

life, require transfusions to sustain them in battle; the captive Max is a "blood bag," tattooed with his own specifications—universal donor, O-negative, high-octane—as though he were a grade of petrol; and the battles over fuel in *Mad Max 2* are consummated in the shedding of blood, gallon for gallon. Three theoretical frames illuminate the structure. Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) argued that every living system receives from the sun more energy than its maintenance requires, and that the surplus must be spent—gloriously, in sacrifice, festival, and gift, or catastrophically, in war; the War Boys' ecstatic self-immolation is Bataillean *dépense* in its purest form. Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished a mythic violence, which founds and preserves law, demands blood, and binds its subjects to fate, from a divine violence that annihilates law and expiates; the Erinyic economy is the economy of mythic violence, whose emblem in Benjamin's own essay —the punishment of Niobe—situates it squarely within the Greek mythic world. And René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) analysed vengeance as an interminable reciprocal escalation in which rivals become indistinguishable doubles, a crisis that can be halted only by the unanimous violence of the community against a single victim. This last analysis leads directly to the third of the thesis's concepts: the Erinyic economy is the condition that the scapegoat exists to interrupt.

Chthonopolitics 1.6.2

The second concept names a form of sovereignty grounded in the control of what lies beneath. The saga's sovereigns do not rule territories so much as wells, seams, and sumps; their power is the power to regulate the flow of chthonic substance to a dependent population. Immortan Joe's Citadel—a complex of rock towers raised above an aquifer whose water he releases at his pleasure in thunderous cascades while admonishing his subjects not to grow addicted to it—is the most explicit instance, but the refinery of *Mad Max 2* and the methane Underworld of Bartertown are its precursors. Four bodies of theory converge upon this formation. Karl Wittfogel's *Oriental Despotism* (1957), whatever its empirical and ideological liabilities, proposed that total power arises from the managerial control of water; Immortan Joe is a hydraulic despot of textbook purity. Carl Schmitt's *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950) argued that every legal order originates in a primordial appropriation of land, a *Landnahme*, from which the measure and division of the world derive; the post-apocalyptic order is a new nomos founded upon the appropriation not of land as surface but of land as depth. Timothy Mitchell's *Carbon Democracy* (2011) demonstrated that the political forms of the twentieth century were shaped by the material properties of the fuels on which they ran—that the fluidity of oil, which flows through pipelines and tankers rather than being hewn and hauled by organised labour, diminished the capacity of workers to interrupt energy flows at their chokepoints—and the saga's set-pieces are almost invariably battles for chokepoints: the refinery gate, the tanker cab, the canyon pass. Martin Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1954), finally, described the essence of modern technology as *Gestell*, an enframing that reveals everything—river, forest, human being—as *Bestand*, standing-reserve, a stock held ready for extraction and use. The Citadel is *Gestell* incarnate. Its women are milked like cattle; its men are harvested for blood; its children are bred as warriors; its water is hoarded as stock. Chthonopolitics is the sovereignty of enframing.

The Pharmakos-Witness 1.6.3

The third concept reconceives the protagonist. Max Rockatansky has generally been described as a hero, an anti-hero, or, in Campbellian terms, a mythic wanderer who refuses the call only to answer it. The thesis argues instead that his structural function is that of the *pharmakos*: the scapegoat whose expulsion purges the community and thereby founds it. In the Thargelia of Athenian and Ionian cult, human *pharmakoi* were ritually led out of the city; in Leviticus 16, the goat for Azazel is driven into the wilderness bearing the iniquities of the people. Max's narrative pattern

conforms to this rite with remarkable consistency. At the close of every film after the first, a community forms or re-forms around his departure. The Great Northern Tribe of *Mad Max 2* is founded on the exodus that his decoy tanker makes possible, after which he is left alone upon the road; the Lost Tribe of *Beyond Thunderdome* escapes to the ruined city while he remains in the desert; and the populace of the Citadel lifts Furiosa toward the summit while Max slips away into the crowd. *Beyond Thunderdome* renders the rite literal. Max, having broken a deal, is sentenced by the spin of a wheel to "Gulag," and is driven into the desert lashed to a horse, his head encased in a grotesque mask—an image so precisely Levitical that it can scarcely be read otherwise. Jacques Derrida's "Plato's Pharmacy" (1968) observed that the *pharmakos* is bound etymologically and semantically to the *pharmakon*, the drug that is at once remedy and poison; *Fury Road* literalises the bond when Max's blood, harvested as medicine for the dying Nux, becomes at the climax the transfusion that saves Furiosa's life.

To this sacrificial function the thesis adds a second, which the Greek language itself supplies. The word *martys*, from which "martyr" derives, originally meant *witness*. The War Boys of *Fury Road* seek martyrdom as spectacle, crying "Witness me!" as they hurl themselves to their deaths and demanding that their sacrifice be seen. Max is their inverse: the witness who refuses martyrdom, the survivor condemned to see. His hallucinations of the dead are not psychological ornament but the visible form of the obligation that witnessing imposes—the Furies of memory that pursue the one who has seen. Even his surname, for a director trained in medicine, sounds an apposite echo, whether or not intended, of Carl von Rokitansky, the nineteenth-century Viennese pathologist who presided over tens of thousands of autopsies and made the dead body the foundation of modern medical knowledge. Max is the pathologist of the Wasteland: the one who has seen what the machines do to flesh, and who cannot stop seeing it.

1.6.4 *Kinetic Liturgy*

The fourth concept addresses the form of the films. Miller has repeatedly described his ideal as a "pure cinema" in the sense Alfred Hitchcock gave the phrase—a cinema that communicates through image and motion rather than dialogue—and has located its exemplars in the silent era, in the chase comedies of Keaton and Harold Lloyd, whose kinetic legibility transcended language. *Fury Road* was conceived and largely designed as a sequence of some three and a half thousand storyboards before a conventional screenplay existed, and its editing relies upon a principle of centre-framing that holds the point of attention near the heart of the image across cuts of

extreme rapidity, enabling a velocity of montage that nonetheless remains legible. The thesis argues that this kinetic form functions not as spectacle but as liturgy, and the term is chosen with philological care. In classical Athens a *leitourgia* was a public work financed by a wealthy citizen on behalf of the polis, and among the most prestigious was the *choregia*, the funding of a dramatic chorus at the Dionysia —the institution through which the *Oresteia* itself was staged, and in which the young Pericles had served as *choregos* for Aeschylus's *Persians* in 472 BCE. A liturgy is the public work through which a community makes its myth present to itself. Mircea Eliade's account of ritual as the periodic re-actualisation of a mythic time of origins in *The Myth of the Eternal Return* (1949), Victor Turner's analysis of the liminal phase of ritual and the *communitas* it generates in *The Ritual Process* (1969), and Mary Douglas's study of ring composition in ancient texts, *Thinking in Circles* (2007), furnish the analytical instruments. *Fury Road* is a ring: a journey out from the Citadel and back again, pivoting upon a central turning-point on the salt flats, that returns to its origin transformed. Its chase is a procession, accompanied by its own war-drums and its own flame-spewing musician, whose re-enactments—in the cinema, on domestic screens, at the festivals that now restage the Wasteland each year in the Mojave Desert—have the structure of rite. Paul Virilio's *Speed and Politics* (1977), published two years before *Mad Max*, supplies the political dimension: a *dromology*, a logic of speed in which power belongs to whoever commands velocity, and in which the invention of every vehicle is also the invention of its accident.

The Eumenidean Turn 1.6.5

The fifth concept names the saga's culminating movement, toward which every other concept is oriented: the conversion of fury into fertility, of the petro-chthonic into the humic-chthonic, of combustion into germination. It is figured in *Fury Road* by the passage from the War Boys' cult of the V8 to the Keeper of the Seeds' pouch of seeds; by the reversal of the fugitives' flight upon the salt flats, when they renounce the exodus toward a vanished Green Place and turn back to seize the Citadel and its water; by the death of Nux—whose name is the Latin *nux*, "nut," whose diminutive gives *nucleus*, "kernel"—in a self-sacrifice that seals the canyon behind the fugitives and recalls the Johannine seed: "Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone" (John 12:24); and by the final release of the hoarded waters. It is figured in *Furiosa* by the peach stone the protagonist carries from her stolen childhood and plants, in one of the History Man's competing versions of the ending, in the living body of her mother's murderer—vengeance transmuted, with a horror the film declines to soften, into cultivation. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag

Theory of Fiction" (1986), which proposed that the first cultural device was not the spear of the hunter-hero but the container of the gatherer, and that the hero-story might be displaced by a story of carrying and gathering, describes the formal implication of the turn with striking precision: across the saga, the lance and the spear give way to the bag, the tanker, the womb, the seed-pouch.

The Eumenidean turn is not, however, a utopian closure. As in Aeschylus, whose settlement was a precarious compromise struck in the shadow of political murder, the saga's resolutions remain shadowed. The Citadel's hierarchy survives the tyrant's fall, its new rulers ascending upon a platform above the multitude; the Green Place cannot be recovered, only reinvented; and the tree that grows from Dementus's body is at once a grace and an atrocity. The turn is a direction, not a destination.

1.7 State of the Field

The critical literature on the saga is extensive, heterogeneous, and fragmented—divided by film, by discipline, and by the thirty-year hiatus between 1985 and 2015. Its earliest serious strand is Australian and national-cultural. Within the debates that attended the revival of a national cinema in the 1970s, the first film occupied an anomalous position. Susan Dermody and Elizabeth Jacka's *The Screening of Australia* (1987–88) distinguished the tasteful literary and period dramas favoured by the public funding bodies—what they named the "AFC genre"—from the commercial genre cinema that later critics would celebrate under the sign of "Ozploitation," and *Mad Max*, privately financed, commercially triumphant, and greeted at home with alarm at its violence, became the emblem of the latter. Ross Gibson's essay "Yondering" (1985), a reading of *Beyond Thunderdome*, situated the saga within the settler-colonial construction of the Australian interior as a space of myth and estrangement. Meaghan Morris's "White Panic or Mad Max and the Sublime" (1998) read the films as expressions of an Anglo-Australian anxiety of invasion and dispossession sublimated into landscape. Delia Falconer's contribution to *The Road Movie Book* (1997) tracked the road's progressive disappearance across the trilogy; Tom O'Regan's *Australian National Cinema* (1996) situated the films within the international ambitions of the industry; and Adrian Martin's monograph *The Mad Max Movies* (2003) remains the most acute formal analysis of Miller's kinetic style before *Fury Road*.

A second strand, emerging with *Fury Road*, belongs to the energy humanities. The coinage "petrofiction," proposed by Amitav Ghosh in a 1992 review of Abdelrahman Munif's *Cities of Salt*; the field-defining work of Stephanie LeMenager's

Living Oil (2014), with its account of "petromelancholia," the grief attending the loss of an oil-saturated way of life; and the anthology *Energy Humanities* edited by Imre Szeman and Dominic Boyer (2017) furnished the conceptual apparatus within which *Fury Road* rapidly became something of a set text: the most conspicuous cinematic image of a world consuming its own energetic foundations. A third strand is feminist. *Fury Road*'s reception was polarised. It was celebrated for its centring of Furiosa and the Wives and for the consultation of the playwright Eve Ensler, whose work with survivors of wartime sexual violence informed the actors' preparation; attacked from the reactionary right by online commentators who called for a boycott of what they deemed feminist propaganda; and criticised from the left for retaining Max as the titular centre of a story that is not his, for the essentialism of its figuration of the Many Mothers, and for the whiteness of its emancipated women.

A fourth strand is postcolonial, and remains the least developed. The Wasteland of the Australian films is conspicuously empty of Aboriginal presence: a cinematic restaging of the colonial fiction of *terra nullius*, which the High Court of Australia would repudiate only in *Mabo v Queensland (No 2)* in 1992. *Beyond Thunderdome*'s Lost Tribe bears ochre markings and a ritual oral tradition that borrow the iconography of Indigenous and Melanesian cultures while excluding their peoples. And *Fury Road* was shot in the Namib, with its production based near Swakopmund—a town that held a concentration camp during the German colonial genocide of the Herero and Nama peoples between 1904 and 1908—amid reported allegations, disputed by Namibian authorities, that the production had damaged the fragile ecology of the Dorob National Park. The saga's deserts are never as empty as its fictions require.

The reading proposed here departs from each strand while drawing upon all of them. Against the fragmentation of the literature, it reads the five films as a single evolving mythic system. Against the hegemony of the monomyth, it substitutes a historically specific tragic homology. Against the energy humanities' tendency to treat *Fury Road* as an illustration of petrocultural theory, it argues that the saga is itself a theory: that it thinks, in images and motion, the isomorphism of energy and justice that theory has only recently begun to articulate. Against the opposition of celebratory and suspicious feminist readings, it locates the saga's gender-politics within the long Western argument over the *Oresteia* in which feminist thought has been decisively engaged. And against the postcolonial strand's justified suspicion of the saga's deserts, it proposes that the chthonic hypothesis supplies the means by which that suspicion may be deepened: the Wasteland is empty not because it was always empty but because the settler-extractive order the films extrapolate is itself an order of evacuation, of which *terra nullius* was the founding legal fiction. To the best of the present author's knowledge, the Aeschylean frame—despite the transparency

of Furiosa's name—has nowhere been systematically developed, nor has *Furiosa* yet received sustained scholarly treatment as the completion of the saga's ethical arc. The present thesis attempts both.

1.8 Method: Myth as the Sum of Its Variants

Claude Lévi-Strauss's "The Structural Study of Myth" (1955) proposed that a myth consists of all its versions; that no version is authentic or original in a sense that would render the others derivative; and that the meaning of a myth resides not in any single telling but in the structure of transformations relating its variants—so that Freud's account of Oedipus was, in Lévi-Strauss's provocative formulation, simply one more version of the Oedipus myth. The saga invites this method with unusual insistence. Its discontinuities, as noted above, are the formal signature of variance, and *Furiosa* thematises variance within a single film when its narrator offers competing accounts of the protagonist's vengeance without choosing among them. The saga thus treats itself as Lévi-Strauss treated myth: as a set of versions whose truth lies in their relations. The thesis accordingly reads the five films not as instalments in a continuous chronicle but as variants of a single mythic problem, each of which transforms the others. Read in this way, the apparent inconsistencies of the saga—Max's shifting age, the resurrected Interceptor, the competing chronologies of the fall—cease to be problems requiring reconciliation and become data requiring interpretation: the points at which one telling of the legend diverges from another, and therefore the points at which the legend's deep structure becomes visible.

Two further methodological resources supplement the structural. Aby Warburg's lifelong inquiry into the *Nachleben der Antike*—the afterlife of antiquity—and his concept of the *Pathosformel*, the formula of emotional intensity through which ancient gestures of ecstasy, terror, and violence survive and are reactivated in later art, provides a model for tracing the iconographic survivals that bind the saga to its antique precursors: the charioteer, the pursuing Fury, the maenad in frenzy, the falling warrior, the suppliant at the altar. Warburg's unfinished *Mnemosyne Atlas* (1924–29), with its panels of juxtaposed images across millennia and media, is the model for the comparative method the thesis adopts across cinema, literature, comics, painting, music, and the interactive media into which the saga has been disseminated. Roland Barthes's *Mythologies* (1957), which defined myth as a second-order system of signification that converts history into nature, and which opened its analysis of the new Citroën by comparing the automobile to the Gothic cathedral, provides a model of demystification. The saga, notably, performs Barthesian critique

within its own diegesis. It shows its sovereigns manufacturing myth—Immortan Joe's promise of Valhalla, Aunty Entity's juridical liturgy, Dementus's demagogic oratory—and invites its audience to watch the manufacture. The War Boys' chapels of steering wheels are Barthes's cathedral taken at its word.

The comparative scope of the thesis demands a discipline of distinction, and three registers of relation are maintained throughout. The first is *documented influence*: relations for which the filmmakers' testimony or the production record supplies evidence, such as the western, the films of Kurosawa, the silent chase film, and Campbell's monomyth. The second is *contextual convergence*: relations between the saga and contemporaneous works responding to the same historical conditions without demonstrable contact—J. G. Ballard's fictions of the car crash and the drought, Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980), Le Guin's *Always Coming Home* (1985). The third is *structural homology*: relations between the saga and works separated from it by centuries or millennia that address the same deep problem under different material conditions—Aeschylus, the Epic of Gilgamesh, Exodus, the Grail romances, the Norse eschatology of the *Poetic Edda*, the historical sociology of Ibn Khaldun. The distinction guards against the twin errors of comparative mythography: the reduction of every resemblance to influence, and the dissolution of every difference into archetype. The thesis aims to read the saga as Wendy Doniger, in *The Implied Spider* (1998), proposed that myths be compared: attentive to the shared human experiences—the implied spider—that spin similar webs of story across cultures, without dissolving the particularity of each web or the history of the hands that wove it.

A final methodological commitment concerns the relation between the films and theory. The thesis does not apply theory to the saga as a master-code to a text. It follows Gilles Deleuze's proposition in *Cinema 1* (1983) and *Cinema 2* (1985) that cinema thinks—that filmmakers create concepts in images and movements as philosophers create them in words—and it treats the saga as an interlocutor of the theorists with whom it is placed in dialogue rather than as their illustration. Miller's cinema is, in Deleuze's taxonomy, the action-image raised to its limit: the sensory-motor schema of situation, action, and transformed situation accelerated until, in *Fury Road*, it approaches pure movement. That the saga's most profound moments —Max's hallucinations, the stillness of the Wives washing in the desert, the History Man's divergent endings—are precisely those in which the action-image falters and something like a time-image breaks through will be among the thesis's later claims. The saga thinks most deeply where it stops moving.

1.9 Architecture of the Argument

II **Chapter Two, "Genealogies of the Wasteland,"** reconstructs the intellectual and material conditions of the saga's emergence. It begins with Miller's clinical formation in the era of Australia's peak road toll, which reached its historical maximum in 1970—the same year in which Victoria became the first jurisdiction in the world to make the wearing of seatbelts compulsory—and proceeds through the 1972 "supercar scare," which turned high-performance Australian Fords and Holdens into objects of moral panic; the oil shocks; the Australian apocalyptic imagination descending from Nevil Shute's *On the Beach* (1957), set and filmed in the very Melbourne in which *Mad Max* was shot; the visual tradition of Sidney Nolan's Ned Kelly series (1946–47), whose black geometric helmet against an empty interior is the iconographic ancestor of the masked outlaw in the void; the metaphysical deserts of Patrick White's *Voss* (1957); the Ozploitation cinema of Peter Weir's *The Cars That Ate Paris* (1974), with its township living by the harvest of wrecks, and Sandy Harbutt's *Stone* (1974); and the international genealogy of the western, the samurai film, the silent chase, and Campbell's monomyth.

III **Chapter Three, "The Law Exhausted,"** reads *Mad Max* (1979) as the saga's *Agamemnon* and *Libation Bearers*: an anatomy of law's collapse into the violence it was instituted to contain, read through Benjamin's critique of violence, Girard's mimetic crisis, Durkheim's anomie, and Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651). Against the Hobbesian consensus, it argues that the Wasteland is not pre-legal but post-nomic—the afterlife of an exhausted law rather than the state of nature that precedes law—and it reads Max's madness as his becoming-Fury: the moment at which the officer of law assumes the chthonic function of the avenger.

IV **Chapter Four, "The Economy of Fire,"** reads *Mad Max 2* and *Beyond Thunderdome* together as the saga's anatomy of petro-sovereignty and its Orestean wanderings. It treats the refinery as chokepoint and the fuel war as Bataillean expenditure; Bartertown as a staging of the economists' myth of barter that David Graeber dismantled in *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011); the Thunderdome as a judicial ordeal; Master Blaster as a literalisation of Hegel's dialectic of lord and bondsman; the "Gulag" as Levitical rite; and the Tell as a cargo-cult liturgy whose kinship with Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959), Hoban's *Riddley Walker*, Jack London's *The Scarlet Plague* (1912), and George R. Stewart's *Earth Abides* (1949) is examined in detail. The chapter closes on the annus mirabilis of 1985, in which the saga's third film appeared alongside Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale*, Cormac McCarthy's *Blood Meridian*, Don DeLillo's *White Noise*, Le Guin's *Always*

Coming Home, Michael Walzer's *Exodus and Revolution*, and Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto."

Chapter Five, "The Dynamo and the Virgin," the centre of the thesis, reads *Fury Road* as the saga's *Eumenides*. Its title is taken from the twenty-fifth chapter of *The Education of Henry Adams*, in which Adams set the dynamo, idol of modern force, against the Virgin of Chartres, the medieval force of reproduction, and the chapter argues that the film is the most rigorous dramatisation of Adams's opposition in modern art. It reads Immortan Joe as a monstrous Fisher King—the wounded sovereign of the Grail romances whose infirmity is the sterility of his land—through Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) and T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922); the War Boys' creed of living, dying, and living again as the conjunction of James Frazer's dying-and-rising god with the Norse *einherjar*, slain and restored each day in Valhalla; the Citadel through Foucault's biopower, Agamben's bare life, and Achille Mbembe's necropolitics; the flight and return through Exodus, Walzer's *Exodus and Revolution*, and Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970); and the Wives' rebellion as the refusal of the Apollonian embryology. V

Chapter Six, "Compost and Chronicle," reads *Furiosa* as the completion of the saga's Eumenidean turn. It reads Dementus as demagogue and, by a homophony the thesis offers as heuristic rather than etymological, as *dema*: the slain primordial being of Adolf E. Jensen's ethnology, from whose dismembered body the food-plants spring. It reads the History Man as a living archive and interrogates the problem of a historiography written upon skin; Ibn Khaldun's *Muqaddimah* (1377), with its cycle of nomadic solidarity (*asabiyya*) and sedentary decadence, as the deep structure of the film's politics; and the peach tree as the closing of what Marx called the metabolic rift between town and country, the severed circulation of nutrients back to the soil. VI

Chapter Seven, "Kinetic Liturgy," turns to form and to the saga's afterlives: Miller's pure cinema; the chase as rite; Sergei Eisenstein's montage of attractions, Keaton's *The General* (1926), and Virilio's dromology; the *Black & Chrome* edition; and the saga's dissemination through comics, games, music, fashion, and festival. It assembles the comparative constellation of speculative fiction across media within which the saga must be read—from Moebius's wordless desert odyssey *Arzach* (1975) and Alejandro Jodorowsky's *El Topo* (1970) to *Fist of the North Star*, Miyazaki's *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind*, *Judge Dredd*'s Cursed Earth, Frank Herbert's *Dune*, *Snowpiercer*, *Children of Men*, Hideo Kojima's *Death Stranding*, Octavia E. Butler's Earthseed novels, and McCarthy's *The Road*. VII

Chapter Eight, "Burying the Furies," draws the threads together into a theory of *humic eschatology*: an account of the end of the fossil world that refuses both the VIII

petromelancholic mourning of what is being lost and the techno-messianic fantasy of a new and inexhaustible fire, and proposes instead the Eumenidean labour of returning the chthonic powers to the ground.

1.10 Coda: Where Must We Go?

Fury Road ends with a question, attributed to a figure the film calls the First History Man: where must we go, it asks, we who wander this Wasteland "in search of our better selves"? The question is posed in the voice of a chronicler—a historian standing at the origin of history—and it is posed after the restoration of the waters rather than before it, as though the end of the tyranny were not the end of the wandering but its beginning. Bruno Latour, in the last years of his life, posed the political question of the climate emergency in almost identical terms. *Où atterrir?* —where to land?—was the title of his essay of 2017, translated as *Down to Earth* (2018): an argument that the modern project of escape, whether toward the global or back toward the local, had lost its ground, and that politics must henceforth be reoriented toward the Terrestrial, the thin critical zone of soil, water, and living things upon which every human project depends. The First History Man's question and Latour's are the same question. Both ask where a species that has burned its foundations might come to rest.

The question also inherits a theological form. Exodus is the paradigmatic narrative of a people wandering a wilderness toward a land it has not seen; Gilgamesh, maddened by the death of Enkidu, roams the steppe clad in skins in search of a life that will not end, and returns to Uruk with nothing but the knowledge of its walls. The saga places both itineraries under the sign of combustion. Its wanderers seek not a promised land but a habitable one, and what they discover—in *Fury Road*, on the salt; in *Furiosa*, in the ruins of the Green Place—is that the land they sought has already been consumed, and that the only habitable ground is the ground to which they must return and which they must remake. The wandering ends not in arrival but in conversion.

Walter Benjamin, in the ninth of his theses "On the Concept of History" (1940), described Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history: its face turned toward the past, where it sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at its feet, while a storm blowing from Paradise—the storm we call progress—drives it irresistibly into the future to which its back is turned. At the close of *Mad Max 2*, Max stands alone upon the road as the camera withdraws from him into the sky, seen by the child who will tell his legend; at the close of *Fury Road* he vanishes into the

crowd, acknowledged once by Furiosa from the rising platform. He is the angel of the saga's history, condemned to see the wreckage and unable to stay. The question the saga leaves to its audience is whether the storm can be stilled: whether the fire that drives us can be returned to the earth from which we raised it, and whether, in place of progress, the Furies might be persuaded to grant us growth.

The chapters that follow pursue that question through the five films, their genealogies, and their kin across the mythic, speculative, and philosophical record. The answer they propose is Aeschylean. The Furies cannot be defeated, and should not be burned. They must be buried with honour, so that they may bless the soil.

II

CHAPTER TWO

Genealogies of the Wasteland

The Clinic, the Workshop, and the Antipodean Apocalypse

Descent, Not Origin 2.1

The Wasteland was not invented in 1979; it was inherited. Every element of the saga's world—its crashed bodies and fetishised engines, its economy of fuel, its emptied desert and its expelled wanderer, its kinetic form and its self-mythologising frame—descends from lines of cultural, technological, and institutional history that had been converging upon the industrial fringe of Melbourne for decades before Miller and Kennedy began to shoot. This chapter traces those lines. Its method is genealogical in the sense that Friedrich Nietzsche inaugurated in *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887) and that Michel Foucault systematised in "Nietzsche, Genealogy, History" (1971): an inquiry that renounces the search for a single, pure origin (*Ursprung*) in favour of the tangled lines of descent (*Herkunft*) and the contingent moments of emergence (*Entstehung*) from which a formation is assembled. Genealogy does not ask where the Wasteland came from, as though it had a source. It asks what heterogeneous materials were fused to make it, and under what pressures.

Foucault's essay offers, moreover, a figure that the saga literalises with startling fidelity. Genealogy, he argued, situates itself at the articulation of the body and history: its task is to expose a body thoroughly imprinted by history, for the body is the inscribed surface of events. The Mad Max saga is crowded with inscribed bodies. Max's back is tattooed by his captors with his blood group and his specifications as a donor; the War Boys scarify their skin with the schematics of the engines they worship; the History Man of *Furiosa* carries upon his flesh the remnants of a

vanished civilisation's learning. The limit-case of the series stands outside it, in Franz Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919), whose apparatus executes the condemned by inscribing the violated commandment into his body with needles until he dies of the sentence—a machine that does not merely punish the body but writes the law upon it. That Kafka's apparatus stands in a penal colony, the institutional form in which modern Australia was founded, is a coincidence that the fifth section of this chapter declines to treat as merely coincidental. The saga's bodies are archives. To read them genealogically is to recover the histories written upon them.

Five lines of descent are traced in what follows, and each contributes one element of the petro-Oresteian structure outlined in Chapter One. The clinic supplies the wounded body and the figure of the witness (2.2). The workshop and the Australian automobile supply the machine, the fetish, and the folk devil (2.3). The oil shocks supply the economy of fire and the language of energetic war (2.4). The antipodean apocalyptic imagination supplies the chthonic desert, the expelled wanderer, and the lost children (2.5). The cinema—Australian, American, Japanese, and silent—supplies the generic bricolage and the kinetic liturgy (2.6). A sixth section examines the retrospective intervention of Joseph Campbell, whose monomyth reorganised the saga's self-understanding after the first film and was gradually outgrown by it (2.7), and a final section reads the year 1979 as the moment at which these lines converged (2.8). The chapter's claim is not that any one of these lines explains the saga, but that their convergence produced a structure none of them contained—and that this structure, once assembled, would take forty-five years to unfold.

2.2 The Clinic: Trauma, Triage, and the Medical Gaze

The first line of descent runs through the hospital. Miller completed his medical training at the University of New South Wales and served his residency at St Vincent's Hospital in Sydney in the early 1970s, at the moment when the carnage of the Australian road reached its historical apex. The national road toll peaked in 1970 at more than three thousand seven hundred deaths, in a population of under thirteen million; in the same year Victoria became the first jurisdiction in the world to make the wearing of seatbelts compulsory, a legislative admission that the automobile had become one of the principal instruments of death in peacetime life. Miller has described the casualty department of these years as the place in which he encountered, night after night, the bodies of young people broken by cars—an encounter that, by his account, left a permanent impress upon his imagination. The

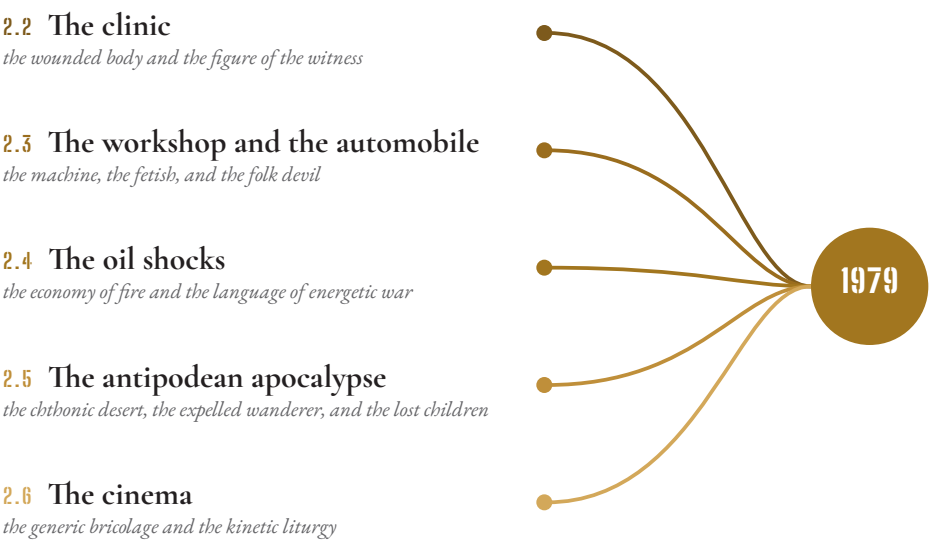


FIG. 5 Five lines of descent converging on the year 1979 (§§ 2.2–2.8).

first genealogical source of the Mad Max saga is, in this precise sense, clinical. Before it was a myth, the Wasteland was a ward.

The clinic brought with it a theory of the wound. The modern concept of trauma —from the Greek *trauma*, "wound"—was born not on the battlefield but on the railway. John Eric Erichsen's *On Railway and Other Injuries of the Nervous System* (1866) described the syndrome that came to be called "railway spine," in which passengers who had suffered no visible injury in a collision developed persistent and disabling symptoms. Wolfgang Schivelbusch's *The Railway Journey* (1977), first published as *Mad Max* was being prepared, reconstructed the process by which the railway accident became the paradigmatic event of industrial modernity: the moment at which the machine ensemble that had annihilated space and time revealed the violence it held in suspension. Sigmund Freud began the inquiry of *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) from the traumatic neuroses that follow railway disasters and war, and found in their compulsive repetition of the catastrophic scene the clue to a drive beyond pleasure; Cathy Caruth, in *Unclaimed Experience* (1996), redefined trauma as an event not fully experienced at the moment of its occurrence, which therefore returns, belatedly and intrusively, to possess the one who survived it. The saga inherits this genealogy whole. Max's hallucinations in *Fury Road*—the flash-cut faces of the dead, the child who calls him to account, the voices that break into the soundtrack—are a formal citation of trauma's temporality: the intrusive

image that arrives without warning and cannot be integrated into narrative. The Furies who hound Orestes, visible to him alone, are the oldest literary representation of post-traumatic intrusion; the saga restores to the diagnosis its mythic name.

The clinic also brought a way of seeing. Foucault's *The Birth of the Clinic* (1963) described the emergence, at the turn of the nineteenth century, of a medical gaze that read the visible surface of the body as the sign of an invisible lesion within, and that grounded this reading in the systematic opening of corpses—the anatomo-clinical method in which death became the teacher of life. The cinematographic style of the first film is saturated with this gaze. Its most insistent device is the extreme close-up of eyes widening in the instant before impact, a figure that fuses the observer and the casualty, the gaze that diagnoses and the body about to be destroyed; and its crashes are composed with an attention to the mechanics of collision that is less sadistic than forensic. The camera of *Mad Max* is a casualty officer's eye. That one of the film's decisive turns occurs in a hospital is therefore structurally exact. Max's resolve to abandon the Main Force Patrol is precipitated in a burns unit, where he confronts the incinerated body of his partner Goose. When he explains his resignation to his commanding officer, he diagnoses himself in clinical idiom: a little longer on the road, he fears, and he will become "a terminal crazy," distinguished from those he hunts only by his bronze badge. *Terminal*: the vocabulary of the oncology ward. Max knows his condition before he contracts it.

The clinic contributes, finally, a logic. *Triage*—from the French *trier*, to sort—entered modern medicine through the battlefield surgery of Dominique-Jean Larrey, chief surgeon of Napoleon's armies, as a procedure for allocating scarce care among the wounded according to urgency and the probability of survival, and it remains the defining practice of the emergency department. Triage is the ethics of scarcity: it decides, under conditions in which not all can be saved, which bodies will receive what is scarce. The Wasteland is a triage society raised to the level of a political order. Immortan Joe's Citadel sorts its population by utility—warriors, breeders, milkers, blood bags, and a destitute multitude who receive water only at the sovereign's whim—and its presiding clinician is the figure *Fury Road* names, with programmatic precision, the Organic Mechanic: a physician who treats bodies as engines and a mechanic who treats engines as bodies, who appraises the War Boys' failing flesh like worn parts and, when the pregnant Angharad dies beneath Joe's wheels, cuts the child from her body and pronounces upon it with a stockbreeder's appraisal. In the Organic Mechanic the dual signature of the saga's creators—the clinic and the workshop, the physician and the engineer—returns as a single monstrous character. The partnership that made the Wasteland is incarnated within it as the Wasteland's doctor.

Against this clinic of exhaustion, Miller's later career offers its inverse. *Lorenzo's Oil* dramatises a clinic of replenishment, in which parents refuse the medical establishment's verdict of hopelessness and labour, with obsessive care, to compound from oils a remedy for their dying son. The saga's triage and the later film's care are the two faces of a single medical imagination: the knowledge that bodies are fragile, and the question of what a community owes them. It is a question the saga will take forty-five years to answer, and its answer, when it comes in *Fury Road*, will be clinical in the most elementary sense—a transfusion, administered by the wanderer to the woman who has bled for the community, in the back of a moving vehicle.

The Workshop: Kennedy, the Interceptor, and the Australian Automobile 2.3

The second line of descent runs through the garage. Byron Kennedy, a Melbourne filmmaker born in 1949, had taught himself his craft through amateur production, and his intimacy with cameras, engines, and the logistics of the shoot complemented Miller's clinical and dramatic intelligence. The Australian Film Institute's establishment after his death of the Byron Kennedy Award, recognising innovation and the pursuit of excellence, attests to the reputation he left. In the partnership the workshop was Kennedy's domain, and from it emerged the saga's first fetish-object: the car that would become the most famous vehicle in Australian cinema.

The V8 Interceptor—the "Pursuit Special," presented in the film as the last of its kind—was a 1973 Ford Falcon XB GT hardtop, extensively modified, its nose reshaped by an aerodynamic kit and its bonnet surmounted by a supercharger that was, on set, a non-functioning prop whose pulley was spun for effect. The detail is not trivial. The saga's inaugural sacred object, the engine whose blower, engaged at the flick of a switch, becomes the emblem of Max's vengeance, is a simulacrum: power displayed rather than delivered, an icon of force whose force is theatrical. Jean Baudrillard, whose *Simulacra and Simulation* (1981) included an essay on Ballard's *Crash*, would have recognised the structure; and Marx's analysis of the commodity fetish, which conceals its social constitution behind an appearance of autonomous power, describes it more exactly still. Within the film the car functions explicitly as an instrument of seduction. The Patrol's commander, Fifi Macaffee, offers it to Max as an inducement to remain in service—the State's most sacred object tendered to retain its most capable servant—and Max takes possession of it only when, his family destroyed, he has ceased to serve anything but vengeance. The machine is the

covenant between the hero and the order. When the covenant breaks, the machine passes to the Fury.

Behind the Interceptor stood a national culture of the automobile with few equivalents in the industrial world. The launch in 1948 of the first Holden, promoted as Australia's own car, made the domestic automobile an emblem of postwar nationhood; the rivalry between Holden and Ford, re-enacted each year in the endurance race at Mount Panorama near Bathurst, acquired the intensity of a sectarian schism; and the high-performance sedans of the early 1970s—the Falcon GT-HO, the Torana XU-1, the Valiant Charger—became objects of a cult whose devotions were performed on suburban streets and country highways. In June 1972 a front-page report in Sydney's *Sun-Herald* that the manufacturers were preparing sedans capable of 160 miles per hour provoked a ministerial outcry and the abandonment of the projects—the episode Australian motoring history remembers as the "supercar scare." The car had become a folk devil. Stanley Cohen's *Folk Devils and Moral Panics* (1972), published the same year, analysed the process by which a society manufactures from a deviant group—in Cohen's case the mods and rockers of English seaside towns—an embodiment of its diffuse anxieties, amplifies its menace through the press, and mobilises against it the instruments of control. The Toecutter's gang condenses the folk devil of the motorcycle outlaw, and the Main Force Patrol the control culture arrayed against it; but the film's insight, developed in Chapter Three, is that panic and its object, the agents of control and the deviants they pursue, become in the end indistinguishable. Moral panic is mimetic crisis by other means.

The automobile was, in Australia as elsewhere, a rite of passage: the licence, the first car, the nocturnal drive as initiation into adulthood and its risks. Arnold van Gennep's *The Rites of Passage* (1909) described the tripartite structure—separation, transition, incorporation—through which societies ritualise the passage from one status to another; the young men who die in the saga's chases die in the liminal phase of an initiation that never ends. The War Boys of *Fury Road* are this generation transfigured into a cult: novices who never graduate, who remain forever in the threshold state of the initiate, and whose only incorporation is death. Their chapels of steering wheels raise to the dignity of a temple the national institution of the backyard shed, which Mark Thomson's *Blokes and Sheds* (1995) documented as a sanctuary of Australian masculinity.

The workshop has its own mythic genealogy, and it is chthonic. Hephaestus, the Greek god of the forge, labours lame of foot, attended by maidens of gold who move and speak by his art (*Iliad* 18); Virgil sets his smithy in volcanic caverns where the Cyclopes hammer thunderbolts in the dark (*Aeneid* 8). The forge-god is the first

engineer and the first disabled maker: the god whose body is broken is the god who builds bodies for others, as he builds the armour of Achilles. The saga's mechanics inherit both his subterranean station and his wounded body. Furiosa's prosthetic arm, the War Boys' irradiated flesh, and the dwarf Master who rules the methane forges beneath Bartertown descend from the lame smith in his underground workshop—and from the Nibelung forges of Richard Wagner's *Ring*, to which Chapter Four will return.

The automobile's most rigorous contemporaneous theorist was not a philosopher but a novelist. J. G. Ballard's *Crash* (1973) proposed that the car crash was the defining sacrament of technological society, the event in which body, machine, and desire were fused under the sign of death; in his introduction to the French edition of 1974, Ballard described the book as cautionary, a warning against the brutal and erotic realm that technology increasingly held out to its users. No documented influence connects *Crash* to *Mad Max*; the relation is one of contextual convergence. But the convergence is exact. Ballard's Vaughan, the self-appointed prophet of the expressway who dreams of dying in a collision with a film star, and the Nightrider, the self-proclaimed "fuel-injected suicide machine" who dies in a fireball in the first film's opening chase, are figures of the same historical moment: the moment at which the automobile ceased to be experienced as transport and began to be experienced as fate. Paul Virilio gave the moment its theory in *Speed and Politics*; Ballard gave it its liturgy; Miller and Kennedy gave it its myth.

Fuel and Fear: The Oil Shocks and the Moral Equivalent of War 2.4

The third line of descent runs through the bowser. The embargo proclaimed by the Arab members of OPEC in October 1973, in retaliation for Western support of Israel during the Yom Kippur War, quadrupled the price of crude within months; the revolution that toppled the Shah of Iran in early 1979 produced a second shock that more than doubled it again. Australia's exposure was cushioned by the Bass Strait fields, which by the mid-1970s supplied a majority of the nation's crude, but the crisis entered the national imagination through prices, through the televised spectacle of queues and rationing in the United States and Europe, and through a new public language in which energy was framed as a question of survival. McCausland, writing decades later, recalled the readiness of ordinary motorists to fight for fuel; the screenplay extrapolated from that readiness a world in which nothing else remained to fight for.

That language was, from the outset, martial. In April 1977 President Jimmy Carter told the American people that the effort to master the energy crisis would be "the moral equivalent of war," borrowing the phrase William James had coined in 1910 for the civic disciplines that might one day substitute for combat; in July 1979, at the height of the second shock, he diagnosed in the nation a "crisis of confidence" whose most visible symptoms were the queues at the pumps. The prologue of *Mad Max 2* takes the metaphor at its word. Over newsreel images of twentieth-century war and civil disorder, its narrator recounts how the warrior tribes went to war over the fuel upon which everything depended, how the cities exploded, and how the world collapsed into the struggle of gangs for what remained. The moral equivalent of war became war; the metaphor of the energy crisis became the literal matter of the apocalypse.

History would supply the image the prologue only imagined. In 1991 retreating Iraqi forces set fire to several hundred Kuwaiti oil wells, darkening the desert sky for months, and Werner Herzog's *Lessons of Darkness* (1992) narrated the burning fields, with deliberate estrangement, as the landscape of an alien planet after an unnamed catastrophe, its firefighters moving through the smoke like the acolytes of an unknown cult. Herzog's film is the saga's documentary double: a real petro-apocalypse rendered as science-fictional myth, as the saga is a science-fictional myth rendered with the textures of the real. Its most disquieting sequence, in which workers who have capped a well set it alight again, as though unable to live without the fire, is the purest image in modern cinema of the Erinyic economy's compulsion: the fire that, once released from the ground, is tended rather than extinguished.

The depletion imaginary of the 1970s also possessed a literary genealogy. Ballard's *The Drought* (1965), in which an industrial film upon the oceans halts evaporation and rainfall, imagined a world dying of thirst in which survivors drift toward the dwindling shoreline and water becomes the medium of power—an anticipation of the hydraulic tyranny of *Fury Road* more precise than any the saga's own documentation supplies. Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), published the same year, built an entire civilisation upon the discipline of water in a desert world, and placed at its centre a messianic hero whom Herbert intended as a warning against the charismatic leader rather than a model for him. The 1970s converted these speculations into political economy: the Club of Rome's modelling, Georgescu-Roegen's entropy law, E. F. Schumacher's *Small Is Beautiful* (1973), and the first political organisation of the environmental movement, which in Australia had already produced, in the United Tasmania Group of 1972, what is commonly regarded as the world's first green party. The Wasteland was conceived in the decade in which industrial civili-

sation first learned, collectively and publicly, to imagine its own exhaustion—and to imagine it, already, as a war over what lies beneath the ground.

2.5 The Antipodean Apocalypse: Australia as the Last Place

Long before Europeans reached it, the southern continent was a theological problem. Augustine, in *The City of God* (16.9), denied that human beings could inhabit the antipodes, the inverted underside of the world, since no descendant of Adam could have crossed the intervening ocean; medieval cosmographers peopled it instead with monstrous races and the world turned upside down. The antipodes entered the European imagination as a space beyond the reach of salvation history—the *mundus inversus*, the place where the order of things is reversed. When the continent was colonised, it was colonised as an inversion: as the penal underside of the British Empire, the place to which the metropole expelled what it could not contain.

Robert Hughes's *The Fatal Shore* (1986) reconstructed the transportation system that between 1788 and 1868 shipped some 160,000 convicts to the Australian colonies—a system whose scale and systematic cruelty have invited comparison with the penal archipelagos of the twentieth century. The resonance with the saga is direct, and double. *Beyond Thunderdome*, released the year before Hughes's book, names its punishment of desert exile "Gulag"; and the rite it depicts—the guilty man driven into the wilderness, masked, upon a beast—is the Levitical expulsion of the scapegoat. The genealogical conjunction is exact. Modern Australia was founded as the *pharmakos* of the British Empire: the continent onto which the metropole discharged its criminal contamination in order to purify itself. The saga's pharmakos-witness wanders a land that was itself constituted as an imperial scapegoat, and the rite of expulsion that *Beyond Thunderdome* enacts upon Max re-enacts, at the scale of a single body, the founding rite of the settler nation.

The settler nation's second founding fiction was legal. The doctrine of *terra nullius*—land belonging to no one—licensed the dispossession of the continent's Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples by declaring their country empty, and the interior was imagined accordingly: as the "Dead Heart" of J. W. Gregory's *The Dead Heart of Australia* (1906), as the void whose distances Geoffrey Blainey's *The Tyranny of Distance* (1966) made the governing condition of national history, as a vacancy awaiting settlement or mastery. The emptiness was manufactured. And in the decades after the Second World War the interior was put to a use that made its fictional emptiness lethally literal. Between 1952 and 1957, with the consent of the

Australian government, Britain conducted twelve major atomic tests on Australian territory—at the Monte Bello Islands, at Emu Field, and at Maralinga in the Great Victoria Desert—followed until 1963 by hundreds of so-called minor trials that scattered plutonium across the test ranges. Aboriginal people living on and downwind of the ranges were exposed; the radioactive cloud that drifted from Emu Field in October 1953 entered Anangu memory as the Black Mist. The Royal Commission into British Nuclear Tests in Australia, chaired by James McClelland, delivered its report in December 1985, the year of *Beyond Thunderdome*. The film's post-nuclear desert, its children's garbled memory of the catastrophe, and its absence of Indigenous people are thus framed by a national history in which the desert had in fact been made a nuclear wasteland, and in which its first peoples had in fact been treated as though absent.

The apocalyptic imagination of postwar Australia had already found its definitive text in Nevil Shute's *On the Beach* (1957), in which Melbourne is the last great city on earth, awaiting the arrival of the radioactive cloud that has already extinguished the northern hemisphere. Stanley Kramer's film adaptation (1959) was shot in Melbourne, and a quip about the city's suitability as a setting for the end of the world, long attributed to Ava Gardner, was later acknowledged by a journalist to have been his own invention—an apocryphal joke that nonetheless named a truth of the national imaginary. Australia was the last place: the remnant at the end of the world, the antipodes at which the catastrophe of the north would arrive last. Twenty years after Kramer, Miller and Kennedy shot *Mad Max* in the same city and on its western industrial fringe, staging the Halls of Justice in the decommissioned sewage pumping station at Spotswood, since absorbed into a museum of science and technology—the house of law set, with unwitting precision, in the city's hydraulic underworld. *On the Beach* imagines the end of the world as an elegy, awaited with dignity; *Mad Max* imagines it as a crash, arriving at speed. Between the two lies the passage from the nuclear to the automotive apocalypse: from the bomb that ends history at a stroke to the slow catastrophe of the road, which ends it one body at a time.

The settler imagination possessed, moreover, a recurrent figure for its anxiety before the interior: the lost child. Peter Pierce's *The Country of Lost Children* (1999) traced the persistence of this figure from the colonial newspapers through Frederick McCubbin's painting *Lost* (1886) to Joan Lindsay's *Picnic at Hanging Rock* (1967) and Peter Weir's film of it (1975), reading in it a displaced expression of the settlers' unease in a land they had seized but did not understand. The Lost Tribe of *Beyond Thunderdome*—children stranded in a desert gorge after a crash, preserving in a degraded oral liturgy the memory of the adult world that lost them—is the lost child

of the Australian imagination multiplied into a people. Ross Gibson's reading of the film as a fable of "yondering," of the settler's yearning toward an unreachable beyond, belongs to this genealogy, as does the film's conclusion, in which the children, having escaped the desert, settle in the ruins of Sydney and keep the city lit at night for those still lost.

The interior had also its own iconography of the outlaw, and its master was Sidney Nolan. Nolan's Ned Kelly series (1946–47) reduced the bushranger, who had fashioned plate armour from plough mouldboards for his last stand at Glenrowan in 1880, to a black geometric helmet with a slot for eyes, floating against the vacancy of the bush—a figure at once comic, menacing, and metaphysical, a man made into a mask and a mask made into a landscape. The saga's gallery of masked sovereigns and captives—the Humungus behind his steel visor, Immortan Joe behind his respirator, Max behind the iron muzzle clamped upon him at the opening of *Fury Road*—descends iconographically from Nolan's helmet: the armoured figure in the empty land, whose face has become a machine. The Kelly legend furnished a moral genealogy as well. Kelly's Jerilderie Letter (1879), his self-justifying denunciation of police, magistrates, and squatters, and the national ballad "Waltzing Matilda" (1895), in which a swagman drowns himself rather than submit to the squatter and the troopers, enshrined in Australian popular culture a sacralisation of the outlaw against the law. Philippe Mora's *Mad Dog Morgan* (1976), a portrait of the bushranger Dan Morgan, carried the epithet of madness into the cinema three years before Max. The saga inherits this ambivalence entire: a law become indistinguishable from the outlaws it pursues, and an outlaw who becomes, by default, the bearer of whatever justice remains.

The literary interior found its metaphysician in Patrick White. *Voss* (1957) follows a German explorer, modelled loosely on Ludwig Leichhardt, whose expedition into the continent's centre is at once a geographical enterprise and a spiritual campaign of the will—an attempt to master the desert by becoming its god—which ends in starvation, delirium, and decapitation. Voss is the precursor of every self-deifying sovereign of the saga's Wasteland, from the Humungus to Immortan Joe to Dementus: the European will that enters the desert to possess it and is possessed by it instead. That the novel counterpoints Voss's march with the inward pilgrimage of Laura Trevelyan, who remains in Sydney and shares his ordeal by a kind of spiritual telepathy, anticipates the saga's own counterpoint between the sovereign's conquest and the woman's endurance. Australia's apocalyptic imagination, from Shute to White to the Maralinga reports, supplied the saga with its stage: a desert that was never empty but had been made to look so; a continent founded upon expulsion;

and a last place, at the end of the world, where the end of the world would arrive last and might be survived.

2.6 The Cinema of Wheels: Ozploitation, the Western, the Samurai, and the Silent Chase

The fifth line of descent runs through the cinema, and it is the most tangled. The Australian feature industry, moribund for most of the postwar period, was revived in the 1970s by public investment—through the Australian Film Development Corporation from 1970 and the Australian Film Commission from 1975—and the revival bifurcated almost at once. One branch produced the literary period films that won international prestige: *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, *The Getting of Wisdom* (1977), *My Brilliant Career* (1979). The other produced a raucous cinema of sex comedy, horror, action, and exploitation that Mark Hartley's documentary *Not Quite Hollywood* (2008) would later christen Ozploitation. *Mad Max*, made with private money and aimed at the international genre market, belongs to the second branch and transcends it, and its relation to that branch is genealogically intimate.

Peter Weir's *The Cars That Ate Paris* (1974) supplied the saga with its founding economic fantasy: a decaying country town that survives by engineering crashes on the roads that pass through it and harvesting the wrecks, their parts, and their survivors, upon whom the town's doctor practises experimental surgery. The film is a parable of an economy of collision, and its rebellious youth, who prowl the town in modified cars, include a Volkswagen bristling with metal spikes—an image the saga would remember four decades later in the spiked, porcupine-like vehicles of the Buzzards in *Fury Road*. Sandy Harbutt's *Stone* (1974), concerning a policeman who goes undercover among an outlaw motorcycle club, supplied personnel and ethos: several of its players, Hugh Keays-Byrne among them, passed into *Mad Max*, and its celebrated funeral cortège of hundreds of motorcycles anticipated the saga's war-party processions. Colin Eggleston's *Long Weekend* (1978), in which a careless suburban couple's desecration of a coastal wilderness provokes the vengeance of the land itself, offered an ecological counter-myth—nature as Fury—that the saga would take nearly four decades to absorb. And in the saga's own wake, Brian Trenchard-Smith's *Dead End Drive-In* (1986) imagined a near future of economic collapse in which unemployed youth are interned in a drive-in cinema: the car culture of the 1970s converted into a carceral camp.

The international genealogy is broader still. The western supplied the saga's architecture of solitude. George Stevens's *Shane* (1953) ends with a child calling

after the gunfighter who has saved his family's community and must now leave it, since the violence that saved it can have no place within it; the closing image of *Mad Max 2*, in which the Feral Kid watches Max stand alone upon the road, is its direct descendant. John Ford's *The Searchers* (1956) ends with Ethan Edwards framed in a doorway he will not cross, having restored the abducted girl to a home that cannot admit him. Robert Warshow's "The Westerner" (1954) defined the genre's hero as a man of violence who knows the limits of the law he defends, and Richard Slotkin's *Regeneration Through Violence* (1973) traced the American frontier myth to the conviction that the community is renewed through the violent passage of its hero into, and back out of, the wilderness. The saga accepts the western's architecture and refuses its theology. Violence, in the Wasteland, does not regenerate. It exhausts. The saga will discover regeneration only when it substitutes germination for violence—when the seed replaces the gun as the instrument of renewal.

The samurai film supplied the saga's ethic of the masterless warrior. Akira Kurosawa's *Seven Samurai* (1954), in which a band of hired swordsmen defends a farming village against bandits, is the template of *Mad Max 2*'s siege of the refinery compound; *Yojimbo* (1961), in which a ronin sells his sword to rival factions in a desolate town and plays them against one another, is the template of Max's initial mercenary bargaining for fuel. Sergio Leone's *A Fistful of Dollars* (1964), an unauthorised remake of *Yojimbo*, had already demonstrated that the samurai and the gunfighter were variants of a single figure; the saga completed the demonstration by adding the motorist. The reception history that led Miller to Campbell—Max received as samurai in Japan and as gunfighter in France—was thus less a discovery of universal archetype than a recognition of genealogy. Max *was* the ronin and the gunfighter, because the films had been assembled from their remains.

The silent cinema supplied the saga's form. Miller has spoken repeatedly of the chase comedies of Buster Keaton and Harold Lloyd as the purest expression of cinema's capacity to communicate through motion alone, and of his ambition to make films legible without dialogue to any audience in the world. Keaton's *The General* (1926), a feature-length chase on and around a locomotive during the American Civil War, is the saga's formal ancestor: a film in which a machine is pursued by machines across a landscape, and in which narrative, character, and comedy are all generated by the logistics of motion. Tom Gunning's account of early film as a "cinema of attractions" (1986)—a cinema of display and shock that addressed its spectator directly rather than absorbing him into a fiction—describes the mode to which *Fury Road* would return with a fully industrial apparatus. The kinetic liturgy examined in Chapter Seven has its rubrics in Keaton.

2.7 The Retrospective Monomyth: Campbell, Vogler, and the American Monomyth

The sixth genealogical line differs from the others in that it entered the saga after the first film had been made. Campbell's *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949), drawing upon Carl Gustav Jung's theory of archetypes and the collective unconscious, proposed that the myths of all cultures enact a single heroic itinerary: a departure from the ordinary world in answer to a call, an initiation through trials and encounters with divine powers in a special world, and a return bearing a boon that renews the community. Miller's discovery of this schema, prompted by the worldwide reception of a film he had conceived as a low-budget action picture, reorganised the saga's self-understanding. *Mad Max 2* is the first film made under the sign of the monomyth. Its narrative is framed by the voice of a member of the community the hero saved; its hero refuses the call before accepting it; and its conclusion bestows a boon—the fuel, the escape, the founding of a tribe—upon a people the hero cannot join.

Miller was not alone. George Lucas had made *Star Wars* (1977) under Campbell's influence, and in 1985 the Hollywood story analyst Christopher Vogler circulated a memorandum distilling the monomyth into a practical guide for screenwriters, later expanded into *The Writer's Journey* (1992). The monomyth thereby became an industrial template, and its universality an artefact of its own success: the more films were made according to the hero's journey, the more the hero's journey appeared to be what all films had always been. Folklorists, Alan Dundes prominent among them, objected that Campbell's universalism dissolved the specificity of particular traditions into a homogeneous psychic substance. And two critics of American popular culture, Robert Jewett and John Shelton Lawrence, proposed in *The American Monomyth* (1977) that the dominant heroic pattern of American mass culture was not Campbell's cycle of initiation at all but a distinct pattern of redemption: a community threatened by evil, whose ordinary institutions have failed; a selfless and solitary hero who emerges from outside it to save it; and his recession into obscurity once his task is done. The pattern, they argued, was profoundly anti-democratic, since it implied that communities cannot save themselves and must await a redeemer.

Jewett and Lawrence's pattern fits the first trilogy more exactly than Campbell's. Max undergoes no initiation; he is not transformed by a special world; he brings back no boon from it. He arrives from outside a threatened community whose institutions have failed, performs the redemptive violence of which it is incapable,

and recedes. The trilogy is an American monomyth transposed to an Australian desert. And it is precisely this pattern that the late films dismantle. In *Fury Road* the redemptive enterprise is conceived, initiated, and largely executed by Furiosa and the Wives; Max is recruited as an auxiliary, and his single decisive intervention—the proposal to turn back—returns the initiative to the community rather than usurping it. In *Furiosa* he is reduced to a glimpse at the edge of the frame. The saga's trajectory is, among other things, an immanent critique of the monomyth it adopted: an education, conducted over four decades, out of the belief that communities must await a redeemer.

The feminist critique of the monomyth supplies the final term. Maureen Murdock, in *The Heroine's Journey* (1990), recounted asking Campbell how the hero's journey applied to women, and receiving the answer that women need not make the journey at all, since in the mythological tradition the woman is the place toward which the hero travels. *Fury Road* reads like a refutation composed scene by scene. Its women make the journey; they are not its destination. The destination toward which they travel—the Green Place, the maternal paradise of Furiosa's childhood—has ceased to exist, its soil soured and its water poisoned, its custodians reduced to a remnant of ageing riders on motorcycles. The woman is no longer the place to which the hero journeys, because the place itself has been killed. What remains is a journey without a destination, which must therefore become a journey of return and of remaking. Le Guin's "Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986), with its proposal that the hero's spear be displaced by the gatherer's container, names the narrative form this discovery requires. The saga's genealogy thus includes, at its late end, the critique of its own early mythography: Campbell supplies the frame that Murdock and Le Guin teach the saga to break.

Convergence: The Year 1979 2.8

The five lines of descent converged upon a single year. *Mad Max* opened in Australia in April 1979, in the months between the Iranian Revolution that triggered the second oil shock and the address in which Carter diagnosed his nation's crisis of confidence. On 28 March of that year a partial meltdown at the Three Mile Island nuclear plant in Pennsylvania confirmed that the principal alternative to oil carried its own apocalyptic charge. In the same year Jean-François Lyotard's *The Postmodern Condition* defined postmodernity as an incredulity toward the grand narratives of emancipation and progress—an exhaustion of narrative to set beside the exhaustion of fuel—and Margaret Thatcher's election in May inaugurated the

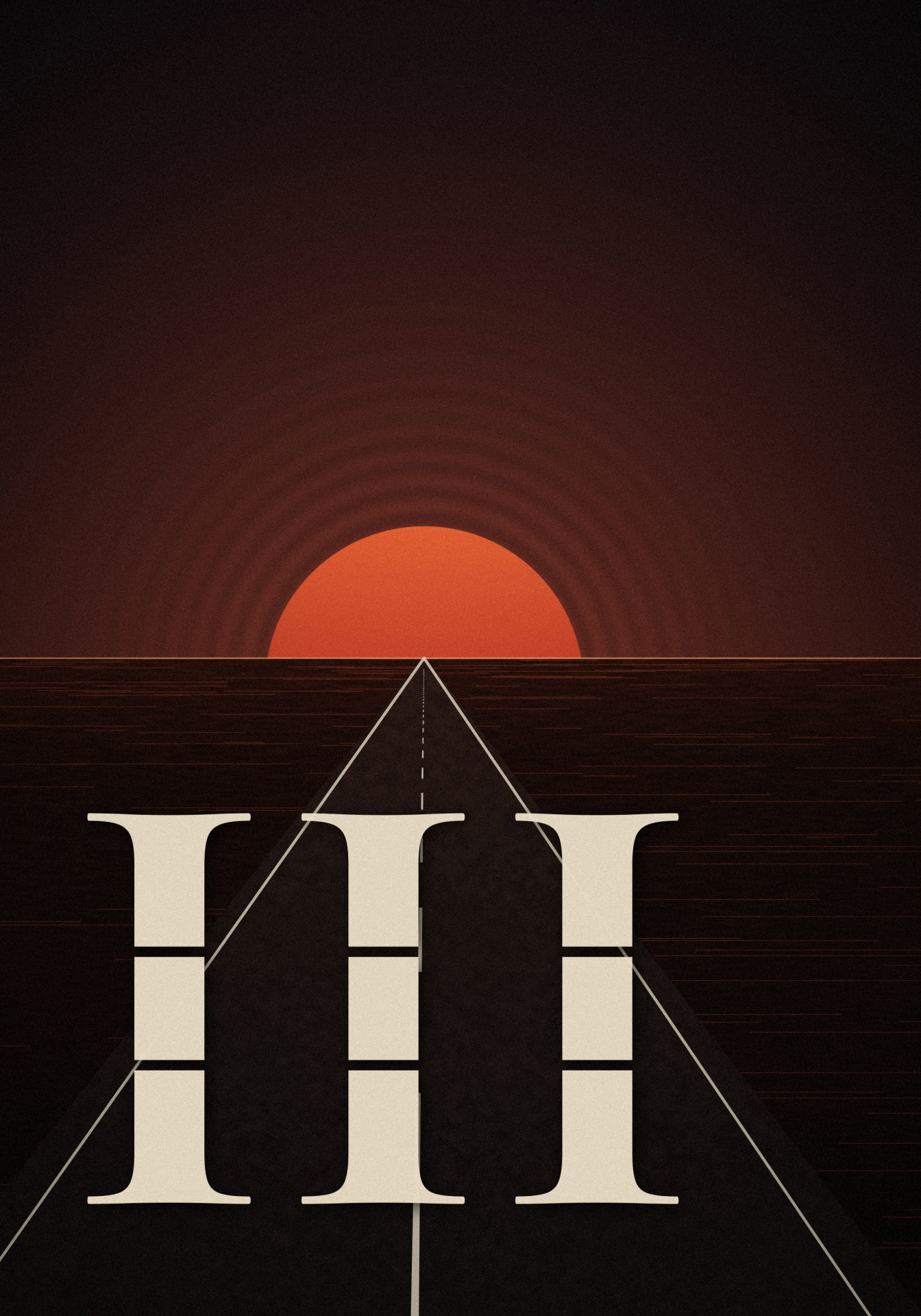
market revolution that would remake the political economy of the West. The journalist and historian Christian Caryl, in *Strange Rebels* (2013), has read 1979 as the year in which the twenty-first century was born, through the simultaneous return of the market and of religion as world-historical forces. The Wasteland of the later films —a world of militarised religion and ruthless exchange, of Valhalla and Bartertown, of the War Boys' martyr cult and Gastown's commodity of fire—is the mythic image of precisely this conjunction.

The cinema of 1979 registered the conjunction with uncanny unanimity. Andrei Tarkovsky's *Stalker*, adapted from Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972), sent its pilgrims through the Zone—a forbidden wasteland left by an unexplained visitation—toward a room said to grant the innermost wish, which none of them, in the end, dares to enter. Walter Hill's *The Warriors*, derived from Sol Yurick's novel and through it from Xenophon's *Anabasis*, followed a gang across a hostile nocturnal city toward the sea. Francis Ford Coppola's *Apocalypse Now* ended in the jungle compound of a renegade officer worshipped as a god by his followers, in whose quarters the camera discloses James Frazer's *The Golden Bough* and Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance*—the very texts upon which Chapter Five will draw to read Immortan Joe as a dying sacred king—and whose killing by his successor is intercut with a ritual sacrifice. The god-king of the wasteland, slain by the one who will take his place, entered the cinema in the same season as Max.

Stalker and *Mad Max* are the year's antithetical masterpieces of the wasteland: Tarkovsky's long takes and Miller's velocity, the pilgrim who waits and the driver who cannot stop, the zone of contemplative stillness and the road of kinetic frenzy. Both concern a journey through a ruined landscape toward a promised centre that may not exist; both conclude that the centre cannot redeem those who seek it. It would take Miller thirty-six years, and *Fury Road*, to bring the two cinemas together: to open, in the stillness of the Wives washing in the desert and the stillness of Max's hallucinations, a time-image within the action-image, and to discover, like Tarkovsky, that the wasteland's promised room was empty and that its pilgrims must remake the world from which they had fled.

The Wasteland, then, was assembled—from the casualty department and the backyard shed, from the bowser and the newsreel, from the penal colony and the test range, from Ozploitation, the western, the samurai film, and the silent chase, and finally from the mythographer's schema that its makers adopted and later outgrew. No single source contains it, and none explains it. What the genealogy reveals is rather a pattern of convergence in which each line of descent supplies one term of the petro-Oresteian structure: the wounded body and its witness, the fetish-machine and its folk devil, the economy of fire, the chthonic desert and its expelled

wanderer, the kinetic liturgy. The saga's achievement was to fuse these terms into a single mythic apparatus. The next chapter examines the first and rawest form of that apparatus: the film of 1979, in which the law exhausts itself upon the road, and the Fury is born.


III

CHAPTER THREE

The Law Exhausted

Mad Max *(1979) and the Birth of Fury*

"A Few Years from Now": The Tense of Exhaustion 3.1

Mad Max opens not with a catastrophe but with a caption: "A few years from now..." The phrase establishes the film's temporality with a precision its sequels would abandon. It is set neither after the end of the world nor before it, but during it—in the slow interval in which an order runs down. Unlike *Mad Max 2*, the first film contains no prologue of war, no mythic narrator, no named catastrophe. Its world is recognisably the outer suburbs and coastal hinterland of 1970s Victoria: beaches and ice-cream kiosks, country service stations and farmhouses, a hospital, a magistrates' court, a family holiday. Upon this ordinary landscape the film superimposes the signs of decay—the dilapidated Halls of Justice, highways emptied of traffic, a road sign in the opening chase that names the route Anarchie Road—without ever explaining them. The apocalypse of *Mad Max* is not an event. It is a process: the social correlate of the entropic degradation described in Chapter One, in which an order loses not its existence but its energy.

Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) described the modern transformation of apocalyptic time as a passage from the imminent to the immanent: an End no longer awaited at a determinate date but diffused through the present as a condition of perpetual crisis. The caption of *Mad Max* is the grammar of immanent apocalypse. "A few years from now" names a future that is already here, a near-future distinguishable from the present only by the intensity of its symptoms. James Berger's *After the End* (1999) argued that post-apocalyptic representation is less concerned with the catastrophe itself than with its aftermath—with the traces and symptoms through which a catastrophe that cannot be represented directly is registered. The first film inverts the formula: it represents not the aftermath of an end but

the symptoms of an end that has not yet been declared. It is a pre-post-apocalyptic film, a diagnosis rather than an autopsy.

The film's generic situation sharpens the diagnosis. *Mad Max* belongs, by its premise, to the vigilante cycle that dominated American crime cinema of the 1970s —*Dirty Harry* (1971), *Walking Tall* (1973), *Death Wish* (1974)—a cycle that answered perceived crises of public order, and the procedural liberalisation of criminal justice of which *Miranda v. Arizona* (1966) had become the emblem, with fantasies of a lawman or citizen who must transgress the law in order to restore it. Its plot is that of *Death Wish*: a man whose family is destroyed by criminals the law fails to punish takes justice into his own hands. But where the American films present vigilantism as the recovery of a true law beneath the false one—Harry Callahan's contempt for procedure as fidelity to justice, Paul Kersey's killings as civic hygiene —*Mad Max* declares its verdict in its title. Its avenger is not restored; he is mad. The film does not endorse the vigilante's logic so much as diagnose it, and its diagnosis is that vengeance does not restore the law but completes its exhaustion. In its local context the diagnosis had a specific resonance. Victoria had only recently been through the Beach Inquiry of 1975–76 into allegations against members of its police force, and the image of a patrol whose officers are scarcely distinguishable from those they pursue did not need to be imported from Hollywood.

This chapter reads the film as the saga's *Agamemnon* and *Libation Bearers*. It traces the vendetta that structures the plot as a curse of Atreid form transposed onto the infrastructure of the road (3.2); the separation of law from force that defines the film's political condition, and that grounds the thesis's claim that the Wasteland is post-nomic rather than pre-legal (3.3); the crisis of distinctions in which the Patrol and the gang become monstrous doubles (3.4); the gang as a sacral community whose ecstatic cult the saga will later institutionalise as a state (3.5); the Elizabethan genealogy of the officer of law who becomes a revenger (3.6); the destruction of mother and child as the film's founding catastrophe (3.7); Max's transformation into a Fury and the literal *lex talionis* of the film's ending (3.8); and the exhausted state's attempt to manufacture heroes as a substitute for legitimacy (3.9).

3.2 The House of Atreus on the Highway

In the *Oresteia* the curse is a structure, not an event. The chorus of *Agamemnon* returns again and again to the principle that the deed of violence breeds its own progeny, that blood once spilt upon the ground calls for more, and that the house of Atreus is possessed by a daimon who works through each generation's crime

to produce the next: Atreus's butchery of his brother's children, Agamemnon's sacrifice of his daughter, Clytemnestra's murder of her husband, Orestes's murder of his mother. Each act is simultaneously retribution and provocation; each avenger becomes the object of the next vengeance. The curse is the name for a process that cannot terminate from within.

Mad Max compresses this structure from generations into weeks and transposes it from a dynasty to a social field. Its chain of retaliation runs without interruption from the first reel to the last. The Nightrider, an escaped gang member who has seized a police Pursuit Special, dies in a fireball at the end of the opening chase. His death summons the Toecutter's gang, who arrive at a country railway station to claim his coffin and then descend upon the town, where they run down and assault a young couple. Johnny the Boy, left behind by the gang, is arrested by Max and Goose, but released when the witnesses fail to appear in court. The gang sabotages Goose's motorcycle and ambushes him on the road; the Toecutter compels Johnny to set the overturned vehicle alight; Goose is burned. Max resigns—or, at his commander's urging, takes leave to reconsider—and departs with his family for the coast, where the gang finds them by chance; Jessie and the child are run down on the highway. Max returns in the uniform he has renounced, hunts the gang down one by one, and ends the film by consigning Johnny to a death or a mutilation of his own choosing. Every link in the chain is both an answer and a summons. No act of violence in the film is first, and none is last.

What distinguishes the film's curse from Aeschylus's is its bearer. The house of Atreus is cursed through blood; the world of *Mad Max* is cursed through infrastructure. The sociologist John Urry, in "The 'System' of Automobility" (2004), described the car not as an object but as the dominant element in a self-organising and self-expanding system—roads, fuels, industries, signs, practices, desires—that reproduces itself by locking its users into dependence upon it and that generates, as a structural by-product, a ceaseless toll of injury and death. Automobility is a curse in the Aeschylean sense: a structure that works through individual agents to produce a series of crimes that none of them, individually, intends. Every link in the film's vendetta is forged upon the road and with the instruments of the road—the stolen patrol car, the sabotaged motorcycle, the burning utility, the gang's machines bearing down on mother and child. The highway is the house of Atreus, and its daimon is speed.

The film's dramaturgy observes, moreover, the Aristotelian anatomy of tragic recognition. Aristotle's *Poetics* distinguished, among the kinds of *anagnorisis*, recognition by tokens—scars, necklaces, objects—and judged it the least artful; yet the *Oresteia*'s second play stages one of its most famous instances, when Electra, at her

father's tomb, recognises her brother's return by a lock of hair and by footprints that match her own. *Mad Max* stages its recognition by a token of the same kind. Max arrives too late at the scene of the attack, and the film registers the death of his son through a single object: a small shoe lying on the bitumen. The footprint at the tomb and the shoe on the road are tokens of kinship inscribed by the foot, and in both cases recognition is the hinge upon which the avenger turns. Electra's recognition reunites the avengers; Max's isolates the avenger absolutely. The token that in Aeschylus restores a family announces in Miller its extinction.

The *Oresteia* ends in a court. *Mad Max* ends on an empty road, with no Athena, no Areopagus, no persuasion of the Furies, and no procession conducting them home. Its structure is that of a trilogy truncated after its second play: the curse completed, the avenger triumphant and polluted, the Furies loosed. The saga's subsequent films are, in this light, a long search for a third play—for the court that the first film's world has lost the capacity to convene.

3.3 Law Without Force, Force Without Law

The building that houses the Main Force Patrol is the film's first image of the law, and it is a ruin. The Halls of Justice—the name displayed over a decaying industrial structure—present the law as a survival: an institution whose name persists after its substance has drained away. Inside, in one of the film's strangest scenes, the Patrol's commander, Fifi Macaffee, stripped to the waist, tends the potted plants of his office with a watering can. The image is comic, and it is exact. Francis Bacon opened his essay "Of Revenge" (1625) with a horticultural figure: "Revenge is a kind of wild justice; which the more man's nature runs to, the more ought law to weed it out." Bacon makes the law a gardener and revenge its weed. In the Halls of Justice the law's gardener waters his pots indoors while, on the roads outside, the wild justice has overrun the field.

The film's single scene of formal legal process confirms the diagnosis. Johnny the Boy, arrested after the gang's assault on the young couple, is brought before the court, and the case collapses because the witnesses, intimidated, fail to appear. The court convenes, counsel pleads, procedure is observed, and nothing can be compelled. Goose's fury at the outcome erupts in the courthouse itself, and the officers of the law find themselves restraining one another. This is law without force: a juridical order that retains its forms, its rituals, and its vocabulary but has lost the capacity to make them bind. The film's final movement presents the inverse condition. Max, having left the Patrol, dons its uniform and takes its most powerful vehicle to hunt

the gang; his violence borrows the insignia of the law while answering to nothing but his grief. This is force without law. Between the court's impotence and the avenger's omnipotence the film locates the space in which the Wasteland will be born.

Giorgio Agamben's *State of Exception* (2003) gave this separation its theoretical formula. In the state of exception, Agamben argued, the force of law is detached from law itself; what circulates is a "force-of-law" in which the word *law* is placed under erasure—force that retains the authority of law without its content. Agamben drew the thread from Walter Benjamin, whose "Critique of Violence" (1921) singled out the police as the institution in which the distinction between law-making and law-preserving violence collapses. The police, Benjamin argued, intervene "for security reasons" wherever the legal order cannot obtain its ends; their power is formless, nowhere tangible and everywhere present, a ghostly presence in the life of civilised states. The Main Force Patrol is Benjamin's police raised to the level of myth: an institution whose violence is neither founded upon law nor bound by it, which operates in the space the courts have abandoned, and whose best officer, by the film's end, has become what he pursued. Benjamin's later thesis that the state of emergency in which we live is not the exception but the rule could stand as the epigraph of the film's near-future.

The political-theoretical consensus that has attended the saga since 1979 is Hobbesian. The Wasteland is routinely described as the state of nature of *Leviathan* (1651, ch. 13): a war of every man against every man, in which there is "no place for industry," no arts, no letters, no society, and the life of man is "solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short." The description fits the later films better than the first, and even there it misleads. Hobbes's state of nature is pre-political—the condition that precedes the covenant and from which the covenant delivers. The world of *Mad Max* is post-political: it possesses courts, police, hospitals, roads, and commerce, and a state whose institutions persist in form while failing in function. Max Weber defined the state, in "Politics as a Vocation" (1919), as the human community that successfully claims the monopoly of the legitimate use of physical force within a given territory. The film depicts not the absence of such a community but the failure of its claim: a monopoly contested by the gangs and dissolved from within by the Patrol, until legitimacy and force can no longer be told apart. It is worth noting, too, what Hobbes names first among the goods the state of nature lacks: after industry, there is "no culture of the earth." The absence of agriculture is, for Hobbes, the first consequence of the war of all against all. The saga's late films will make the recovery of the culture of the earth—seed, soil, the Green Place—the condition of any exit from the Wasteland.

A more exact philosophical frame is supplied by John Locke. In the *Second Treatise of Government* (1689), Locke argued that in the state of nature every individual holds the executive power of the law of nature: the right to punish those who transgress it, in proportion to the transgression. Civil government, for Locke, is the remedy for the inconveniences of a condition in which every man is judge in his own case, since self-love makes men partial to themselves and their friends, and passion and revenge carry them too far in punishing others. *Mad Max* stages the undoing of that remedy. When the magistrate fails, the executive power reverts to the injured party; Max becomes judge and executioner in his own cause, with precisely the partiality and excess Locke predicted. The film depicts not a world before the Leviathan but a world in which the Leviathan has abdicated, returning to individuals the executive power they had ceded to it. Its condition is what this thesis calls *post-nomic*: the nomos persists as form and memory, but the energy that animated it has been spent, and the powers it once concentrated have been dispersed back into the bodies of the injured.

Jacques Derrida, in "Force of Law: The 'Mystical Foundation of Authority'" (1990), argued that every legal order rests upon a founding act of violence that cannot be justified by the law it founds, since that law does not yet exist; the foundation is therefore, in a phrase Derrida borrowed from Montaigne and Pascal, mystical. Max's final act is a founding violence without a foundation. It establishes no order, institutes no court, binds no community. What it founds is only a legend—the story of the man who did it—and the next film will begin from that legend, told by a narrator who knew him only as a wanderer. The law exhausted in 1979 is replaced not by a new law but by a myth.

3.4 The Monstrous Double: Mimetic Crisis on the Road

René Girard's account of the sacrificial crisis begins with the collapse of differences. In a society governed by retaliation, Girard argued in *Violence and the Sacred* (1972), the distinctions that structure social order—between ranks, between kin, between the sacred and the profane, between legitimate and illegitimate violence—are progressively eroded by the reciprocity of vengeance, until antagonists become indistinguishable: monstrous doubles, each the mirror of the other's violence. *Mad Max* is a meticulous dramatisation of this erosion, and it announces it in its opening sequence. The first outlaw the film shows us is driving a police car. The Nightrider has seized a Pursuit Special, and he taunts the Patrol across the stolen vehicle's radio with the incantatory self-description—"fuel-injected suicide machine"—that makes

him the first of the saga's self-mythologising madmen. Before the film has introduced its hero, it has placed the law's instrument in the outlaw's hands.

The symmetry is maintained throughout. Officers and outlaws alike wear black leather; both ride high-powered machines with a connoisseur's devotion; both bear nicknames rather than names—Goose, Fifi, the Bronze on one side, Toecutter, Bubba Zanetti, Johnny the Boy on the other; both conduct their violence as spectacle upon the open road. The Patrol's pursuits produce wreckage indistinguishable from the gang's depredations, and its officers' conduct in the courthouse mirrors the gang's conduct in the town. The film's editing reinforces the rhyme, cutting between pursuers and pursued until the eye can no longer sort them. Max's self-diagnosis, examined in the previous chapter—that a little longer on the road will make him a "terminal crazy" distinguished from the gang only by his badge—is the moment at which the double becomes conscious of itself. His resignation is an attempt to step out of the mirror. The film's catastrophe is the demonstration that the attempt is futile: the gang finds him on holiday, and the mirror closes.

Stanley Cohen's analysis of moral panic, introduced in Chapter Two, converges here with Girard's. Cohen drew upon the criminologist Leslie Wilkins's model of deviancy amplification (1964), in which the reaction of a control culture to a deviant group intensifies the deviance it seeks to suppress, which in turn intensifies the reaction, in a spiral that neither party can arrest. The relation between the Patrol and the gang is such a spiral, and its terminus is the identity Girard predicted. By the end of the film the Patrol's most gifted officer is a lone rider in black leather hunting men on the highway—which is to say, a gang of one.

Émile Durkheim supplies a third frame, and a typology that the saga will exhaust. Durkheim's concept of *anomie*—introduced in *The Division of Labour in Society* (1893) and developed in *Suicide* (1897)—named the condition in which social norms lose their regulative hold upon individual desire, leaving appetite without limit and action without measure. *Suicide* distinguished four types: egoistic suicide, born of insufficient integration into society; altruistic suicide, born of excessive integration, of which Durkheim found the modern exemplar in armies; anomic suicide, born of deregulation; and fatalistic suicide, born of oppressive over-regulation, of which the suicides of slaves were his example. The saga distributes these types across its films with almost schematic completeness. The Nightrider, celebrating his own death-drive as a suicide machine, is anomic suicide given a chassis: a desire from which every norm of the road has fallen away. The War Boys of *Fury Road*, ecstatically dying for the warlord who made them, are Durkheim's altruistic suicides, soldiers absorbed so completely into the group that their deaths become its sacrament. The Wives, imprisoned as breeders, inhabit the oppressive over-regulation

that Durkheim associated with fatalistic suicide—a condition Angharad defies, and finally escapes, by exposing her pregnant body to the warlord's guns. And Max himself, through the trilogy's long solitude, approaches the egoistic: the man so detached from every collective that his survival has become indistinguishable from his slow self-extinction. The first film's anomie is the matrix from which all four types descend.

The Girardian reading has one further consequence, which the following sections pursue. A sacrificial crisis, for Girard, cannot be resolved by the victory of one double over the other, since each victory merely renews the reciprocity of violence. It can be resolved only by the convergence of the community's violence upon a single victim—the scapegoat—whose expulsion or death restores the differences the crisis had dissolved. *Mad Max* ends with such a convergence, and with its failure. Before examining that ending, however, it is necessary to look more closely at the gang itself: for the Toecutter's band is not merely the Patrol's double, but a religious community whose cult the saga will spend the next four decades institutionalising.

3.5 The Toecutter's Thiasos: The Gang as Sacral Community

The Toecutter's gang is not merely criminal; it is cultic. Its leader is a performer of sacred speech, delivering his threats in a heightened, quasi-liturgical register that transforms intimidation into ceremony. Its first appearance in the film is a funeral rite. The gang arrives at a country railway station to receive the Nightrider's coffin, and its members comport themselves before the dead man as before a relic, the Toecutter presiding over the remains of the fallen comrade as a priest over a martyr. The gang's subsequent descent upon the town has the structure of a sacral irruption: a band of ecstatics, bound by devotion to a charismatic leader and to the memory of their dead, invading an ordered community and subjecting it to a violence that is as much ritual as instrumental.

The classical prototype of such an irruption is the *thiasos*, the ecstatic retinue of the god Dionysus, and its tragic locus is Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE). In the *Bacchae* the god arrives at Thebes at the head of his followers; the king, Pentheus, who embodies the city's order and its law, resists him; and the play ends with the *sparagmos*, the tearing-apart, of Pentheus by the maenads, his own mother among them. The Toecutter's name names the *sparagmos*: dismemberment as identity. Friedrich Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) framed Greek tragedy as the fusion of two powers—the Apollonian principle of form, measure, and individuation,

and the Dionysian principle of intoxication, dissolution, and collective ecstasy. *Mad Max* sets the two against each other and lets the Dionysian win. The Patrol, with its uniforms, its codes, its radio protocols, and its hierarchy of rank, is an Apollonian order; the gang is Dionysian. But the film's trajectory is not the subjugation of the Dionysian by the Apollonian, as the law-and-order cinema of the decade would have it. It is the absorption of the Apollonian into the Dionysian. Max, the Patrol's best officer, ends the film as a solitary ecstatic of vengeance—the last surviving member of a thiasos whose other members he has killed.

Eric Hobsbawm's *Bandits* (1969) distinguished three types of social bandit: the noble robber, who rights wrongs and takes from the rich; the primitive resistance fighter, who wages irregular war against an oppressive power; and the avenger, whose violence exceeds any instrumental purpose and becomes a public demonstration of terror—a cruelty that announces that the weak, too, can make others tremble. The Australian tradition of the bushranger, whose iconography Chapter Two traced to Nolan's Kelly, had long sentimentalised the first type. The Toecutter's gang belongs unmistakably to the third. Its violence is not appropriation but display: it takes nothing from the town that it needs, and everything from it that it can spoil. And by the logic of the double, Max becomes an avenger in Hobsbawm's sense in the film's final act. His killings, too, are demonstrations as much as punishments—messages addressed to no one, since no one is left to receive them.

The gang's deepest significance for the saga, however, lies in what it will become. Max Weber, in *Economy and Society* (1922), described charismatic authority as inherently unstable: an authority grounded in the extraordinary qualities of a leader and the emotional devotion of his followers, which cannot survive its founder unless it is routinised into traditional or bureaucratic forms. The Toecutter is the charismatic leader of an emotional community. Thirty-six years later, the same actor, Hugh Keays-Byrne, would play Immortan Joe, the sovereign of *Fury Road*: a ruler whose War Boys are a Dionysian thiasos institutionalised as an army, whose cult of the dead comrade has become a state religion of Valhalla, and whose ecstatic violence has been routinised into a dynasty with heirs, a court, a priesthood of mechanics, and a hydraulic economy. The casting is the saga's most profound structural rhyme. The cult that Max destroyed in 1979 returns in 2015 as the State. The Fury released by the first film's vendetta becomes the matrix of the tyranny that the later films must overthrow; the gang becomes the Citadel; and the actor who began as the Toecutter ends as the Immortan—the dismemberer become the undying.

The rhyme has a further implication for the thesis's Oresteian reading. In Aeschylus the curse of the house of Atreus does not end with the death of any individual; it ends only when its energies are transformed by the institution of the court. In the

saga, the destruction of the Toecutter's gang ends nothing. Its energies—the cult of speed, the veneration of the dead, the ecstasy of violence, the charisma of the speaker—migrate, survive, and eventually reconstitute themselves as sovereignty. Vengeance does not consume the Fury; it propagates it. The lesson the first film teaches without stating, and the later films state without ceasing, is that the Erinyic economy cannot be ended by victory, only by conversion.

3.6 "Hieronymo's Mad Againe": The Officer as Revenger

The figure of an officer of justice who becomes an avenger when justice fails him has a precise genealogy in European drama, and its source is the house of Atreus. Seneca's *Thyestes*, the Roman tragedy of Atreus's cannibal banquet—the crime from which the curse of the *Oresteia* descends—was translated into English by Jasper Heywood in 1560 and gathered with the other Senecan tragedies in 1581, and it furnished the Elizabethan stage with the model of revenge tragedy whose history Fredson Bowers traced in *Elizabethan Revenge Tragedy, 1587–1642* (1940). The genre's founding play is Thomas Kyd's *The Spanish Tragedy* (c. 1587). Its protagonist, Hieronimo, is Knight Marshal of Spain, an officer charged with the administration of justice, whose son is murdered and hanged in his own garden. Denied redress by a court whose king is distracted and whose murderers are noble, Hieronimo goes mad, and achieves his revenge through a play-within-the-play in which the killing is performed as theatre; at its end he bites out his own tongue.

Hieronimo is Max's Elizabethan ancestor in every structural particular: the officer of law who cannot obtain from the law the justice his office exists to provide; the murdered child; the madness that is both the price and the instrument of vengeance; the vengeance staged as spectacle. The kinship is sealed by a title. The edition of 1615 called the play *The Spanish Tragedie: or, Hieronimo is Mad Againe*—a subtitle that could serve, unaltered, for the saga, whose hero is mad again in every film. And the line passes, by a route that seems almost too apt to be accidental, through the poem that named the saga's world. T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land* (1922) ends among the ruins of a civilisation, with fragments shored against them, and among its last lines is Kyd's: "Why then Ile fit you. Hieronymo's mad againe." The madman of the revenge tragedy is the last voice of the European tradition that Eliot's Waste Land allows to speak before its closing words of Sanskrit benediction. Max is Hieronymo, mad again, in the Waste Land.

Eliot's final section is titled "What the Thunder Said," and its thunder speaks three injunctions drawn from the *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad*: *datta*, *dayadhvam*,

damyata—give, sympathise, control. The resonance with the saga's third film will be developed in Chapter Four, where the thunder of Bartertown's arena commands not giving, sympathy, and self-control but combat to the death, and where Max, refusing to kill a defeated opponent, obeys Eliot's thunder rather than Aunty Entity's and is exiled for it. For the present it suffices to note that the revenge tradition contained, from the beginning, its own critique. Bacon's essay on revenge ends with an observation that the saga would spend forty-five years dramatising: "This is certain, that a man that studieth revenge keeps his own wounds green, which otherwise would heal and do well." Max's wounds stay green. He carries the brace upon his injured leg into the second film, and the faces of the dead into the fourth.

The revenge tragedy is also, structurally, a tragedy of the theatre. Hieronimo's vengeance is consummated as a performance; Hamlet's is prepared by one; the revenger of the Jacobean stage is a dramatist of death, who must stage his justice because no institution will stage it for him. *Mad Max* inherits the theatricality. Max's final act is composed as a scene: the chain, the fuse, the saw, the speech that sets out the terms, the exit, the explosion—a miniature tragedy whose author, director, and sole spectator is the avenger himself. The theatricality of revenge is the symptom of law's absence. Where courts no longer stage the drama of justice before a public, the revenger stages it before himself, and the audience is reduced to one.

Susan Jacoby's *Wild Justice* (1983), a history of revenge that takes its title from Bacon, argued that the impulse to retaliate is not an aberration that civilised law abolishes but a fundamental human drive that law exists to channel—to satisfy in regulated form and thereby to contain. Her reading of the legal order is, in its deepest structure, Eumenidean. Law does not destroy the Furies; it houses them, honours them, and puts them to work. The tragedy of *Mad Max* is the tragedy of a world in which the house has fallen and the Furies have gone back out onto the road.

The Matricidal Foundation: Jessie, Sprog, and May Swaisey 3.7

Between the burning of Goose and the destruction of Max's family the film pauses for an interlude of almost pastoral calm. Max, Jessie, and their infant son leave the city for the coast: a beach, a farmhouse, a mechanic's yard, the sea. Jessie plays the saxophone; the child plays in the sand; the domestic world, for a few minutes of screen time, exists without engines. Leo Marx's *The Machine in the Garden* (1964) identified as a recurrent figure of the American literary imagination the moment at which the pastoral idyll is interrupted by the machine—the whistle of the loco-

motive breaking the stillness of Hawthorne's Sleepy Hollow. *Mad Max* stages that interruption as an invasion. The gang finds Jessie at a seaside kiosk, pursues her along the coast, and descends upon the refuge she finds; the roar of their engines enters the garden. The interlude is the first film's Green Place: a fragile remnant of a habitable world, located, like the later films' lost paradise, at the margins of the road, and destroyed by the instruments of the road.

The destruction is the film's founding catastrophe, and it is a destruction of mother and child. The gang runs Jessie and Sprog down on the highway; the child dies, and the mother is left broken. Luce Irigaray's argument, introduced in Chapter One, that Western culture is founded upon a matricide it has never ceased to repress, finds here a literalisation as exact as any in modern cinema: the world of the saga is founded upon the murder, on the road, of a mother and her child. But the film's relation to the *Oresteia* is, at this point, inverted with a precision worth stating carefully. In Aeschylus the matricide is committed by the son, in the name of the father, and it is the Furies who rise to avenge the mother. In *Mad Max* the mother is destroyed by the road and its riders, and it is Max who rises to avenge her. Max, in the first film, is not Orestes but the Erinys: the avenger of the murdered mother, hunting her killers across the land. Only in the later films, haunted and himself hunted, will he come to occupy the position of Orestes. The saga's protagonist thus passes through both positions of the Oresteian drama—first the Fury, then the pursued—before the Fury's role passes, in *Fury Road*, to the woman who bears its name.

The film's women are otherwise victims or guardians, and its narrative economy has justly been criticised for instrumentalising their suffering as the motive of male action—the device the comics writer Gail Simone would name in 1999 "women in refrigerators," the killing or maiming of a hero's partner to supply him with a cause. The first film is a canonical instance of the trope, and *Fury Road* is, among other things, its systematic reversal: a film in which the women are the agents of the plot and the man its auxiliary, and in which the death of a pregnant woman supplies not a man's motive but the women's grief, shared and borne collectively. Yet the first film also contains, in embryo, the figure through which that reversal will be accomplished. When Jessie flees the gang she takes refuge at the farm of May Swaisey, an elderly woman who confronts the gang with a shotgun. May is the first of the saga's armed old women: the ancestor of the Vuvalini, the Many Mothers who ride out of the desert in *Fury Road* with rifles at the ready, and of their Keeper of the Seeds, who carries both a rifle and a bag of seeds and speaks with equal composure of killing and of planting.

The counter-*Eumenides* of 2015 is thus latent in the farmhouse of 1979: an old woman, a gun, a fleeing mother, a garden under siege. What the first film cannot yet

imagine is that such figures might be the agents rather than the episodes of the story—that the old woman at the farmhouse door might be not a temporary refuge on the avenger's road but the custodian of the only future the road has not destroyed. The saga will take thirty-six years to move May Swaisey from the margin of its frame to its centre. The movement is, in miniature, the whole of the Eumenidean turn: the passage from a story in which women are what the Furies avenge to a story in which women are what the Furies become.

3.8 Becoming-Fury: Lameness, the Hound, and the Lex Talionis

Max's transformation into the avenger is marked upon his body. Hunting the gang, he is shot in the leg and his arm is crushed beneath a motorcycle wheel; he finishes the film limping, and he enters the second film with a brace upon his knee. The wound is mythically legible. In his structural analysis of the Oedipus myth, Lévi-Strauss observed that the names of the Labdacid line—Labdacus, "lame"; Laius, "left-sided"; Oedipus, "swollen-foot"—share a reference to difficulty in walking straight, which he connected to a widespread mythic association between lameness and autochthony: beings born from the earth, in myth, often emerge from it unable to walk properly. Lameness marks the chthonic. Max's limp is the bodily signature of his becoming-chthonic: the officer of the Apollonian Patrol transformed into a creature of the powers below.

Those powers have, in Aeschylus, a canine form. At the close of *The Libation Bearers*, Orestes, who alone can see them, cries out that the Furies are his mother's wrathful hounds; in the *Eumenides* they track him by the scent of blood across land and sea. The Erinys is a hound. In *Mad Max 2*, Max travels with a dog, and in one of the film's most memorable images eats dog food from a tin, sharing the animal's rations. The image is usually read as a sign of degradation, the hero reduced to animality. It is more exactly a sign of metamorphosis. Max has become what Aeschylus's Furies were: a creature of scent and pursuit, a hound of vengeance whose hunt has outlived its quarry.

The film's final scene makes the metamorphosis legible as law. Max finds Johnny the Boy—the youngest, weakest, and most coerced member of the gang, the one the Toecutter forced to burn Goose—stripping the corpse of a crash victim. He handcuffs Johnny's ankle to the wreck, rigs a crude fuse of leaking petrol and a lit lighter, and hands him a hacksaw: the chain, Max tells him, would take ten minutes to cut through, the ankle perhaps five. Then he drives away, and the wreck explodes

behind him. The punishment is the oldest formula of retributive justice executed to the letter. The covenant code of Exodus prescribes it: "Eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot, burning for burning, wound for wound, stripe for stripe" (Exodus 21:24–25). Goose was burned; Johnny will burn. The gang was led by a man named for the severing of feet; Johnny must sever his own. *Foot for foot, burning for burning*: the film ends with the *lex talionis* performed as a literal rite.

The talion was, in its ancient context, a principle of limitation. The laws of Hammurabi and the Mosaic covenant alike sought to confine retribution to the measure of the injury, against the escalating logic of the blood-feud. Max's talion keeps the measure and abandons the limit. Its proportion is exact and its spirit is boundless, for it delegates the execution to the condemned and turns punishment into a theatre of choice—an ordeal in which the victim must elect his own mutilation. The structure would be recognised a quarter-century later in *Saw* (2004), made by two filmmakers who had met as students in Melbourne, whose premise of a captive chained by the ankle and offered a hacksaw elaborates the scene into a franchise. Whether by direct influence or by the logic of a shared culture, the hacksaw ordeal entered the international repertoire of cinematic cruelty from a road outside Melbourne.

Johnny is, moreover, a scapegoat in Girard's strict sense. The scapegoat, Girard argued, is selected not for guilt but for marginality: the weakest and most isolated member of the group, whose destruction will provoke no further vengeance. The Toecutter, the gang's sovereign, dies an impersonal death beneath the wheels of an oncoming truck, his eyes widening in the film's signature close-up; it is the coerced, frightened, marginal Johnny who receives the ritual punishment. Yet the mechanism fails. A scapegoat's death restores peace to a community, and Max has no community left to restore. He drives away alone, polluted rather than purified. Robert Parker's *Miasma* (1983) reconstructed the Greek conception of the pollution that attaches to the shedder of blood and excludes him from the community until he has been cleansed. Orestes is purified at Delphi—with the blood of slaughtered swine, as he tells Athena—before he can be tried at Athens. Max will seek purification through two films and find it in neither; and Chapter Four will find him, in Bartertown, condemned to an underworld of pigs.

Max does not look back. As the wreck explodes behind him, he drives toward the horizon without turning his head. The gesture invites the comparison to which this thesis has already alluded: Lot's wife, who looks back at the burning cities of the plain and becomes a pillar of salt. Max, refusing to look back, escapes petrification of that kind, but only by suffering another. His refusal is a refusal of memory, of mourning, and of the dead, and the faces he will not turn to see are the faces that will return, in *Fury Road*, to haunt him. The saga will reverse the gesture thirty-six years

later, on the salt flats, when Max for the first time counsels a company of fugitives to turn back—and the turning back is not petrification but life.

"Give 'Em Back Their Heroes": Hero-Production and the Exhausted State 3.9

In the course of persuading Max to remain with the Patrol, Fifi Macaffee explains why he is needed. The people, Fifi complains, no longer believe in heroes; and he and Max, he declares, are going to "give 'em back their heroes." The speech is played as bluster, and it is the most politically lucid statement in the film. A state that can no longer secure obedience by force or by legitimacy turns to the production of heroes —to spectacle, charisma, and legend—as the last resource of authority. Thomas Carlyle's *On Heroes, Hero-Worship, and the Heroic in History* (1841) had made hero-worship the foundation of social order and history the biography of great men; Fifi is a Carlylean in leather, and his project is to restore the Patrol's legitimacy by manufacturing a legend. The Interceptor is that project's instrument, as hollow as its supercharger: an icon of power whose power is theatrical, offered to an icon of heroism whose heroism the state requires for display.

The counter-statement belongs to Bertolt Brecht. In *Life of Galileo*, when the scientist's disappointed pupil laments the unhappiness of a land that breeds no heroes, Galileo answers that the unhappy land is the one that is "in need of heroes." The saga's trajectory over four decades is the passage from Fifi to Galileo. Its third film made the passage audible: the theme song of *Beyond Thunderdome*, sung by Tina Turner, who played the film's sovereign, announces in its title that we don't need another hero. *Fury Road* made it structural, displacing the hero from the centre of his own legend and withholding even his name until the end, when he speaks it once and disappears into the crowd. And *Furiosa* completed it, reducing the eponymous hero of the saga to a figure glimpsed at the edge of another person's story.

Fifi's project is nonetheless realised—not by the state but by the community, and not in life but in memory. The first words of *Mad Max 2* belong to a narrator recalling "the man we called Max": the hero has been given back to the people, as Fifi wished, but as a story told by those he saved and could not join. The legend replaces the law. This substitution is the first film's legacy to the saga. A world in which the law has exhausted itself upon the road leaves behind not a new law but a myth, and the myth becomes the only form in which justice can be remembered. It is no accident that every subsequent film is framed by a teller of tales—the Feral Kid, Savannah Nix, the First History Man, the History Man—since the teller is the

institution that survives the court. Where the Areopagus has fallen, the storyteller sits in judgement, and the sentence is a story.

The chapter's findings may be gathered briefly. *Mad Max* stages the curse of the house of Atreus as a curse of infrastructure, borne not by blood but by the road. It depicts the law not as absent but as exhausted, split into a juridical form without force and a force without juridical form, and it thereby supplies the first and most precise image of the post-nomic condition. It dramatises the Girardian crisis of distinctions in which the Patrol and the gang become doubles, and it presents the gang as a Dionysian cult whose energies, propagated rather than consumed by vengeance, will return as the Citadel. It inherits from Seneca, Kyd, and Eliot the figure of the officer turned revenger, mad again in the Waste Land. It founds the saga upon the destruction of a mother and child, and it makes its hero, at first, not Orestes but the Fury who avenges the mother. And it ends with the *lex talionis* executed as rite, a scapegoat destroyed without a community to purify, and an avenger departing polluted into a world that has no court to receive him.

Friedrich Nietzsche's Zarathustra, preaching against the tarantulas of revenge, declared that the deliverance of humankind from revenge was for him the bridge to the highest hope. *Mad Max* ends at the furthest point from that bridge: vengeance consummated, the avenger alone, the road empty, the Furies loosed upon the land. The saga will spend the next forty-five years building toward the bridge, and it will reach it in *Furiosa*, in a chapter whose very title is "Beyond Vengeance," and in a peach stone planted in a tyrant's flesh. But the bridge cannot be built from the first film's materials. The law is exhausted; the Fury is born; and the world into which she is born must first be consumed by fire. The next chapter enters that world.

IV

CHAPTER FOUR

The Economy of Fire

Petro-Sovereignty, Barter, and the Scapegoat in Mad Max 2 *and* Beyond Thunderdome

The Petro-Eschaton: The Prologue as Scripture 4.1

If *Mad Max* is a film of process, *Mad Max 2* is a film of aftermath. Its opening minutes supply what the first film withheld: a cosmogony in reverse. Over grainy newsreel images of twentieth-century war, mass mobilisation, and civil disorder, an aged narrator recounts the end of the old world—how, for reasons long forgotten, two warrior tribes went to war over the fuel upon which everything depended; how, without fuel, the cities exploded; how the world dissolved into a contest of gangs for what remained. The prologue is the saga's first scripture. It converts the immanent apocalypse of the first film into a past event with a cause, a sequence, and a moral, and it names that cause with an explicitness the later films never surpass: the world ended because it ran short of what it burned. This is the petro-eschaton—the end of time conceived as the end of oil.

The mode of the prologue is significant. Eschatology, in the Jewish and Christian traditions, is prophecy: the End is foretold before it comes. The prologue of *Mad Max 2* is retrospective—an eschatology narrated after the End, by a survivor who has lived on into a world without the fuel that defined the old one. It belongs to a genre that Herman Melville's Ishmael inaugurated for the age of oil. *Moby-Dick* (1851) closes with an epilogue whose epigraph is the messenger's formula from the Book of Job: "And I only am escaped alone to tell thee." The narrator of *Mad Max 2* is not the only survivor, but he is the teller, and like Ishmael he speaks from the far side of a catastrophe whose central figure he witnessed and never fully understood. The analogy is closer than it first appears, since *Moby-Dick* is itself an epic of the oil economy, as section 4.3 will argue.

The narrator is, moreover, a figure of remarkable doubleness. Within the film's action he is the Feral Kid: a mute child who growls rather than speaks, who lives at the margins of the besieged compound, and who fights with a razor-edged steel boomerang. The saga's first legend-maker is a child without language, a wild child in the lineage of Victor of Aveyron, whose education Jean Itard recorded in his reports of 1801 and 1806 and François Truffaut filmed as *L'Enfant sauvage* (1970). The voice that frames the legend belongs to one who, when its events occurred, had no voice at all. Myth begins in muteness: the witness who could not speak becomes, decades later, the one who speaks for all.

The boomerang carries a further charge. An instrument of Aboriginal Australian technology in the hand of a white child gone wild, it marks the Feral Kid as the bearer of a fantasy that Terry Goldie, in *Fear and Temptation* (1989), identified as central to the literatures of settler societies: indigenisation, the settler's desire to become native to the land his culture has seized, in the absence of the people who were native to it. The saga's first narrator is a white child holding an Aboriginal weapon in a desert from which Aboriginal people have been erased. The fantasy will recur, in a more elaborate form, among the Lost Tribe of *Beyond Thunderdome*.

The prologue's newsreel images—drawn from the archival record of the century's wars—perform the operation that Chapter One attributed to the saga as a whole: they convert history into myth. The documented catastrophes of the twentieth century become the prehistory of a legend; the newsreel becomes scripture. In the same gesture the prologue introduces Max not as a person but as a type—"the road warrior," the burnt-out wanderer of the highways—and introduces his past, the destruction of his family, as the backstory of a legend rather than the plot of a film. The first film's Fury has become the second film's myth. What remains to be seen is what the myth does when it enters a world organised wholly around fuel.

4.2 The Refinery Besieged: Petro-Sovereignty and the Protection Racket

The world Max enters is organised around a single installation: a makeshift refinery in the desert, pumping and processing crude, defended by a community of settlers under the leadership of Pappagallo and besieged by a horde of marauders under a masked warlord styled the Lord Humungus. The settlers plan to escape with their fuel to a distant coast; the Humungus offers them safe passage in exchange for the refinery and its contents. The plot is a siege, and its political geometry is that of chthonopolitics in its purest form. Everything turns upon the control of a flow from

beneath the ground. Sovereignty in this world is not the possession of territory—the desert is everywhere and worthless—but the command of a well.

Timothy Mitchell's *Carbon Democracy* (2011) argued that the shift from coal to oil transformed the politics of the twentieth century by altering the points at which energy flows could be interrupted. Coal was mined, hauled, and shovelled by concentrated masses of workers who could halt its flow by striking; oil flows through pipelines and tankers operated by few hands, and its chokepoints are commanded by those who control the wells, the pipelines, and the sea lanes. The siege of the refinery is a chokepoint war. The compound's gate, the tanker that alone can carry its product, and the road that alone leads north are the points at which the flow can be captured or interrupted, and every action in the film is directed at one of them.

The Humungus is a petro-sovereign in embryo. His herald introduces him over a loudspeaker with a string of titles that culminates in the most topical joke in the saga: he is "the Ayatollah of Rock and Rolla." The film was made in the wake of the Iranian Revolution that had triggered the second oil shock, and the epithet fuses, in a single carnival title, the three forces that Chapter Two found converging in 1979: oil, religious charisma, and spectacle. In the vocabulary of Deleuze and Guattari's "Treatise on Nomadology" (1980), the horde is a nomadic war machine that seeks not to destroy the sedentary installation but to capture it—the moment at which the war machine begins to become a State. And the Humungus's offer to the settlers has precisely the structure that the historical sociologist Charles Tilly, in "War Making and State Making as Organized Crime" (1985), identified at the origin of the European state: a protection racket. The racketeer offers protection against a danger that he himself creates; the early state, Tilly argued, did the same, extracting tribute in exchange for security against violence, much of which it supplied. The Humungus offers the settlers their lives in exchange for their fuel—protection from his own horde. He is a state in the larval stage: a racket that has not yet acquired the territory, the bureaucracy, and the theology that will, in Immortan Joe, complete its metamorphosis.

The siege also restages, in mythic form, the end of a cultural moment. The settlers dress predominantly in white and pale fabrics and are organised as a commune around shared labour and an idealistic leader whose name—Pappagallo, Italian for "parrot"—marks him as a speaker of ideals. The horde is clad in black leather, studs, and fetish gear whose iconography descends from the biker imagery that Kenneth Anger's *Scorpio Rising* (1963) had fused with homoeroticism, ritual, and death. The image of a white-clad commune besieged by leather-clad riders recalls the event that, for many contemporaries, marked the end of the countercultural decade: the free concert at Altamont in December 1969, at which members of the Hells Angels,

engaged as security, beat concertgoers and at which a young Black man, Meredith Hunter, was stabbed to death—an event recorded in Albert and David Maysles's *Gimme Shelter* (1970). *Mad Max 2* is a post-Altamont fable. The commune's idealism cannot survive the bikers without the help of a man who believes in nothing, and even with his help its leader dies. The saga's first utopian community is not destroyed, but it must flee, deceive, and sacrifice in order to survive.

Two figures among the settlers and their allies deserve particular notice, since they anticipate the saga's late transformation. The first is the Warrior Woman, a fighter in the commune's defence who rides into the final battle and dies in it: the saga's first female warrior, and the precursor, thirty-four years early, of Furiosa. The second is the Gyro Captain, a scavenging aviator who first tries to rob Max, guards his flying machine with a snake, guides Max to the compound in exchange for his life, harries the horde from the air in the final chase, and at the end leads the survivors north. He is the saga's Hermes: thief, messenger, guide, and god of boundaries and commerce, crossing between earth and air, between horde and commune, between death and survival. The actor who plays him, Bruce Spence, returns in *Beyond Thunderdome* as Jedediah, another airborne thief who steals from Max at the film's opening and rescues the lost children at its close, carrying them by air to the ruined city—Hermes again, now as psychopomp, the guide of souls to the other world. The saga's aerial figures are its mediators. Where Max moves only along the ground, they move above it, and it is through them that communities cross over.

4.3 Expenditure Without Reserve: Bataille, Melville, and the Tanker of Sand

The climactic chase of *Mad Max 2* is among the most celebrated sequences in action cinema, and its economy is paradoxical. The horde pursues the tanker in order to capture its fuel, and the pursuit consumes fuel, vehicles, and lives at a rate that makes the prize almost irrelevant. Cars are rammed, overturned, incinerated; riders are thrown beneath wheels; the Humungus himself dies in a head-on collision with the tanker he covets. The chase is the expenditure of what it seeks to acquire. Georges Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) explained such paradoxes as expressions of a general economy that the restricted economy of utility and scarcity cannot comprehend. Every living system, Bataille argued, receives from the sun more energy than it can use for its growth; the surplus—the accursed share—must be spent, and it can be spent gloriously, in sacrifice, festival, art, and gift, or catastrophically, in war. Marcel Mauss's *The Gift* (1925) had described the potlatch of the Pacific Northwest,

in which chiefs destroyed wealth in agonistic displays of prestige; for Bataille the potlatch revealed the truth of all economies, that their final aim is not accumulation but consumption, and that the only question is whether consumption takes a sovereign or a catastrophic form. The fuel war is a potlatch in its catastrophic form: a contest in which the parties prove their power by destroying, at speed, what they claim to be fighting for.

Fossil fuel is, in Bataille's terms, the accursed share par excellence: an immense surplus of ancient solar energy, accumulated over geological time and released, within two centuries, into human hands that have found no sovereign way to spend it. The prologue's war over fuel is the catastrophic expenditure of that surplus at the scale of a civilisation; the chase is the same expenditure at the scale of a convoy. The saga thereby states in images what the energy humanities would later state in theory: that the problem of fossil energy is not only its scarcity but its excess—an excess that, lacking any glorious form of expenditure, has spent itself in speed, in war, and in the heating of the world. Paul Thomas Anderson's *There Will Be Blood* (2007), whose title is commonly traced to the plague of blood in Exodus, would later make the equation of oil and blood its organising conceit; its oilman's boast that he has drained the oil from beneath his neighbour's land—"I drink your milkshake"—renders extraction as the drinking of a fluid that belongs to the ground, the gesture that Immortan Joe will perform upon the aquifer beneath the Citadel.

The nineteenth century had already produced an epic of this economy, and it is *Moby-Dick*. Melville's novel is, among other things, an encyclopaedia of the whale-oil industry that lit the cities of the industrial world before petroleum: the *Pequod* is a floating factory, and in the chapter called "The Try-Works" Ishmael describes the furnaces in which blubber is rendered into oil at night as a vision of hell—the ship rushing through the darkness, laden with fire, its furnaces fed with the scraps of the very creature whose body they consume. "Like a plethoric burning martyr, or a self-consuming misanthrope," Ishmael observes, "once ignited, the whale supplies his own fuel and burns by his own body." No sentence in the nineteenth century describes more exactly the self-consuming logic of the combustion economy. And the *Pequod*'s captain is the first great figure of the Erinyic economy. Ahab subordinates the ship's commercial purpose to his private fury against the whale that took his leg—lame, like Max, and like the Labdacids of Lévi-Strauss's analysis—and drives the oil-vessel, its crew, and himself to destruction in pursuit of a vengeance that his mate Starbuck calls blasphemous, since its object is a dumb brute. *Moby-Dick* fuses in a single ship the oil economy and the vengeance economy that the saga will fuse on the road.

The difference is instructive. In *Mad Max 2*, Max has outlived his vengeance. He is a Fury without a quarry, a burnt-out avenger who drives the tanker not for revenge but for the fuel he has been promised. The vengeance economy has exhausted itself in him, leaving only the oil economy—and he discovers, at the end of the chase, that he was not even carrying oil. When the tanker overturns, killing the Humungus and his lieutenant Wez, and Max crawls from the wreck, he sees sand pouring from the ruptured tank. The settlers' fuel was never in it; it travelled in drums in the vehicles that broke away from the convoy and headed north while the horde pursued the tanker. Max had been the decoy, and no one had told him. The revelation is the hinge of the film and of the saga's understanding of its hero. Max has performed the redemptive act of the American monomyth—the outsider saving the community—only to discover that the community had instrumentalised him as a scapegoat in the Levitical sense: the creature sent into the wilderness bearing what the community needed to be rid of, in this case the pursuit itself. The community survives because the predators follow the decoy. Max carries the desert; the community carries the fire.

The tanker of sand is also an image of the entropic condition examined in Chapter One: a vessel built to carry concentrated energy, filled instead with the material of maximal dispersal. And it inaugurates a motif that the saga will complete. In 1981 the great vessel at the centre of the chase is a decoy, empty of what it appears to contain. In 2015 the great vessel at the centre of the chase—the War Rig—is full: it carries fuel, water, and mother's milk, and hidden within it are the Wives, the women whose bodies are the Citadel's future. The movement from the empty tanker to the full one is the movement, in Le Guin's terms, from the spear to the carrier bag: from the hero's sacrifice to the community's vessel. In *Mad Max 2* the vessel is a lie told to the predators; in *Fury Road* it is the womb of a new world.

4.4 Bartertown: The Myth of Barter Inverted

Beyond Thunderdome moves from the siege of a well to the founding of a city. Max, robbed of his wagon by an airborne thief, follows the tracks to Bartertown: a walled trading post in the desert that has grown into a market town, governed by Aunty Entity, who presents it as the first civilisation to rise from the ruins. Entry requires something to trade; the town's law is the law of contract; and its sovereign tells Max, in a moment of rare candour, that before the collapse she had been nobody, and that the catastrophe gave her the chance to become somebody. Bartertown is the saga's first city, and it is founded not on fuel or water but on exchange.

Its founding principle is one of the oldest myths of political economy. Adam Smith, in *The Wealth of Nations* (1776), located the origin of the division of labour in a human "propensity to truck, barter, and exchange one thing for another," and the textbooks that followed told a story of origins in which a primitive economy of barter, hampered by the need for a double coincidence of wants, gave rise to money as a medium of exchange. David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) demolished the story. No society, Graeber showed, has ever been observed to organise its economy around barter; the anthropologist Caroline Humphrey had concluded, in "Barter and Economic Disintegration" (1985), that no pure barter economy has ever been described, let alone the emergence of money from one. Barter, the ethnographic record shows, occurs between strangers, across borders, and above all in the aftermath of monetary collapse—in the cigarette economy of the prisoner-of-war camp that R. A. Radford described in 1945, or in economies whose currencies have failed. Humphrey's essay appeared in the year of *Beyond Thunderdome*, and the film's insight is the same as hers. Bartertown is not the beginning of economic history but its end-state. It stages the economists' myth of origins as a myth of ends: not the cradle from which money will emerge, but the ruin into which money has collapsed.

The law that governs Bartertown is the law of the broken contract, and it is enforced with a cruelty that Friedrich Nietzsche would have recognised. "Bust a deal, face the wheel": whoever breaks an agreement must submit to the spin of a great wheel whose segments assign the penalty. In the second essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887), Nietzsche argued that the concept of guilt (*Schuld*) descends from the material concept of debt (*Schulden*), and that the earliest form of justice was the creditor's right to compensate himself for an unpaid debt by inflicting suffering upon the debtor. He cited the Roman Twelve Tables, which permitted creditors to cut flesh from the body of a defaulting debtor, and found in the creditor's pleasure in cruelty the hidden root of punishment. Shakespeare's Shylock, demanding his pound of flesh under the terms of a bond, is the literary emblem of this law. Bartertown's justice is Nietzschean throughout: the contract is enforced upon the body, and the enforcement is a public pleasure.

The wheel adds a medieval term to the modern contract. Fortune's wheel, the emblem of the arbitrariness of worldly power, received its classic philosophical treatment in Boethius's *Consolation of Philosophy* (c. 524), written in prison as its author awaited execution, and it presided over the medieval imagination of history as a cycle in which kings rise and fall at the turn of a goddess's hand. Bartertown fuses the two: the most modern form of law, the enforcement of contract, is administered by the most ancient image of chance. The fusion is a satire upon the market's

self-understanding. The invisible hand, which in Smith's metaphor converts private interest into public good without anyone's intention, is made visible as a spinning wheel—and its operation is revealed as what it always partly was: a lottery of fates administered by a sovereign who profits from the spectacle.

Aunty Entity's name carries a further charge. In Australian English, and above all in Aboriginal English, "Aunty" is a title of respect conferred upon a female elder. The film confers it upon the sovereign of a market town in a desert from which Aboriginal people are absent, played by an African American superstar whose casting makes her the only Black lead in the saga's first three films. Whatever its intention, the naming performs a characteristic displacement: a title of Indigenous female authority detached from Indigenous women and attached to a figure of global celebrity. And yet Aunty is the most morally complex sovereign the saga produces before Furiosa. She builds; she legislates; she institutionalises violence in order to contain it; and in the film's final scene, having pursued Max across the desert, she spares him, acknowledging with a laugh the kinship of two survivors: "Well, ain't we a pair, raggedy man." She is, as section 4.6 will argue, the saga's Athena manquée—the founder of a city and a court who cannot yet persuade the Furies, but who in the end chooses mercy over the law she made.

4.5 The Underworld: Nibelheim and the Thesmophorion

Bartertown's power comes from below. Beneath the market lies the Underworld, a subterranean works in which pigs are kept in their hundreds, their manure collected and processed into methane, and the methane burned to light and power the town above. The Underworld is ruled by Master Blaster—a composite sovereign formed by Master, a dwarf engineer of formidable intelligence, riding upon the shoulders of Blaster, a giant of enormous strength whose face is concealed by a helmet. Master's control of the energy supply makes him the rival of Aunty's political authority, and he demonstrates the fact by imposing an "embargo": cutting the town's power until Aunty publicly concedes, over the loudspeakers, that Master Blaster runs Bartertown. The scene is the saga's most direct restaging of the oil shock. An energy producer cuts supply to extract a political concession from the consuming polity; the embargo of October 1973, which made the producer states of the Gulf arbiters of Western politics, is replayed as a farce of humiliation in a desert town.

The composite figure literalises the most famous dialectic of modern philosophy. In the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), Hegel described the struggle of self-consciousnesses that issues in the relation of lord and bondsman: the lord, having

risked his life, commands; the bondsman, having feared death, labours. But the lord's independence is illusory, since he depends upon the bondsman's labour for everything he enjoys, while the bondsman, through labour, forms both the world and himself. The truth of the lord is the bondsman. Master Blaster is Hegel's dialectic given a single body—the head that commands and the body that labours, the intellect that rules and the strength that serves—and the film enacts the dialectic's reversal. When Blaster is killed after the combat in Thunderdome, Master is exposed as wholly dependent upon him: a mind without a body, reduced at a stroke from sovereign to prisoner and set to labour among the pigs he once commanded.

The bodies of Master and Blaster belong, too, to the saga's long meditation on disability, which descends from the lame Hephaestus of Chapter Two and culminates in Furiosa's prosthetic arm. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's *Extraordinary Bodies* (1997) analysed the cultural history of the display of non-normative bodies, from the freak show to the literary text, as a means by which a normative culture defines itself against the bodies it exhibits. Thunderdome is such a display, and the revelation beneath Blaster's helmet—a gentle, frightened face that the film presents as belonging to a man with the mind of a child—is the moment at which the spectacle of the extraordinary body collapses into the recognition of a vulnerable person. That recognition is the subject of section 4.6.

The Underworld has a mythic genealogy of unusual precision. In Richard Wagner's *Der Ring des Nibelungen*, first performed complete in 1876, the dwarf Alberich steals the gold of the Rhine, renounces love in order to forge from it a ring of world-dominion, and enslaves his fellow Nibelungs to mine and smith beneath the earth in Nibelheim. George Bernard Shaw's *The Perfect Wagnerite* (1898) read the cycle as an allegory of industrial capitalism, with Alberich as the capitalist who renounces love for gold, Nibelheim as a factory of sweated labour, and the ring as the power of accumulated capital. Master is Alberich: the dwarf who commands the underground source of energy, compels the labour of others, and uses his monopoly to dominate the world above. And the *Ring* offers the saga more than a figure. It is the nineteenth century's great myth of extraction and its consequences. It begins with the theft of treasure from a river and ends, in *Götterdämmerung*, with Valhalla in flames and the Rhine overflowing its banks to reclaim the ring. The theft from nature is undone only by a world-fire and a flood that return the stolen treasure to its element. Chapter Five will find Valhalla again, promised by Immortan Joe to his dying War Boys, and will read the release of the Citadel's waters as the saga's *Götterdämmerung*.

A second genealogy is older still, and it concerns the pigs. The swine was, in Greek religion, the sacrificial animal of the chthonic and agrarian powers, above all

of Demeter. At the Eleusinian Mysteries each initiate bathed a piglet in the sea before its sacrifice; at Delphi, as Chapter Three noted, Orestes was purified of his mother's blood with the blood of slaughtered swine. Most remarkable of all was the Thesmophoria, the autumn festival of Demeter celebrated by women alone. According to an ancient scholium on Lucian, piglets were cast into subterranean pits, the *megara*, and left to rot; later in the festival, women designated as "bailers" descended into the pits, brought up the decomposed remains, and laid them upon altars, whence they were mixed with the seed-grain for the coming sowing to ensure the fertility of the fields. Walter Burkert's *Greek Religion* (1977) and Marcel Detienne's study of the festival's gendered violence (1979) reconstructed the rite's logic: the rotting of the sacrificed animal in the earth is converted, by the hands of women, into the fertility of seed. The Thesmophoria is the ritual form of what this thesis has called the humic-chthonic—decomposition in the underworld made the source of life above.

Bartertown's Underworld is a Thesmophorion inverted. Its materials are the same—pigs, decay, an underground chamber—but their purpose is reversed. The decomposition of the pigs' waste in the dark is converted not into seed but into fuel; its product is not fertility but combustion; and its rite is administered not by women for the sake of the fields but by a male engineer for the sake of power. Pig Killer, the convict whom Max meets shovelling manure in the Underworld, is there because he killed a pig to feed his family: in a world where pigs are energy, the sacrificial animal has become sacrosanct not as an offering but as an asset. Biogas from manure is, in one sense, the most sustainable energy system the saga depicts—renewable, circular, drawn from decay rather than from deep time. The Underworld therefore stands at the hinge between the thesis's two chthonics. It draws its energy from the humic processes of rot and return, but subjects them to the petro-chthonic logic of combustion and command. The materials of the Eumenidean turn are already present beneath Bartertown. What is missing is the conversion of their purpose—the passage, which the saga will accomplish only in *Fury Road* and *Furiosa*, from the pit that fuels to the pit that sows.

4.6 Thunderdome: Ordeal, Spectacle, and the Face

Above the Underworld stands the arena that gives the film its name. Thunderdome is a domed lattice of steel in which combatants, suspended from elastic harnesses, fight with weapons hung from the dome's frame, while the spectators cling to its exterior and chant the rule that the master of ceremonies has proclaimed: two men enter, one man leaves. The structure's form is not incidental. The geodesic dome

was the signature architecture of R. Buckminster Fuller, whose *Operating Manual for Spaceship Earth* (1969) imagined the planet as a vessel requiring intelligent stewardship, and whose domes became, in the communes of the counterculture and the pages of Stewart Brand's *Whole Earth Catalog* (1968), the emblem of an ecological utopia of efficient and sustainable dwelling. Thunderdome takes the architecture of Spaceship Earth and makes it a cage for killing. The countercultural utopia that *Mad Max 2* showed besieged is, in *Beyond Thunderdome*, converted into the instrument of the spectacle that replaced it.

The arena's function is explained within the film: it exists to contain violence. Disputes that might otherwise escalate into feud and war are settled here, publicly and finally, in a single combat whose outcome no one may contest. The institution has a triple genealogy. It recalls the Roman *munera*, the gladiatorial combats that originated, according to the ancient sources, in the funeral games of 264 BCE and that retained throughout their history the character of an offering to the dead —"Death is listening," the master of ceremonies tells the crowd. It recalls Juvenal's diagnosis that a populace deprived of political power will be content with bread and circuses. And it recalls the medieval judicial duel, the trial by combat that Robert Bartlett's *Trial by Fire and Water* (1986) analysed alongside the ordeals of fire and water as procedures by which communities without strong central authority delegated judgement to God. Thunderdome is ordeal, funeral game, and circus at once. It is also, in Guy Debord's sense, a spectacle: not a collection of images but a social relation mediated by images, in which a community produces its unity through a shared gaze upon a violence it does not itself commit (*The Society of the Spectacle*, 1967).

Considered as a legal institution, Thunderdome is a dark parody of the Areopagus. Athena's court converts the vendetta into a public trial, in which persuasion replaces force and a vote replaces a killing; Aunty's arena converts the vendetta into a public combat, in which force is ritualised but not replaced, and the verdict is a corpse. Both institutions aim to end the cycle of retaliation by concentrating it in a single sanctioned event. But the Areopagus channels the Furies into speech, while Thunderdome channels them into spectacle. Aunty is an Athena who has founded a court without discovering persuasion: a lawgiver whose law can contain violence only by staging it.

The combat between Max and Blaster is the saga's first ethical turning point. Max, overmatched by the giant's strength, discovers that Blaster is acutely sensitive to high-pitched sound, disables him with a whistle, and stands over him to deliver the death blow the rules require. He removes Blaster's helmet. Beneath it is the face of a man whom the film presents as having the mind of a child—frightened, gentle,

uncomprehending. Max cannot strike. Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totality and Infinity* (1961) and in the conversations published as *Ethics and Infinity* (1982), argued that the ethical relation begins in the encounter with the face of the other, whose nakedness and vulnerability express, before any word is spoken, the commandment not to kill. The unmasking of Blaster is the most Levinasian moment in popular cinema: the face appears, and the arena's law dissolves before it. The saga's gallery of masks —Nolan's helmet, the Humungus's visor, Immortan Joe's respirator, the muzzle clamped upon Max himself—may be read, in this light, as a technology of armour against the face: the machine interposed between the warrior and the vulnerability that would forbid him to kill. Thunderdome is the place where, for the first time, the mask comes off.

The refusal answers, across six decades, the thunder of Eliot's *Waste Land* introduced in Chapter Three. Eliot's thunder speaks three syllables—*datta*, *dayadhvam*, *damyata*: give, sympathise, control. Bartertown's thunder speaks another rule: two men enter, one man leaves. Max obeys the first thunder rather than the second. His refusal to kill is *dayadhvam*, sympathy, enacted in the very dome built to forbid it, and it is the first act in the saga by which the hero breaks the Erinyic economy rather than serving it. Aunty's men kill Blaster regardless, and Bartertown's law turns upon the one who refused. The deal has been broken; the wheel must be spun.

4.7 Gulag: The Scapegoat Rite

The wheel turns, and stops at "Gulag." The punishment is exile. Max is bound to a horse, an enormous grotesque mask is placed over his head, and he is driven out into the desert to die. The rite is the most literal enactment of the scapegoat in modern cinema. Leviticus describes the ceremony of the Day of Atonement with precision: the high priest lays both his hands upon the head of the living goat and confesses over it all the iniquities of the people, "putting them upon the head of the goat," and sends it into the wilderness by the hand of an appointed man. "And the goat shall bear upon him all their iniquities unto a land not inhabited: and he shall let go the goat in the wilderness" (Leviticus 16:21–22). The giant head that Bartertown places upon Max is the head upon which the city's guilt is laid: the surface of transfer, enlarged to the scale of a carnival effigy so that no one can mistake who bears the burden. Max is expelled because his refusal to kill exposed what Bartertown's order required—the murder of the vulnerable for the sake of the sovereign's power—and the city purges itself of that knowledge by sending its bearer into the desert.

The scapegoat of *Mad Max 2* was expelled by deception; the scapegoat of *Beyond Thunderdome* is expelled by law. The progression matters. In the second film the community used Max without his knowledge, sending him into the wilderness as a decoy; in the third, the city sends him into the wilderness as a sentence, publicly, by the spin of a wheel, before a crowd. The mechanism Girard described as the hidden foundation of social order has become an explicit institution. Bartertown does not merely practise scapegoating; it has written it into its constitution.

James Frazer devoted a volume of the third edition of *The Golden Bough*, *The Scapegoat* (1913), to the public expulsion of evils, and elsewhere in the same work recorded among the folk customs of Central Europe the rite of "carrying out Death": an effigy of Death, often grotesquely costumed, was carried out of the village in spring and thrown into water or across the boundary, after which green boughs or a decorated tree were carried in to welcome the summer. Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) analysed the carnival rite of the mock king—crowned and decrowned, mocked and beaten—as the comic form of the same ambivalence: the renewal of the world through the ritual expulsion of its old order. Max, masked and driven out, is carried out of Bartertown as its Death, and the rite works as the folk custom says it should. The desert does not kill him. Half-dead, he is found by a girl from a hidden gorge where water flows and trees grow, and carried into the green. The scapegoat expelled as Death arrives among the lost children as a returning god.

The Australian resonance noted in Chapter Two returns here with full force. A continent founded as the penal destination of an empire—the place to which the metropole expelled those it judged polluted—produces, in its cinema, a hero whose fate in every film is expulsion, and a film in which the expulsion is called Gulag. The settler nation's founding rite is re-enacted upon the body of its most famous fictional son. But the rite's outcome is reversed. The convicts of the transportation era were sent into exile to vanish; Max is sent into exile and finds, at the far side of the desert, a community that has been waiting for someone to arrive.

The Tell: Cargo Cult and the Literature of the Remnant 4.8

The children of the gorge are the survivors of an airliner that came down in the desert years before. The adults among them set out on foot under the plane's captain, Walker, to seek help, promising to return; they never did. The children who remained have grown up waiting, and they have made of their waiting a religion. Their history is recited in a ritual called the Tell, performed by Savannah Nix before

images upon a wall; their relics include a View-Master whose stereoscopic slides show the lights of a city they call Tomorrow-morrow Land; their language is a creolised English; and their eschatology is the return of Captain Walker, who will repair the plane and fly them home. When Max is carried into the gorge, they take him for Walker. He denies it, and his denial divides the community: some accept his warning that the world beyond the sand is a ruin, and others set out across the desert in search of the city of the slides.

The community is, in the most precise sense, a cargo cult. The anthropology of Melanesia documented from the early twentieth century a series of millenarian movements in which communities disrupted by colonial contact anticipated the return of ancestors or saviours bearing the manufactured goods—the cargo—that Europeans appeared to obtain by ritual means, and in which believers built airstrips, control towers, and effigies of aircraft to summon them. Peter Worsley's *The Trumpet Shall Sound* (1957) read these movements as proto-nationalist responses to colonial domination; Kenelm Burridge's *Mambu* (1960) and Lamont Lindstrom's *Cargo Cult* (1993) refined and criticised the category, Lindstrom showing how the term had become a Western projection—a mirror in which Europeans contemplated their own desire for commodities. The genealogy has a specific Australian strand. Papua and New Guinea were administered by Australia until 1975, and one of the earliest documented movements was investigated by the Australian government anthropologist of Papua, F. E. Williams, whose report of 1923 named it "The Vailala Madness." The colonial administration that diagnosed the cargo cult as a madness belonged to the nation whose cinema would make madness the epithet of its hero.

Beyond Thunderdome transposes the cargo cult from Melanesians to white children, and in doing so both reproduces and estranges the projection Lindstrom identified. The children's ochre markings, their oral rite, and their tribal organisation borrow the iconography of Indigenous and Melanesian cultures for a community of settler descendants—a further instance of the indigenisation fantasy marked by the Feral Kid's boomerang—while the peoples to whom that iconography belongs remain absent from the film. Yet the film also turns the projection back upon its source. The cargo the children await is modernity itself, the lit city of the slides, and the film's audience knows, as Max knows, that the city is a ruin. The cargo cult of the Lost Tribe is the faith in progress viewed from its far side: a liturgy of waiting for a civilisation that will not return, because it has already consumed itself.

The Tell is the saga's most elaborate image of oral tradition. Walter Ong's *Orality and Literacy* (1982) described the characteristic features of oral thought—additive rather than subordinative, aggregative rather than analytic, redundant, conservative, agonistically toned, participatory, and homeostatic—and Milman Parry and Albert

Lord's study of the South Slavic epic singers, *The Singer of Tales* (1960), showed how oral poets compose in performance from a repertoire of formulas. Savannah's Tell displays these features. It is recited collectively, the children joining its formulas; it preserves the past by continually reshaping it to present need; and it is homeostatic in Ong's sense, discarding what no longer serves. Walter Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) had lamented the decline of storytelling under the pressure of the novel and of information, and located the storyteller's authority in death, from which, Benjamin argued, the storyteller borrows the sanction of everything he can tell. The post-apocalypse restores the storyteller. When information has collapsed and the archive has burned, the Tell is the form in which experience survives, and its authority is the authority of the dead it commemorates.

The Tell places *Beyond Thunderdome* within a literature of the remnant that runs through the twentieth century. Jack London's *The Scarlet Plague* (1912) imagined an old survivor of a pandemic recounting the history of the vanished world to grandsons who no longer believe him and no longer speak his language. George R. Stewart's *Earth Abides* (1949) followed a survivor whose hammer becomes, among the unlettered descendants of the collapse, a sacred object. Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) imagined monks preserving the fragmentary relics of the pre-nuclear world—among them a shopping list and an electrical blueprint—as holy texts whose meaning they cannot read; the View-Master of the Lost Tribe is a Leibowitzian relic. Russell Hoban's *Riddley Walker* (1980), set in a Kent of the far post-nuclear future, renders its world in a degraded English and makes a garbled myth of the splitting of the atom the sacred narrative of its people, performed as a puppet show; it is the Tell's closest literary kin. And the children's community recalls two antithetical fables of children without adults. J. M. Barrie's *Peter Pan* (1904; *Peter and Wendy*, 1911) imagined a band of Lost Boys in a land where no one grows up, to whom Wendy tells stories; William Golding's *Lord of the Flies* (1954) imagined schoolboys stranded after an air crash degenerating into tribal murder. The Lost Tribe refutes Golding and fulfils Barrie. Stranded after an air crash, they do not descend into violence but organise themselves around a story, and their Wendy is Savannah: the storyteller-mother of children who have had no mothers.

The film ends with the remnant's transfiguration. The children, escaping Bartertown with Max, Master, Pig Killer, and Jedediah's plane, reach the ruined city of the slides—Sydney, its harbour bridge broken—and settle there. Years later Savannah, grown, recites the Tell to a new generation among the ruins, and the community lights the dead city each night as a beacon for those still lost in the desert, among them the raggedy man who saved them and stayed behind. The pharmakos has become the absent hero of the community's legend; the cargo cult has become a

culture; the lost children have become the keepers of a light. The film's final sequence reconciles the two founding acts that its plot had opposed: the expulsion of the scapegoat and the establishment of a community of memory. Max, driven into the desert as Bartertown's Death, becomes in the children's Tell the figure of a return for which they keep the lights burning—the one who is remembered because he could not stay.

4.9 1985: A Constellation of Remnants

Beyond Thunderdome appeared in the middle of a year of extraordinary convergence, in which the anglophone imagination returned, across media and disciplines, to the questions the film posed: what survives a catastrophe, who controls reproduction and memory, and what forms of community might be built from the remnant. Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* imagined a theocracy in which fertile women are conscripted as breeders for a ruling caste—the political form that *Fury Road* would give to Immortan Joe's Citadel. Cormac McCarthy's *Blood Meridian* imagined a desert of scalp-hunters presided over by the Judge, whose theology declares that war is god—the creed the War Boys would embody. Don DeLillo's *White Noise* imagined a suburban family fleeing an "airborne toxic event," the industrial exhaust of a consumer society returned to it as a cloud of death. Ursula K. Le Guin's *Always Coming Home* imagined the Kesh, a peaceable people of a far-future California whose songs, rituals, and gathering economy are set against the Condor people, a militarised and monotheistic patriarchy devoted to its war machines, which keeps its women in subjection and whose ambitions founder upon the scarcity of what they consume—an anticipation of the opposition between the Vuvalini and the Citadel more exact than any other in the literature. Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" proposed the cyborg, the hybrid of organism and machine, as a figure for a feminist politics beyond the dualisms of nature and culture; Furiosa's mechanical arm would make the figure iconic. Michael Walzer's *Exodus and Revolution* read the march through the wilderness as the paradigm of revolutionary politics, and Caroline Humphrey's essay declared the barter economy a myth. In Australia, the Royal Commission into British nuclear tests delivered its report on the poisoning of the desert.

Two coincidences of that July complete the constellation. In the month in which *Beyond Thunderdome* reached American cinemas, Tina Turner, its sovereign, performed at Live Aid, the transatlantic concert staged to raise relief for the famine in Ethiopia: the queen of Bartertown appeared upon the stage of a global spectacle

convened in response to drought, hunger, and the failure of the land. And in the same month Robert Zemeckis's *Back to the Future*, the summer's great success, ended with its inventor returning from the year 2015 with a domestic reactor fuelled by household refuse. The popular cinema of 1985 imagined that thirty years hence the problem of fuel would be solved by the burning of garbage; the year 2015, when it arrived, brought instead *Fury Road*, a film in which the world has burned and its survivors must learn to plant again. Between the two images lies the thesis's argument in miniature: the fantasy of an energy that would come from decay without the labour of germination, set against the myth of a world that must return to the ground what it took from it.

Beyond Thunderdome was also an ending. It was the first film of the saga made after Byron Kennedy's death, which it commemorates, and it would be the last for thirty years. Miller turned to other work—*The Witches of Eastwick* (1987), *Lorenzo's Oil*, the *Babe* films, *Happy Feet*—while the Wasteland lay fallow through the decades in which the climate crisis passed from scientific projection to political fact. The second and third films had completed the saga's anatomy of the economy of fire: the refinery besieged and the protection racket of the petro-sovereign; the catastrophic expenditure of the accursed share; the tanker of sand and the first expulsion of the scapegoat; the market town founded upon the myth of barter and enforced by the creditor's cruelty; the Underworld that fuels rather than sows; the arena that stages violence in order to contain it; the face that interrupts the arena's law; the scapegoat carried out as Death; and the lost children who make of their waiting a culture.

What the two films had not found was the Eumenidean settlement—the conversion of the Furies' energies from destruction to fertility. They had approached it from several sides. Aunty's arena had attempted to house the Furies and succeeded only in staging them; Master's Underworld had drawn energy from decay and spent it in combustion; the Lost Tribe had founded a community upon memory, but upon the memory of a world that could not return. Each had grasped one element of the settlement and missed its centre: the transformation of the chthonic from a reservoir to be burned into a ground to be sown. That transformation required a different protagonist and a different vessel. When the saga resumed in 2015, the vessel was a war rig carrying women, and the protagonist bore the name of the Fury herself.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Dynamo and the Virgin

Fury Road *and the Eumenidean Turn*

The Dynamo and the Virgin 5.1

In the twenty-fifth chapter of *The Education of Henry Adams*, the historian recalls standing in the Gallery of Machines at the Paris Exposition of 1900 before the great electrical dynamos, and feeling them, to his own astonishment, as a moral force. "He began to feel the forty-foot dynamos as a moral force," Adams writes of himself in the third person, "much as the early Christians felt the Cross"; before long he found himself inclined to pray to them. The dynamo was, for Adams, the symbol of a new kind of force—infinite, occult, indifferent—which had replaced the forces by which earlier civilisations had organised their lives. Against it he set the greatest force the Western world had ever felt: the Virgin of Chartres, the medieval embodiment of the power of reproduction, whom he identified with the Venus of antiquity, and whose energy had raised the cathedrals. "All the steam in the world could not, like the Virgin, build Chartres." The modern world, Adams observed, had learned to worship the dynamo and to be ashamed of the Virgin. Its art and thought had banished the force of sex from their imagination, and the energy of reproduction had been displaced by the energy of the machine.

Mad Max: Fury Road is the most rigorous dramatisation of Adams's opposition in modern art. Its world is divided between a cult of the dynamo and the force of the Virgin. The War Boys of Immortan Joe's Citadel worship the engine: they salute one another by joining their hands in the shape of a V8, keep chapels of steering wheels, scarify their skins with the diagrams of motors, and pray at the moment of death to be carried to Valhalla "shiny and chrome." Against them are arrayed the

forces of reproduction: the five Wives whom Joe keeps as breeders, the nursing mothers milked in the Citadel's dairy, the Vuvalini—the Many Mothers of a lost green country—and the Keeper of the Seeds. Adams's Virgin was not a virgin in any narrow sense; he insisted that she was Venus, the force of fertility itself. The women of *Fury Road* are not virgins either. They are the generative force that the dynamocult has seized, enclosed, and harnessed to its own reproduction, and the film's plot is the secession of the Virgin from the Dynamo: the moment at which the force of reproduction escapes the machine that has captured it, and turns against it.

This chapter reads *Fury Road* as the saga's *Eumenides* and as the centre of the thesis's argument. It reads the Citadel as the culmination of chthonopolitics, a hydraulic despotism and biopolitical apparatus that treats every body as a reservoir (5.2); Immortan Joe as the Fisher King of the Grail romances, whose wound is the waste of his land, and the Wives' graffito as a Grail question transformed into an indictment (5.3); the War Boys' creed as the fusion of the dying-and-rising god with the slain and resurrected warriors of Valhalla, and Nux's conversion as the passage from martyrdom to seed (5.4); the Wives' rebellion as the refusal of the Apollonian embryology upon which the Aeschylean settlement was founded (5.5); the flight and return as an Exodus that becomes a revolution, organised as a ring around its turning point on the salt (5.6); the film's moments of stillness as the site of its ethical thought (5.7); and its ending as a counter-Eumenidean settlement in which blood, water, and seed are converted from instruments of domination into substances of renewal (5.8).

5.2 The Citadel: Hydraulic Despotism, Biopower, and the Deathstill

The Citadel is chthonopolitics perfected. It is a complex of three towers of rock rising from the desert, beneath which lies an aquifer that its sovereign pumps to the summit and releases, at intervals and at his pleasure, in thunderous cascades upon the multitude gathered below. As the water falls, Immortan Joe addresses the crowd through a loudspeaker, counselling them not to become addicted to water, lest it take hold of them and they come to resent its absence. The scene is the most concentrated image of sovereignty in the saga. It condenses into a single gesture the hydraulic despotism that Karl Wittfogel analysed, in which total power is founded upon the managerial control of water; the cynicism of a ruler who makes scarcity a virtue in order to justify enforcing it; and the theatre of a gift that is also a demonstration of

the power to withhold. The water is not distributed; it is dispensed, and its dispensation is a liturgy of dependence.

The Citadel's power extends beyond water. Its sovereign is allied with two other fiefdoms—Gastown, which refines fuel under the People Eater, and the Bullet Farm, which manufactures ammunition under the Bullet Farmer—so that the Wasteland's economy rests upon a triumvirate of chthonic substances: water from the aquifer, petrol from the oil-bearing strata, lead from the ore. Every resource that sustains the order is drawn from beneath the ground, and each is controlled by a sovereign whose title names his relation to it. The People Eater, a corpulent figure in a ruined suit who tallies the costs of the war party like an accountant of the apocalypse, is the financial face of petro-power; his name declares what capital, in Marx's figure of the vampire that lives only by sucking living labour, has always done.

Within the Citadel, power takes the form that Michel Foucault called biopower. In the first volume of *The History of Sexuality* (1976) and in his lectures of the same year, Foucault distinguished the ancient sovereign right to take life or let live from the modern power to make live and let die: a power that invests life itself—birth, health, reproduction, longevity—as the object of political management. Immortan Joe exercises both. He makes live: he breeds heirs from his captive Wives, milks the nursing mothers in a dairy of breast pumps, harvests the blood of captives to sustain his sick warriors, and rations the water that keeps the multitude alive. He lets die: the destitute who receive water only at his whim, the War Boys whose bodies fail from the half-life. And he retains the sovereign's ancient right to take life, which he exercises by sending his warriors to die. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) described the bare life that sovereignty produces by including it in the political order only through its exclusion; the multitude at the foot of the Citadel, sustained by the water that falls upon it and abandoned when the pumps fall silent, is bare life in its most literal form. And Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003), which defined sovereignty as the capacity to dictate who may live and who must die, and which analysed the martyr whose body becomes a weapon, supplies the term for the War Boys examined in section 5.4.

The Citadel's biopower has a precise literary precursor in Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), whose Fremen, inhabitants of a desert planet, practise an absolute discipline of water. Among their institutions is the deathstill, in which the bodies of the dead are rendered to recover their water for the tribe, on the principle that a man's flesh belongs to himself but his water belongs to the tribe. Herbert's deathstill is an ethic of scarcity within a community of equals. Joe's Citadel applies its logic to the living, for the benefit of one. Every body in the Citadel is a reservoir: the Wives for heirs, the mothers for milk, the captives for blood, the War Boys for death. In Heidegger's

vocabulary, introduced in Chapter One, the Citadel is the regime of *Gestell*, in which every being is revealed as standing-reserve; in the terms of James C. Scott's *Against the Grain* (2017), which described the earliest states as apparatuses for capturing and concentrating human populations, managing their reproduction, and extracting their labour and grain, it is the archaic state reborn. The Citadel even possesses its grain. At its summit, visible only to those who live there, are gardens of green: the private paradise of a sovereign who has made the land below a waste.

The sovereign's own family discloses the order's sickness. Joe's adult sons are Rictus Erectus, a giant of enormous strength and childlike mind, and Corpus Colossus, a man of sharp intelligence in a small and fragile body. Between them they reproduce, divided, the composite sovereign of Bartertown's Underworld: Master's intellect without strength, Blaster's strength without intellect. The figure that *Beyond Thunderdome* assembled into a single ruling body, *Fury Road* splits into two failing heirs. The dynasty cannot reproduce itself whole—which is why Joe's breeding programme, and his desperation for a perfect son, sit at the centre of the plot.

5.3 The Fisher King and the Grail Question

Immortan Joe's body is a ruin held together by apparatus. His skin is covered with sores; he cannot breathe without the respirator moulded into a skeletal jaw; his torso is encased in a transparent cuirass sculpted with the musculature he no longer possesses; his medals and armour present the image of a warrior over the reality of decay. His sons are infirm, his heirs unborn, his land a desert. The configuration has a mythic name. In the Grail romances of the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, the Fisher King is a wounded sovereign—injured, in many versions, in the thighs or groin—whose wound is mysteriously bound to the barrenness of his realm: while he languishes, the land lies waste. Jessie Weston's *From Ritual to Romance* (1920) argued that the legend preserved the memory of ancient fertility rites in which the vigour of the king and the fertility of the land were one, and that the Grail quest was the romance form of a ritual of renewal. T. S. Eliot, acknowledging in his notes that "not only the title, but the plan and a good deal of the incidental symbolism" of *The Waste Land* had been suggested by Weston's book, made the Fisher King the presiding figure of modernist desolation. Immortan Joe is the Fisher King of the petro-age: a sovereign whose diseased body and sterile realm are two faces of a single wound, and whose wound is the extraction that has made both.

The romances turn upon a question. In Chrétien de Troyes's *Perceval, or the Story of the Grail* (c. 1180–90), the young knight, admitted to the Fisher King's castle, watches the procession of the bleeding lance and the grail and fails, out of misplaced courtesy, to ask whom the grail serves; because he does not ask, the king remains wounded and the land waste. In Wolfram von Eschenbach's *Parzival* (early thirteenth century), the hero returns after years of wandering and at last asks the healing question—a question of compassion addressed to the suffering king, asking what ails him—and the king is healed. The Grail question is a question that heals by acknowledging the wound.

Fury Road has its question, and it is written on a wall. In the vault where the Wives were kept, they have left their testament in paint: "We are not things." "Our babies will not be warlords." And, most insistently, "Who killed the world?" The graffito is a Grail question, but it has been transformed. It does not ask what ails the king; it asks who killed the world, and its answer is the king. Where Wolfram's question healed the sovereign by acknowledging his wound, the Wives' question heals the land by indicting the sovereign whose wound it is. The healing question of the Grail romance has become an accusation, and the restoration it calls for is not the cure of the king but his removal.

That removal follows the oldest version of the myth. James Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* (1890) with the riddle of the priest of Nemi, the King of the Wood, who held his office until he was slain by his successor, and quoted Macaulay's lines on "The priest who slew the slayer, / And shall himself be slain." Frazer read the rite as the survival of a widespread belief that the sacred king, upon whose vigour the fertility of the land depended, must be killed when his strength failed, lest the land fail with him. Coppola had staged this structure in 1979, placing Frazer's book and Weston's on the shelves of the jungle god-king whom his hero is sent to kill. *Fury Road* completes it. Furiosa kills Immortan Joe—hooking his respirator to a spinning wheel and tearing it from his face, so that the sovereign who made the air unbreathable dies of breathing it—and returns his body to the Citadel, where the waters are released. The king's death restores the land.

But the Frazerian frame also discloses the danger of the settlement, which the film's final image registers and which *Furiosa* will confront directly. The slayer of the king risks becoming the next king; the priest who slew the slayer may herself be slain. The rite of Nemi is not a resolution but a cycle, and a cycle of regicide is only the Erinyic economy in its dynastic form. The question the saga must answer after *Fury Road* is whether the death of the sovereign can end the cycle of succession or only renew it—whether Furiosa, ascending to the summit from which Joe ruled, has converted the Furies or merely inherited them.

5.4 "I Live, I Die, I Live Again": Valhalla and the Machine Martyrs

The War Boys are the saga's most original creation, and their creed is condensed into a single cry. "I live, I die, I live again!" Nux shouts as he prepares to sacrifice himself in the first great chase. The formula is a theology of resurrection. Its promise is that death in the service of the Immortan will be followed by a new life in Valhalla, where the War Boys will ride eternal, shiny and chrome, in the company of heroes. Two mythic systems are fused in the creed, and their fusion is the key to its meaning.

The first is the myth of the dying-and-rising god that Frazer assembled from the cults of Adonis, Attis, and Osiris: the god of vegetation who dies with the harvest and returns with the spring, whose death and resurrection were enacted in rites of mourning and rejoicing that secured the renewal of the crops. Jonathan Z. Smith's celebrated critique (1987) argued that the category was in large part a scholarly construction, assembled from heterogeneous sources on a Christian model; the War Boys' creed, in this light, is a modern myth that gives the contested category a body. And it does so with a decisive substitution. The dying-and-rising god of Frazer's synthesis is a god of vegetation, whose death is a planting and whose return is a harvest. The War Boys' resurrection has been severed from vegetation altogether. They die not into the soil but into chrome; they rise not as grain but as machine. Their creed is the vegetation myth captured by the dynamo: resurrection without germination.

The second system is Norse. In Snorri Sturluson's *Gylfaginning* and in the poems of the *Poetic Edda*, the warriors slain in battle are chosen by the Valkyries and carried to Valhalla, where, as the *einherjar*, they fight each day, killing one another, and rise each evening to feast, until the last battle of Ragnarök. "I live, I die, I live again" is the daily cycle of the *einherjar* compressed into a battle cry. Immortan Joe has appropriated the Norse warrior-paradise and promised it to boys whose bodies are failing—an afterlife of endless combat for those to whom the present life offers only sickness and war. The Valkyrie herself appears in the film, but on the other side: the name is borne by one of the Vuvalini, a Many Mother who lures the travellers to her tower and dies in the final battle. The chooser of the slain has defected to the women.

The Norse eschatology contains, however, an ending that the War Boys' theology omits. In the *Völuspá*, the prophecy of the seeress that opens the *Poetic Edda*, the world ends in fire and flood; the gods fall; the earth sinks into the sea. And then, as Henry Adams Bellows rendered the passage in 1923, the seeress sees "the earth anew / Rise all green from the waves again," and fields that no one sowed bear

grain. Ragnarök is not an ending but a passage to a green world. The War Boys know the Valhalla of endless combat but not the green earth that rises after the gods have burned. Wagner's *Götterdämmerung*, examined in Chapter Four, ended with Valhalla in flames and the Rhine reclaiming its gold; *Fury Road* ends with the death of the god who promised Valhalla and the release of the water he hoarded. It carries the Norse cycle through to its conclusion, and the conclusion is not chrome but green.

Between the two myths stands Nux. He begins as the purest believer: a half-life War Boy who seizes Max as his blood bag and hurls himself into the chase in pursuit of a glorious death, crying to his comrades to witness him. His first attempt at martyrdom fails, prevented by Max, who is chained to him; his second is cancelled by the sovereign himself. When Nux stumbles during an assault on the War Rig, Immortan Joe looks down from his vehicle and dismisses him with a single word—"Mediocre." The verdict strips Nux of his martyrdom; the god he served has refused to witness him. Hidden in the War Rig, he is found by the Wife called Capable, who does not condemn him but comforts him, and through her he passes from the cult of the machine to the care of persons. His death at the film's climax is the inversion of the death he sought. He overturns the War Rig in the narrow canyon so that its wreck blocks the pursuit and the others may escape, and his last "witness me" is addressed quietly to Capable alone. Martyrdom as spectacle has become a sacrifice witnessed by love.

Chapter One proposed that Nux's name—the Latin *nux*, "nut," whose diminutive gives *nucleus*, "kernel"—marks him as a seed, and the Johannine figure completes the reading: the grain of wheat that falls into the ground and dies, and so bears much fruit. Nux dies into the earth of the canyon, and his death opens the way to the city. He is the first of the saga's War Boys to die not into chrome but into soil—the first, that is, to die as the vegetation god of the old myth died, so that something might grow. In him the War Boys' creed is not refuted but fulfilled in its original sense: he lives, he dies, and he lives again in those whose lives his death made possible.

"We Are Not Things": Apollo's Embryology Refused 5.5

The plot of *Fury Road* is set in motion by an absence. Immortan Joe enters the vault where his Wives are kept and finds it empty. On its walls the women have left their testament, and on its floor lie the chastity belts, toothed with metal, that marked their bodies as his. The Wives—the Splendid Angharad, Capable, Toast the Knowing, the Dag, and Cheedo the Fragile—have escaped in the War Rig, smuggled

out by the Imperator Furiosa, and Joe's war party pursues them across the desert. What it seeks to recover is not fuel or water but wombs, and above all the child that Angharad is carrying. When Angharad is endangered in the chase, Joe's cry asserts his claim with brutal economy: the child is his, his property.

Joe's claim is the Apollonian embryology examined in Chapter One, carried to its literal conclusion. In the *Eumenides* Apollo argued that the mother is no parent of her child but only the nurse of the seed the father has sown; the father alone begets, and the mother keeps his seed as a stranger keeps a stranger's. The Citadel is founded on this doctrine. Its Wives are vessels for its sovereign's heirs; the child in Angharad's womb is his before it is hers; the women's bodies are, in the most literal sense, his property—enclosed in a vault, locked in toothed belts, appraised by his physician. The War Rig that carries them is also a vessel, and the film makes the rhyme explicit: the Rig sets out carrying water and mother's milk to trade for fuel, and secretly it carries the most precious cargo of all. Joe's empire is an empire of tankers, and the women are its most valuable tank.

The Wives' answer is written on the wall: "We are not things." The sentence has a philosophical ancestry as old as the distinction between persons and property. Kant's *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785) distinguished, in the kingdom of ends, between what has a price and what has a dignity, and grounded morality in the imperative to treat humanity never merely as a means. Simone Weil's essay "The Iliad, or the Poem of Force" (1940–41) defined force as that which "turns anybody who is subjected to it into a thing"—first the corpse, then the slave, the living being reduced by force to the condition of an object. Immortan Joe's Citadel is a poem of force in Weil's sense: it turns every body into a thing, a reservoir of blood, milk, labour, and heirs. The Wives' slogan is the counter-poem. Its grammar is collective —*we*, not *I*—and its assertion is not a demand but a statement of fact that force has tried and failed to falsify. "Our babies will not be warlords" completes the refusal, transferring the claim upon the unborn from the father who begot them to the mothers who will bear and raise them.

The literary analogue is exact. In Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985), the theocracy of Gilead conscripts fertile women as Handmaids, assigning each to a Commander whose child she is to bear; the narrator, Offred, finds scratched into the wardrobe of her room a phrase of mock Latin left by her predecessor—*Nolite te bastardes carborundorum*—which becomes for her a message of solidarity and defiance across the silence imposed upon her. The Wives' graffiti in the vault perform the same act: the testament of the reproductive prisoner, written where the jailer will find it and addressed to the women who will come after. And like Atwood's novel, *Fury Road* refuses to locate the source of tyranny in mere individual villainy.

Gilead and the Citadel are systems that make reproduction the property of the state, and the women's resistance is directed not only against the master but against the order that makes him possible.

The film confers upon its Wives a dignity that the epic tradition reserved for heroes. Their names are formed with epithets—the Splendid, the Knowing, the Fragile—in the manner of the Homeric formulae that Milman Parry showed to be the building blocks of oral epic: swift-footed Achilles, grey-eyed Athena, much-enduring Odysseus. The Wives are named as the heroes of an epic are named, and each epithet names a quality the plot will test and transform. Cheedo the Fragile proves resolute; the Splendid Angharad falls to her death after shielding Furiosa with her pregnant body; and the Dag—whose name is Australian slang for an eccentric or unfashionable person—inherits the seeds.

Against the Citadel's patriarchy the film sets not a matriarchal paradise but its remnant. The Vuvalini, the Many Mothers from whom Furiosa was stolen as a child, are a band of ageing women on motorcycles, armed and wary, who have survived the death of their Green Place and now live by the road. Their name proposes a counter-principle to Joe's proprietary fatherhood: not one father who owns but many mothers who share, a motherhood collective and non-proprietary. Yet the film is careful not to make them the matriarchy that Bachofen imagined and that Froma Zeitlin showed the *Oresteia* constructing in order to overthrow. The Vuvalini are not a golden age restored; they are few, old, and dying, and their paradise is dead. The counter-*Eumenides* that *Fury Road* proposes is not a return to mother-right but a new founding, in which the remnant of the Many Mothers and the escaped Wives together take the city from the father.

Furiosa herself stands between the two groups and outside both: an Imperator of Joe's army, raised in his service, whose mechanical forearm makes her the saga's emblem of the hybrid figure that Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" proposed against the dualisms of nature and culture, man and woman, organism and machine. Haraway's manifesto ended with the declaration that she would rather be a cyborg than a goddess. Joe treats his Wives as goddesses of fertility, enshrined and imprisoned; Furiosa, the cyborg, is the one who frees them. In Deleuze and Guattari's terms, she is the war machine that the State had captured and put to its service, defecting from the State with the State's most precious possession. The Imperator's rank was the sovereign's gift; her defection turns his war machine against him.

5.6 Exodus and Return: The Turn on the Salt

The plot of *Fury Road* is an Exodus. A band of the enslaved flees a tyrant who has claimed their bodies and their offspring; they cross a wilderness; they are pursued by the tyrant's chariots, as Pharaoh "took six hundred chosen chariots, and all the chariots of Egypt" in pursuit of Israel (Exodus 14:7); and they seek a promised land of plenty that their leader remembers from her childhood. The leader's biography completes the parallel. Moses was a Hebrew child raised in Pharaoh's household, who became a man of Egypt before he turned against it; Furiosa is a child of the Vuvalini stolen into the Citadel and raised in Joe's service to the rank of Imperator, who turns against him to lead his captives out. The promised land is the Green Place.

But the promised land is dead. When the fugitives meet the Vuvalini, Furiosa learns that the swamp they crossed in the night—a poisoned bog haunted by scavengers on stilts—was the Green Place itself, its water fouled and its soil soured, abandoned by those who survived it. The scene that follows is the emotional centre of the film. Furiosa walks out into the dunes, falls to her knees, and screams. The Exodus has no destination. The survivors resolve to ride out across the salt flats in search of anything that might lie beyond them—a crossing of a hundred and sixty days into a white void—and Max, having taken his share of fuel and a motorcycle, rides off to resume his solitary wandering.

He comes back. In the film's only scene of sustained persuasion, Max proposes that the fugitives turn around. The Citadel, he points out, has water and green growing things; its war party is out in the desert pursuing them; if they return through the canyon they can take it, and in taking it they may come, together, upon some kind of redemption. The proposal is the turning point of the film, and its political meaning has two precise theoretical correlates. Michael Walzer's *Exodus and Revolution* (1985) argued that the Exodus narrative has served Western political culture as the paradigm of revolution: the story of a people's liberation from bondage, of a march through the wilderness as a time of political education, and of a covenant founding a new polity. Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) distinguished two responses available to the members of a deteriorating organisation—exit, which abandons it, and voice, which attempts to change it from within—and observed that the availability of exit tends to weaken voice, while its absence compels it. The salt flats are the end of exit. With the promised land destroyed and nothing ahead but salt, the fugitives choose voice. They return to Egypt to overthrow Pharaoh. *Fury Road* turns the Exodus into the revolution that Walzer found latent within it.

The turn has a mythic logic as well. Chapter One recalled that Lot's wife, looking back at the burning cities of the plain, became a pillar of salt, and that salt is, in the

biblical imagination, the substance of the curse of sterility. On the salt flats the fugitives look back, and they are not petrified; they are turned toward life. The return also reverses the Odyssean *nostos*. Odysseus comes home to find his house occupied by suitors devouring its substance, and must reclaim it by force. Furiosa's homecoming finds no home at all; the home she must reclaim is the house of her captor, occupied by a sovereign who devours the substance of the land. The *nostos* is displaced from the place of origin to the place of bondage. Home is not where one came from, but where one returns to remake the world.

The turn is the centre of the film in a structural as well as a dramatic sense. Mary Douglas's *Thinking in Circles* (2007) described the ring composition characteristic of many ancient texts, from Leviticus to Homer, in which a narrative proceeds through a series of stages to a central turning point and then returns through corresponding stages to its beginning, so that the ending rejoins the opening and the meaning is concentrated at the centre. *Fury Road* is a ring. It runs out from the Citadel through the canyon, the storm, the bog, and the meeting with the Vuvalini to the salt; it turns; and it runs back through the bog and the canyon to the Citadel where it began. The outward journey is a flight; the return is a conquest. The same places are passed twice and change their meaning in the passing: the canyon where Furiosa bargained with the Rock Riders becomes the canyon where Nux dies; the Citadel from which the Wives fled becomes the city they enter as its rulers. The turning point on the salt is the film's still centre, and the meaning it concentrates is the meaning of the whole saga: there is no escape from the Wasteland, only its transformation. Bruno Latour's question—where to land?—receives here its first answer. The ground on which to land is not elsewhere. It is the ground one fled.

Stillness and Grief: The Time-Image at the Centre 5.7

Fury Road is celebrated for its velocity, and rightly; but its ethical thought is concentrated in its moments of stillness. Chapter One proposed, following Deleuze, that the saga thinks most deeply where the action-image falters and something like a time-image breaks through—where movement yields to duration, and the sensory-motor chain of situation and response is suspended. *Fury Road* contains a handful of such moments, and each marks a stage of the Eumenidean turn.

The first comes when Max, chained to the unconscious Nux after the storm, finds the War Rig halted in the desert and the Wives washing themselves with a hose, in white gauze, amid the sand: a tableau of almost classical stillness, recalling the bathing nymphs of Renaissance painting, in which the women whose bodies are the

object of the pursuit appear for the first time outside it. The second comes in the night in the bog, when the War Rig is mired and the Bullet Farmer's searchlights approach. Max, after missing with two of their last three rounds, hands the rifle to Furiosa and offers his own shoulder as her rest; she fires, and the light goes out. The gesture is wordless, and it seals the alliance. The hero yields the weapon and becomes the support. The third is the conversation between the Dag and the Keeper of the Seeds, in which the old woman opens her bag and shows the young pregnant woman her seeds—trees, plants, the fruit of a lost country—and speaks, with equal composure, of planting them wherever she can and of the killing she has done. The fourth is Furiosa's scream in the dunes.

That scream is the hinge of the film's mythic structure. In the *Eumenides*, the Furies' transformation is preceded by their grief. When Athena's court acquits Orestes, they lament their dishonour in a repeated cry against the younger gods who have ridden down the ancient laws and torn their prerogatives from their hands, and they threaten the land with blight. Athena does not silence their grief; she answers it, offering them honour, a dwelling, and a role in the life of the city. Furiosa's scream is the Fury's lament: the cry of a woman who has learned that the world she fought to return to has been destroyed, and that her rage has no object left to pursue. It is the moment at which fury, finding no quarry, turns into grief—and grief, unlike fury, can be answered. Max's proposal on the salt is the answer. He offers what Athena offered: not consolation but a place in the city, and a task that will convert the energy of rage into the labour of founding.

In this light Max's role at the turn is, unexpectedly, Athena's. The Aeschylean settlement was achieved by Persuasion—Peitho, whom Athena thanks at the trilogy's close for guiding her tongue as she won over the Furies. Max, the saga's most taciturn figure, performs his most consequential act not by violence but by speech. His persuasion on the salt is the only extended argument he makes in the entire saga, and it accomplishes what no violence in four films had accomplished: it converts the Fury's flight into the Fury's founding. The hero's highest deed is to persuade. Having persuaded, he will depart.

The four stillnesses share a structure. In each, the film's kinetic machinery halts and something other than force appears: the bodies of the Wives outside the pursuit; the collaboration of the shared rifle; the seeds in the old woman's bag; the grief beneath the fury. They are the film's glimpses of the humic-chthonic—of a world in which bodies are not reservoirs, weapons are shared rather than seized, seeds are carried rather than fuel, and rage is mourned rather than discharged. The chase is the film's body; the stillnesses are its conscience. And it is significant that the saga's most kinetic film should place its ethical centre in moments when nothing moves.

The Erinyic economy is an economy of motion, of combustion converted into speed. The Eumenidean turn begins when the motion stops.

The Eumenidean Settlement: Blood, Water, Seed 5.8

The return is costly. The Keeper of the Seeds dies in the battle, and her bag of seeds passes to the Dag, who is carrying Joe's child: the old woman's seeds and the young woman's pregnancy are united in a single body, and the next generation of the Green Place will be borne by a mother whose child will not be a warlord. The Valkyrie dies. Nux overturns the War Rig in the canyon and dies in its wreck. Furiosa kills Joe. And Furiosa herself is stabbed, and lies bleeding to death in the back of a vehicle as the survivors race toward the Citadel.

Max saves her with his blood. The captive who was tattooed as a universal donor and harvested as a blood bag lies down beside her and gives her a transfusion, and it is at this moment that he speaks his name—"Max. My name is Max"—which he has withheld throughout the film. The scene completes the transformation of the pharmakos traced since Chapter One. The substance that the Citadel extracted from him by force he now gives by choice; the *pharmakon*, poison and remedy, becomes remedy alone; and the witness, the *martys* who refused martyrdom, bears witness by giving his blood to the one whose life will found the city. The name is the seal of the gift. The man who would not be named as a hero names himself as a donor.

At the Citadel, Furiosa presents the multitude with the body of their sovereign, and the waters are released. They pour from the summit upon the crowd below—not as a sovereign's dispensation, timed to display the power to withhold, but as an outflow that the new rulers have no intention of stopping. The War Boys, who had pursued the Wives across the desert, raise the platform that lifts Furiosa, the Wives, and the surviving Vuvalini toward the summit. Max, unseen by most, slips away into the crowd; Furiosa, rising, looks down and finds him, and the two exchange a single glance before he disappears.

The ending is the saga's Eumenidean settlement, and its structure follows Aeschylus with remarkable fidelity while reversing the gender of his solution. In the *Eumenides* the Furies, persuaded, accept a dwelling within the city and a role as guardians of its fertility, and the trilogy ends with a procession conducting them to their new home. In *Fury Road* the Fury and the Many Mothers are installed in the Citadel, and their first act is to release the waters upon the people: the chthonic resource that the tyrant hoarded becomes the source of the community's life. The procession has become a platform rising. The subterranean home of Aeschylus's

Furies has become the summit of a city whose depths—the aquifer—now flow outward to all. The conversion is precisely the one Chapter One named the Eumenidean turn: the chthonic powers, which under the petro-chthonic regime were extracted, hoarded, and burned, are converted into the humic-chthonic powers of circulation and growth. Water that was a weapon falls like rain. Blood that was harvested is given. Seed carried out of a dead country is carried into a living city. It is, in Wagner's terms, the twilight of the gods: the god who promised Valhalla is dead, and the waters have reclaimed what he stole.

Luce Irigaray's "mechanics of fluids," introduced in Chapter One, finds here its cinematic realisation. The Citadel's order was an order of containment: water in the aquifer and the cistern, milk in the dairy's vessels, blood in the bags, women in the vault, seed in the warlord's claim. Its overthrow is an outflow. Everything the Citadel held is released—the women from the vault, the blood from the donor, the water from the pipes—and the final images are of fluids moving freely: water falling on upturned faces, children splashing in it, the platform climbing through the falling water. The solid order of the fortress gives way to the circulation of what it hoarded.

But *Fury Road*, like the *Oresteia*, ends in a settlement rather than a utopia, and its final image keeps the settlement's precariousness in view. The platform rises; the multitude remains below; a new set of rulers ascends to the summit from which the old one ruled. The film does not show what the new rulers will do, and it does not pretend that the release of the water has abolished the hierarchy of the Citadel. Max departs into the crowd, the scapegoat who has made the community possible and cannot join it. And the film closes with its epigraph attributed to the First History Man, asking where we must go, we who wander this Wasteland in search of our better selves. The question is posed after the restoration, not before it. The Eumenidean turn has been achieved, but the city it founds must still be built—and the saga's final film will ask, by returning to Furiosa's past, what it cost to make the woman who founded it.

5.9 Conclusion: The Counter-Eumenides

Fury Road is the saga's *Eumenides*, and it is a counter-*Eumenides*. It keeps the Aeschylean structure—the conversion of the Furies' energies from destruction to fertility; the installation of the chthonic powers within the city as guardians of its life; the decisive role of persuasion in accomplishing the conversion; the procession that conducts the transformed Furies to their place—while reversing the gender of the settlement. Aeschylus founded his city upon Apollo's embryology and the

domestication of the female powers by a motherless goddess acting on behalf of the father. *Fury Road* founds its city upon the refusal of that embryology, and installs the Fury and the Many Mothers in the place of the father.

The film achieves this reversal through a series of conversions that the preceding sections have traced. The Dynamo's captive Virgin secedes and takes the Dynamo's city. The Fisher King's question becomes an indictment, and the king's death heals the land. The War Boys' resurrection in chrome becomes, in Nux, a death into soil. The Wives, whom the Citadel treated as things, assert their personhood in a collective voice and inscribe it on the walls of their prison. The Exodus becomes a revolution, and the flight from the Wasteland becomes its transformation. The Fury's rage becomes grief, and grief is answered by persuasion. And blood, water, and seed, which the Citadel extracted and hoarded, are given, released, and carried into the city.

It bears emphasis that every one of these conversions is the completion of something the earlier films began. May Swaisey's shotgun in 1979 becomes the Vuvalini's rifles; the Warrior Woman of 1981 becomes Furiosa; the empty tanker becomes the full War Rig; Master Blaster becomes Joe's divided heirs; the Thunderdome's unmasked face becomes Joe's torn-away respirator; the methane pit that fuels becomes the seed-bag that sows; the scapegoat expelled by deception and by law becomes the donor who gives his blood and names himself. *Fury Road* is not a reboot of the saga but its harvest: the film in which the variants of thirty-six years are gathered and their latent meanings brought to term.

What *Fury Road* does not do is answer the question its epigraph poses. It shows the founding of the city but not its life; it shows the Fury converted but not the cost of her making; it shows the tyrant killed but not what becomes of the one who killed him. Those questions belong to *Furiosa*, the saga's final film, which returns to the years before *Fury Road* to tell the story of how the Fury was made—and which ends, as the next chapter will argue, with a peach tree growing from the body of a tyrant.

VI

CHAPTER SIX

Compost and Chronicle

Furiosa, *the Dema-Deity, and the Historiography of Vengeance*

A Saga of Feud: The Prequel as Genealogy 6.1

The fifth film of the cycle names its genre in its title. *Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga* (2024) is the only film of the series to call itself a saga, and the word is chosen with more precision than marketing requires. The sagas of the Icelanders, the *Íslendingasögur*, written down in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries and set in the Icelandic Commonwealth founded around 930, constitute the medieval literature of the blood-feud par excellence: prose narratives of killings and counter-killings among neighbouring families, conducted within a society that possessed laws and an annual assembly, the Althing, but no executive power to enforce them. Their masterpiece, *Njáls saga* (c. 1280), follows a sage lawyer who spends his life brokering settlements between feuding kin, and who is burned to death in his own house by enemies whom no settlement could bind. The Icelandic saga is, in short, the *Oresteia* of a stateless society: a sustained meditation on whether law can contain retaliation when there is no sovereign to enforce it. That is precisely the question of the post-nomic Wasteland.

The comparison yields structure as well as theme. Theodore M. Andersson's *The Icelandic Family Saga* (1967) identified a recurrent six-part pattern in the sagas' plots —introduction, conflict, climax, revenge, reconciliation, aftermath—and William Ian Miller's *Bloodtaking and Peacemaking* (1990) showed that feud in saga Iceland was not anarchy but a regulated system of reciprocal exchange, in which killings were reckoned, compensated, and balanced like debts, and in which arbitration offered an alternative to the next killing. *Furiosa* is divided into five titled chapters—"The Pole of Inaccessibility," "Lessons from the Wasteland," "The Stowaway," "Homeward,"

and "Beyond Vengeance"—and its arc follows the saga pattern until its last movement, which substitutes for Andersson's reconciliation a third term that neither the saga nor the *Oresteia* possessed. The final chapter is called neither Revenge nor Reconciliation, but Beyond Vengeance.

The saga form supplies one further feature that the film adopts with conspicuous deliberateness: its narrator's manner of reporting what is said. The saga authors characteristically attribute uncertain matters to report—it is said, some say—and transmit variant traditions without adjudicating among them. *Furiosa*'s narrator, the History Man, does precisely this at the film's climax, recounting the rumours that circulate about the fate of the warlord Dementus before offering the version that, he says, Furiosa herself told him. The film thereby closes the saga by thematising, within a single narrative, the variance that this thesis has argued is the saga's very mode of existence.

Furiosa is a prequel: made last, it narrates events that precede *Fury Road*, following its protagonist across some fifteen years from her abduction as a child to her elevation as Imperator. A prequel is, in the terms of Chapter Two, a genealogical form. It does not reveal an origin but traces a descent, showing how a figure already known was assembled from accidents, losses, and choices. This chapter reads the film as the genealogy of the Fury and the completion of the Eumenidean turn. It reads the film's opening as an abduction of Persephone from a Peach Blossom Spring (6.2); its antagonist as the saga's other madman, a demagogue who demands that vengeance be made epic (6.3); its protagonist's years of silence, craft, and mutilation as the making of an Imperator (6.4); its political drama through Ibn Khaldun's cycle of nomad and city (6.5); its narrator as a chronicler whose archive is his skin (6.6); its ending as the conversion of the tyrant into compost—a dema-deity, a georgic, a closing of the metabolic rift (6.7); and its last scene as the point at which the saga's end becomes its beginning (6.8).

6.2 The Pole of Inaccessibility: Persephone, the Peach Blossom Spring, and Demeter's Pursuit

The film opens where no previous film of the saga had gone: in a living green world. The Green Place of Many Mothers is an oasis of fresh water and cultivation—orchards, gardens, springs—hidden in the desert and defended by the women of the Vuvalini. The title of the first chapter, "The Pole of Inaccessibility," borrows a term of geography: the point within a landmass farthest from any coast, the place hardest of all to reach. The Green Place is utopia in the etymological sense that Thomas

More's *Utopia* (1516) made famous—the good place that is no place, located where no one can arrive. The critic Oli Mould observed at the film's release that its opening offers a fleeting solarpunk alternative to the series' habitual dystopia. The vision lasts minutes before the dystopia arrives.

It arrives as a theft. Two girls, Furiosa and her friend Valkyrie, are picking peaches when raiders stumble upon the oasis. Furiosa's first act in the film is to sabotage the raiders' motorcycles—a child disabling the machines that threaten her world—and her second is to be seized as a prize for the warlord Dementus. The structure is that of the oldest abduction myth in the Western tradition. In the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*, Persephone is gathering flowers in a meadow when the earth opens and Hades carries her off to the underworld; her mother, Demeter, searches the earth for her with torches; in her grief the earth ceases to bear; and Persephone, having eaten pomegranate seeds in the house of the dead, is bound to return there for part of every year. Furiosa is seized while gathering fruit and carried into the underworld of the Wasteland—first the Horde's camp, later the vault of the Citadel—and she carries into it a seed.

The seed is her mother's gift. Mary Jabassa pursues the raiders across the desert, killing them one by one and taking a dead rider's clothes to enter the Horde's camp, where she frees her daughter. When Dementus's riders close in, Mary stays behind to buy her daughter time and gives her a peach pit by which to remember her; Furiosa refuses to flee without her, and both are taken. Dementus forces the child to watch her mother crucified and tortured. Mary is Demeter, and the film denies her Demeter's triumph: the mother who scours the earth for her stolen daughter dies in the sight of the child she came to save. The myth's division of labour is thereby rearranged. Furiosa must become her own Demeter—the one who will bring the seed back from the underworld and make the earth bear—and the seed she carries will not, like Persephone's pomegranate, bind her to the house of the dead, but will in the end bind the house of the dead to her.

The death of Mary repeats, with variation, the founding catastrophe of the first film. In 1979 a mother and child were run down on the highway, and Max rose as the Fury who avenged them. In 2024 a mother is crucified before her child, and the child rises as the Fury who will avenge her. Aeschylus's Erinyes are, before anything else, the avengers of a murdered mother; Furiosa, whose name declares her kinship with them, is born as one at the moment of her mother's death. The saga's two great avengers are thus constituted by the same act—the destruction of the mother—and differ in what they make of it. Max's vengeance consumed itself in 1979 and left him a wanderer. Furiosa's will be converted, at the end of her film, into a tree.

The Green Place has a further and more distant ancestor, which its emblematic fruit discloses. In "The Peach Blossom Spring" (c. 421), the Chinese poet Tao Yuanming tells of a fisherman who follows a stream through a forest of peach trees in blossom and comes upon a hidden valley whose people, descendants of refugees who fled the violence of the Qin dynasty centuries before, live in peace, ignorant of every dynasty that has since risen and fallen. They feed him and ask him to say nothing of them. He leaves, marks his way, and reports what he has seen; but neither he nor anyone after him can find the valley again. Tao's tale founded a tradition of the hidden refuge outside history that runs through the whole of East Asian literature, and its structure is the structure of the Green Place: a peach-grove sanctuary from the violence of empire, found by accident, inaccessible by design, and impossible to return to. Furiosa spends the film trying to go home, as the fisherman tried to return; *Fury Road* has already told us that she will not succeed, and that when she finds the Green Place it will have become a poisoned bog. The Peach Blossom Spring cannot be found twice. What can be carried out of it is a seed.

The fruit carries one more association. In Chinese tradition the peach is the fruit of immortality, grown in the orchard of the Queen Mother of the West and ripening only once in thousands of years. The saga's sovereign has named himself the Immortan, and seeks his immortality in the dynastic reproduction of his own blood. The peach of the Green Place offers another kind: not the persistence of a ruler through his heirs, but the persistence of life through its seed. Between the Immortan and the peach the saga stages, in a single image, its final opposition.

6.3 Dementus: The Mad One, the Demagogue, the Triumphator

The warlord who takes Furiosa is the saga's most fully realised antagonist and, in a precise sense, its second madman. His name is the Latin *demens*—"out of one's mind," "mad"—given a heroic termination: Dementus is the Mad One, a Latin rendering of the epithet that the saga's first film bestowed upon its hero. The rhyme is not merely verbal. Dementus, like Max, is a man haunted by the death of his family, and he carries with him a child's teddy bear as the relic of the children he lost. He is what Max might have become had his grief found an army: a bereaved man who has made vengeance and spectacle into a politics, and who takes from Furiosa's mother the child he no longer has. Having watched Mary die at his order, he adopts her daughter as his own—the abductor who makes himself the father, laying claim, in a final perversion of the Apollonian embryology, to a child whose mother he has killed.

Dementus rides at the head of his Horde in a chariot drawn by three motorcycles harnessed like horses, his cloak streaming behind him. The image is that of the Roman triumph, in which the victorious general rode through the city in a chariot at the head of his army and his captives, and which the modern imagination knew chiefly through the chariot spectacle of Lew Wallace's *Ben-Hur* (1880) and its adaptations for the screen. The Christian apologist Tertullian recorded the tradition that a voice behind the triumphing general reminded him that he was a man (*Apologeticum* 33). Dementus's teddy bear performs that office: the triumphator carries with him the token of the loss that no triumph can repair.

He is also a demagogue in the classical sense. Thucydides described the Athenian Cleon as at once the most violent of the citizens and by far the most persuasive with the people, and Aristotle's *Politics* observed that in many cities tyranny had grown out of demagogy, the champion of the people becoming its master. Dementus governs by oratory, showmanship, and terror. He harangues his followers from the chariot, stages executions as public rites, and takes Gastown not by siege but by stratagem, smuggling his riders inside in the manner of the wooden horse that Virgil's *Aeneid* and Homer's *Odyssey* made the emblem of epic cunning. But the demagogue who can conquer cannot govern. The refinery he has seized declines under his rule toward ruin, and his Horde, magnificent in pursuit, proves incapable of the administration of a city. Ernesto Laclau's *On Populist Reason* (2005) analysed the construction of a people through the naming of a common enemy; Dementus's people exist only so long as there is someone to ride against. In peace they dissolve.

Dementus's deepest desire is narrative. At the climax of the film, defeated and alone in the desert with the woman who has hunted him across the Wasteland, he poses the question the film's publicity made famous: "Do ya have it in ya to make it epic?" He asks her to make his death, and her vengeance, worthy of a story. Walter Benjamin closed "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility" (1936) with the warning that fascism aestheticises politics, and that its consummation is war, in which humanity's self-alienation has reached the point at which it can experience its own destruction as an aesthetic pleasure of the first order. Dementus is the aesthete of vengeance. He wants to be killed in the grand manner, because a grand death becomes legend, and legend is the only immortality the Wasteland allows. His question is Fifi Macaffee's, examined in Chapter Three, turned inside out. Fifi wanted to give the people back their heroes; Dementus wants a villain's apotheosis. Both ask for an epic. Furiosa will refuse.

The refusal is also a reckoning with the saga's own beginning. Dementus's bereavement and his vengeance repeat, on a political scale, the trajectory of the Max of 1979, and his demand for an epic death repeats the demand that the saga itself

made of its hero across four films—to become the legend its narrators would tell. When Furiosa declines to make Dementus's end epic, the saga declines, through her, the form in which it was born. The madman of 1979 is answered by the madman of 2024, and the answer is that madness will no longer be given the grandeur of a story.

6.4 The Arm and the Rig: Muteness, the Map, and the Making of the Imperator

Dementus does not keep Furiosa. In the settlement that follows his seizure of Gastown he trades her to Immortan Joe, who imprisons her in the vault with the women he keeps as breeders. When Joe's son Rictus tries to carry her off, she slips his grasp, leaving him holding a wig made from her own hair, and vanishes into the depths of the Citadel. For more than a decade she lives disguised as a mute War Boy, working her way through the ranks of Joe's mechanics and helping to build the War Rig, the armoured tanker that will become her vessel. The film's middle chapters are the story of a woman who survives by silence and by craft.

The silence links her to the saga's first narrator. The Feral Kid of *Mad Max 2* was a child without speech who became, in old age, the voice of the legend; Furiosa is a woman who chooses speechlessness as camouflage and becomes the protagonist of the saga's last legend. The silenced woman who testifies by making has an ancient prototype. In Ovid's *Metamorphoses* (Book VI), Philomela, mutilated and imprisoned by Tereus so that she can never tell what he has done to her, weaves her story into a tapestry and sends it to her sister. Furiosa's tapestry is a vehicle. The War Rig, which she helps to build in silence, is her testimony and her means of escape, and in *Fury Road* it will carry the Wives out of the vault from which she herself escaped. Hephaestus, the lame smith of Chapter Two, is her other ancestor: the maker whose craft is born of injury.

Her body is an archive. As a child in Dementus's camp, Furiosa tattoos upon her left arm a chart of the stars by which she can find her way back to the Green Place: the route home inscribed upon the skin. The figure completes the series of inscribed bodies that Chapter Two traced—Max's back marked with his blood group, the War Boys' scarified engines, the History Man's chronicle—and it differs from all of them. Max's tattoos were written by his captors; the War Boys' were written by their faith; Furiosa's was written by herself, and what it records is not a sentence or a creed but a direction.

The film's central set-piece belongs to this chapter of her life. In "The Stowaway," Furiosa hides aboard the War Rig on a supply run in order to escape, and the tanker

is attacked from the air by the Octoboss, Dementus's renegade lieutenant, whose raiders descend upon it beneath parachutes and kill most of its crew. Furiosa and the Rig's master driver, Praetorian Jack, defend it together, and Jack, recognising her abilities, takes her into his service and trains her. The War Rig is thus, in Furiosa's history, first a hiding place, then a school, then a weapon, and finally—in *Fury Road*—a vessel of liberation. It is the saga's great carrier bag in Le Guin's sense: the container in which the precious thing is carried, gathered, and brought home.

She becomes Jack's second-in-command and is promoted to Praetorian, and the two resolve to escape together. Sent to collect arms from the Bullet Farm, they are ambushed by Dementus. Jack, her teacher and companion, is dragged to his death behind a vehicle, and Furiosa, chained, escapes only by severing her own injured left arm—the arm that bore the map. The two images carry the deepest weight of the epic tradition. Jack's death is Hector's: in the *Iliad*, Achilles, maddened by grief and wrath, drags the body of the man who killed his friend behind his chariot, desecrating it day after day. Dementus, like Achilles, is a man whose wrath has outrun every limit. And Jack has been her Mentor in the Odyssean sense, the guide whose form Athena takes to teach the young Telemachus how to act in the world. Miller described the Bullet Farm sequence as a love story set inside an action scene; it is also the scene in which the student loses her teacher and becomes her own.

The severing of the arm is the film's most consequential act, and its meaning is political as well as personal. With the arm goes the map, and with the map the way home. In the terms that Chapter Five drew from Albert Hirschman, Furiosa's exit has been foreclosed. There is no longer any route back to the Green Place, because the only record of the route has been cut away by her own hand; from this moment her home must be made where she is. She returns to the Citadel, shaves her head, and builds herself a mechanical arm. The shorn head is the oldest gesture of mourning in the Greek tradition—it is by a lock of hair laid on his father's tomb that Orestes announces his return in *The Libation Bearers*—and the prosthesis is the cyborg body that *Fury Road* made iconic, shown here in its making. Furiosa is not given her machine; she builds it. Haraway's cyborg is self-fabricated, and the Imperator of *Fury Road* is a woman who has made her own arm out of the loss of the one she cut away.

6.5 Nomad and City: Ibn Khaldun and the Forty-Day War

Behind Furiosa's personal history the film stages a political history, and its deep structure is the cycle of nomad and city that Ibn Khaldun described in the *Muqaddimah* (1377). The great North African historian argued that political power arises from *asabiyya*, the solidarity of a group bound by kinship, shared hardship, and loyalty, which is strongest among the nomads of the desert; that nomadic peoples, possessed of this solidarity, conquer the cities and found dynasties; that the luxury and ease of settled life dissolve the solidarity that won them power, so that a dynasty rarely outlasts three or four generations; and that it then falls to new conquerors from the desert. History, for Ibn Khaldun, is the recurrent conquest of the city by the steppe and the recurrent corruption of the conquerors by the city.

Furiosa enacts the cycle with startling compression. Dementus's Biker Horde is a band of nomads bound by loyalty to a charismatic chief and by the hardship of the road. It assaults the Citadel and is repelled; it seizes Gastown by stratagem, and its chief becomes a settled lord; and within a few years the conquerors' solidarity has dissolved in the city they conquered. Gastown declines under Dementus's misrule toward ruin; his lieutenants defect, the Octoboss turning against him to raid on his own account; and the Horde, outmanoeuvred by a strategy that Furiosa and the Citadel's People Eater devise to turn Dementus's own trap against him, is destroyed by the War Boys in what the History Man calls the Forty-Day Wasteland War. Ibn Khaldun's three generations have shrunk to three campaigns. The number of the war's days is itself the biblical number of trial and passage—the forty days of the Flood, the forty years in the wilderness, the forty days of the temptation in the desert—and it marks the war as the threshold through which the Wasteland passes into the order that *Fury Road* will overthrow.

The film's moral geography is nonetheless more complex than Ibn Khaldun's. For the historian, the desert was the home of virtue: the Bedouin, he argued, were closer to goodness and courage than settled peoples, whose luxuries corrupted their characters. In the Wasteland neither nomad nor city is virtuous. The Horde is a band of predators, and the Citadel a theocracy of extraction. Giambattista Vico's *New Science* (1725; 1744), which also conceived history as a cycle, gave a name to the condition into which a civilisation falls at the end of its course: the "barbarism of reflection," a barbarism worse than the first because it joins savagery to calculation. Dementus and Joe are its twin sovereigns, the one improvising cruelty and the other

administering it, and both possess the technical inheritance of the civilisation whose fall made them.

Between nomad and city the saga places a third principle, and its bearers are the women of the Green Place. The Many Mothers are neither a horde nor a state: they live by cultivation rather than plunder, and they defend rather than conquer. Pierre Clastres's *Society Against the State* (1974) described societies that organise themselves to prevent the emergence of coercive power, binding their chiefs by obligation and denying them command. The Vuvalini are such a society, and their solidarity is an *asabiyya* of kinship and care rather than of conquest. Their misfortune is that they possess what both horde and city covet—water, fruit, children—and cannot defend it forever. Furiosa carries their principle into the Citadel, and *Fury Road* shows her attempting, in alliance with the Wives, to found within the city an order that is neither the Horde's nor Joe's. Whether that order can escape Ibn Khaldun's cycle—whether the new rulers of the Citadel will be corrupted in their turn—is the question the saga leaves open. Its only answer is the seed: an order founded upon cultivation might have a chance that orders founded upon conquest never have.

In the terms of Deleuze and Guattari invoked in earlier chapters, the Horde is a war machine that tries and fails to become a State, and the Citadel is a State that has captured a war machine and harnessed it to its own reproduction. Furiosa is the war machine that escapes capture without becoming a horde: the Imperator who will defect, taking with her not plunder but the city's future. And Max, glimpsed at the edge of the film as a lone figure watching from afar while Furiosa struggles back across the desert toward the Citadel, is the nomad who has never belonged to either—the perpetual outsider of Ibn Khaldun's cycle, watching a history he will enter only briefly, and leave.

The History Man: A Chronicle Written on Skin 6.6

The film is narrated by a figure called the History Man, an old man in Dementus's train whose skin is covered in tattooed inscriptions and whose memory holds what remains of the old world's history, science, and technology. He is a living archive, and his presence makes explicit what the saga's earlier narrators implied: that the Wasteland has its own order of keepers of memory, from the aged Feral Kid of *Mad Max 2* and the storyteller of *Beyond Thunderdome* to the First History Man whose words close *Fury Road*. His opening narration frames the whole film as a question of endurance: as the world falls around us, he asks, how are we to bear its cruelties?

The History Man is, however, an archive in the service of power. Dementus keeps him as he keeps his other possessions, consulting him for knowledge and displaying him as a trophy of learning. Jacques Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) traced the word *archive* to the Greek *arkheion*, the house of the archons, the magistrates who held and interpreted the official documents of the city, and argued that every archive carries within it both a principle of commencement and a principle of commandment: it records origins, and it serves authority. The History Man embodies both. He is the record of the world's beginnings, and he belongs to a warlord. His body is the *arkheion* of the Wasteland, and its archon is Dementus.

What the History Man does with his archive at the film's end is therefore decisive. After the Horde's defeat and Furiosa's pursuit of Dementus into the desert, he recounts the stories told of the warlord's fate—the rumours of what she did to him—and then sets them aside, offering instead the account that, he says, Furiosa herself whispered to him. The gesture is the oldest in historiography. Herodotus, reporting the contradictory traditions of the peoples he visited, set down the principle that he was obliged to record what was said but not obliged to believe all of it (*Histories* 7.152), and his *Histories* proceed by setting side by side the accounts of Persians, Phoenicians, Egyptians, and Greeks, often without deciding among them. The History Man is a Herodotean narrator, and his method is that of *historia* in its root sense: inquiry that reports the *logoi*, the things that are said.

Hayden White's essay "The Value of Narrativity in the Representation of Reality" (1980) distinguished three forms of historical writing—the annals, which list events without connection; the chronicle, which orders them in sequence without closure; and history proper, which gives them the form of a story with a beginning, a middle, and an end—and argued that narrative closure is never neutral, since to end a story is to pass judgement upon it, to give it a moral. The History Man's multiplication of endings suspends that judgement; his final choice of one ending restores it. And the ending he chooses is not the one the epic would choose. Of all the stories told about Dementus's fate, he transmits the one in which vengeance becomes cultivation. His choice is an ethical act. The historian selects, from among the variants, the myth by which the community should live.

The History Man thereby performs within a single film the operation that this thesis has attributed to the saga as a whole. Lévi-Strauss held that a myth is the sum of its variants; the saga has transmitted its legend in five films whose continuity is deliberately unstable; and here, at the end, its narrator lays out the variants of a single event and chooses among them. Walter Benjamin's third thesis "On the Concept of History" held that the chronicler who recounts events without distinguishing between the great and the small acts in accordance with the truth that nothing that

has ever happened should be regarded as lost for history. The History Man is that chronicler and something more: the chronicler who, at the last, distinguishes—who chooses, from among the things that have been said, the one that can be planted. Chapter Three proposed that where the Areopagus has fallen, the storyteller sits in judgement, and the sentence is a story. The History Man's sentence upon Dementus is a tree.

The film's inscriptions are three, and they form a series. The History Man's skin bears the archive of the old world, owned by a warlord. Furiosa's arm bore a map of the way home, cut away so that she might live. And in *Fury Road* the walls of the vault bear the Wives' testament, written for the women who would come after. Archive, map, and testament are the three forms in which the Wasteland's people write upon the surfaces available to them, and the saga's movement runs from the first to the last: from the knowledge of the past held in a sovereign's possession, through the private route of return that must be sacrificed, to the collective declaration that founds a future.

Beyond Vengeance: The Dema-Deity, the Georgic, and the Metabolic Rift 6.7

The final chapter bears the title that this thesis has treated, since Chapter Three, as the saga's destination. After the destruction of the Horde, Furiosa pursues Dementus across the desert and brings him down. Alone with her, broken, he goads her to make his end epic. The film then withholds the act. The History Man recounts the rumours of what she did and sets them aside; and then, in the account he says came from Furiosa herself, the film shows its answer. High in the Citadel's gardens, Dementus lies imprisoned and still alive, withered and ancient, and from his body grows a peach tree, raised from the pit that Mary Jabassa gave her daughter on the night she died. The tyrant has become the root of a fruit tree. Its first peach Furiosa will carry to the Wives.

The image is the saga's most audacious, and it gathers into a single figure several of the oldest structures of the mythic imagination. The first is the one Chapter One anticipated in the warlord's name. The German ethnologist Adolf E. Jensen, studying the mythology of the island of Ceram in the Moluccas, recorded the story of Hainuwele, a girl born from a coconut palm whose body produced precious goods, and who was killed by the people and buried in the dancing ground; her father dug up her body, cut it into pieces, and buried the pieces, and from them grew the tuberous plants that became the people's staple food. Jensen named such beings,

after a term of the Marind-anim of New Guinea, *dema*-deities: primordial beings whose slaying brings into the world death, sexuality, and the cultivated plants by which human beings live. In the Hainuwele myth the age of the deathless ancestors ends with a killing, and from the killed body springs agriculture. The resonance of Dementus's name with the *dema* is, this thesis emphasises, a homophony rather than an etymology; but the structure to which it points is exact. The warlord who rivalled the Immortan is made, in his death-in-life, the source of the first cultivated food that the Citadel's liberators will taste. The age of the immortals ends; the age of planting begins.

The ethics of the *dema* myth are, however, reversed. Hainuwele was a generous being murdered by a jealous community, and her death is a crime from which, mysteriously, life comes. Dementus is a murderer whom his victim's daughter converts into nourishment. The film keeps the structure of the myth—food from a slain body—and inverts its moral, so that the body that feeds the living is the body of the one who devoured them. The Egyptian tradition offers a nearer analogue. The dismembered body of Osiris, gathered by Isis, became the god of the sprouting grain, and the grain-mummies placed in royal tombs—figures of Osiris moulded from earth and seed that sprouted in the darkness—made the dead god's body literally the bed of the crop. Dementus is a corn-Osiris of the Wasteland, with the difference that he has not been killed. He is kept alive to feed the tree.

The second structure concerns genre. Dementus demanded an epic; Furiosa answers with a georgic. Virgil's *Georgics* (29 BCE), composed in the aftermath of Rome's civil wars, is a poem of agricultural labour—ploughing, vine-dressing, husbandry, beekeeping—that imagines the restoration of a land devastated by war through the patient work of cultivation. At the close of its first book Virgil imagines a farmer of the future ploughing the battlefield of Philippi and turning up rusted javelins and empty helmets with his share, and marvelling at the huge bones in the opened graves. The georgic is the form in which the land absorbs the epic's violence and returns it as harvest. Its fourth book contains the strangest of its teachings: the *bugonia*, the rite by which the beekeeper Aristaeus, having lost his bees, regenerates them from the rotting carcasses of sacrificed cattle, a new swarm born from decay. The Hebrew Bible knew the same image. In the Book of Judges, Samson finds a swarm of bees and honey in the carcass of the lion he has killed, and makes of it a riddle: "Out of the eater came forth meat, and out of the strong came forth sweetness" (Judges 14:14). Dementus was the eater and the strong; the peach is the sweetness. The saga that began as an epic of the road ends as a georgic of the orchard.

The third structure belongs to political economy. Marx observed in the third volume of *Capital* that capitalist agriculture produces an irreparable rift in the inter-

dependent process of social metabolism—the circulation of nutrients between the soil and the people it feeds—because it carries the products of the land to distant cities, from which the substance they contain never returns to the fields. He drew the argument from the agricultural chemist Justus von Liebig, who had denounced the agriculture of his day as a system of robbery (*Raubbau*) that exhausted the soil by exporting its substance, and John Bellamy Foster's *Marx's Ecology* (2000) reconstructed the theory of the metabolic rift as a foundation of ecological thought. The Wasteland is the metabolic rift brought to completion: a land robbed of everything, its water pumped to a sovereign's summit, its fuel burned, its people bled. Furiosa's tree closes the rift with the very body of the robber. The extractor's flesh is returned to the soil, and what he took is given back as fruit. Donna Haraway's insistence, cited in Chapter One, that we are compost rather than posthuman, finds here its most literal and most terrible cinematic image.

The fourth structure is Aeschylean, and it explains why the image is terrible as well as just. The Eumenidean settlement did not abolish the Furies' dreadfulness; it housed it. In the *Eumenides* the Furies sing that there is a place where the terrible is good and must remain as the watcher of the mind, and Athena, founding her court, urges the citizens not to cast fear wholly out of the city, since no mortal who fears nothing is just. The August Goddesses are honoured beneath Athens not because they have ceased to be fearsome but because their fearsomeness has been given a place and a use. Furiosa's tree keeps the terrible within the garden. The tyrant is neither forgiven nor simply destroyed; his dreadful presence is preserved at the root of the city's fertility, a living reminder of what the city was and must not become again. The film's refusal to soften the image—its insistence that the tree grows from a living man—is the measure of its fidelity to Aeschylus. The Furies are not tamed. They are planted.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) supplies the final term. Arendt observed that human action is irreversible—what has been done cannot be undone—and that vengeance, the natural and automatic reaction to a trespass, binds doer and sufferer alike to the consequences of the deed, chaining them to a process that runs on without end. The only release from the predicament of irreversibility, she argued, is forgiveness, which interrupts the automatism of retaliation; its alternative, though not its opposite, is punishment, which at least brings the process to an end. Furiosa neither forgives nor merely punishes. She does something Arendt did not name: she answers one irreversibility with another. Her mother's death cannot be undone; but a tree, once grown, cannot be ungrown. Against the irreversibility of destruction she sets the irreversibility of growth. In the thermodynamic vocabulary with which this thesis began, Erwin Schrödinger's *What Is Life?* (1944) described

living things as systems that maintain their order by feeding on negative entropy, drawing order from their surroundings against the universal tendency toward dissipation. The tree that feeds on the tyrant is a local reversal of the Wasteland's entropy: a living order drawn, quite literally, from the body of the man who embodied its disorder. The Erinyic economy, which converted stored energy into heat and death, is answered by an economy of germination that converts death into fruit.

The film is careful, finally, not to guarantee the truth of its own ending. The History Man presents the tree as the version Furiosa told him, and commentators have rightly noted that a tree growing from a living body belongs to the register of legend rather than to the saga's usual material realism. The ambiguity is the point. The tree is the myth that Furiosa chose to tell about her own vengeance, and the myth the chronicler chose to transmit. Whether or not it happened, it is the story by which the Citadel's new founders will understand where their fruit came from. A culture is defined by the stories it chooses to keep, and the saga ends with a choice of story: not the epic of a death, but the georgic of a harvest grown from it.

6.8 The Saga Completed: The Peach for the Wives and the End as Beginning

The film's last scene returns its protagonist to the place of her imprisonment. Raised by Immortan Joe to the rank of Imperator after the defeat of the Horde, and given command of a new War Rig, Furiosa enters the vault where Joe once held her captive and where his five Wives are now held, and she shows them a peach from the tree. On the night before her next supply run the Wives hide in her Rig, and the film's final images join the beginning of *Fury Road*, whose scenes run beneath the closing credits. The saga's last-made film ends where its predecessor began.

The peach is the hinge between the two films, and its passage from Furiosa to the Wives is the transmission of the Green Place's principle into the vault. The women whom Joe keeps as vessels for his heirs receive, from the hand of the woman who escaped that fate, the fruit of a tree grown from a tyrant's body. It is a eucharist inverted. In the Christian rite the faithful eat the body of the god who gave himself for them; here the captives taste the fruit of the body of a tyrant who took everything from the woman who feeds them. The first food of the liberation is the transmuted flesh of its enemy. And the vault, which in *Fury Road* will be found empty, its walls inscribed with the Wives' testament, is shown here at the moment when the testament becomes possible: the moment at which the captives taste something that has grown.

The structure of the saga is thereby completed as a ring. Chapter Five read *Fury Road* as a ring composition that departs from the Citadel and returns to it transformed. *Furiosa* closes a larger ring at the scale of the saga itself: the film made last tells the story that comes first in its protagonist's life, and its ending is the beginning of the film that preceded it in the order of making. Mary, Queen of Scots, embroidered upon her cloth of state the motto *En ma fin gît mon commencement*—in my end lies my beginning—and the saga's final film enacts it to the letter. Even its minor figures take part in the rhyme. The child Valkyrie who picks peaches beside Furiosa in the opening scene of *Furiosa* is the woman who, in *Fury Road*, stands on a tower in the desert to lure the travellers to the Vuvalini, and who recognises in the Imperator the girl who was stolen from the orchard.

The film's reception adds an ironic coda. *Furiosa* received highly favourable reviews and appeared on many critics' lists of the best films of its year, but it grossed some $174 million worldwide against a reported production budget of $168 million and was widely described as a box-office failure. The saga's most explicitly georgic film—the one that refuses its villain an epic death and ends with the planting of a tree—was the least commercially successful of its modern instalments. It would be facile to make much of the coincidence, and the industry's own explanations, among them the weak market for prequels, are plausible. But the thesis may be permitted to observe that the culture of spectacle rewarded the saga most richly when it offered the epic, and least when it offered the georgic.

A more serious limitation concerns the Green Place itself. Its orchards grow peaches—*Prunus persica*, a fruit domesticated in China and carried westward through Persia, from which it took its European name, to Europe and eventually, with the colonists, to Australia. The saga's image of a restored relation to the land is an orchard: a settler-agrarian ideal of cultivation rather than the forms of care for Country practised for tens of thousands of years by the continent's Aboriginal peoples, whose management of land by fire and by seasonal harvest Bill Gammage's *The Biggest Estate on Earth* (2011) brought into wide public consciousness, and whose characterisation as agriculture has been vigorously contested since Bruce Pascoe's *Dark Emu* (2014) and Peter Sutton and Keryn Walshe's reply, *Farmers or Hunter-Gatherers?* (2021). Stephen Morgan argued at the film's release that *Furiosa* did little to address the franchise's long-standing difficulty with Australia's colonial past. The criticism is just. The Eumenidean turn, as the saga stages it, remains within the settler imagination: the Furies are buried in an orchard planted upon land whose first custodians the saga never shows. The final chapter of this thesis will return to this limit, which is also the limit of the saga's hope.

The saga is complete. Its five films, read as variants of a single myth, describe a trajectory from the exhaustion of law in 1979, through the economy of fire and the expulsion of the scapegoat, to the Eumenidean settlement of 2015 and its genealogy in 2024: from a Fury born on the highway to a Fury who plants a tree. The next chapter turns from the saga's argument to its form—to the kinetic liturgy through which the myth is made present to its audiences—and to its afterlives across the media of the speculative imagination.

Sources for Chapter Six. Plot particulars, chapter titles, and production and box-office figures for *Furiosa* were checked against Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga (Wikipedia) <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Furiosa:_A_Mad_Max_Saga>. Critical commentary cited: Oli Mould, "Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga – blink and you'll miss a solarpunk alternative to series' usual dystopia" <https://theconversation.com/furiosa-a-mad-max-saga-blink-and-youll-miss-a-solarpunk-alternative-to-series-usual-dystopia-230460>, *The Conversation*, 3 June 2024; Stephen Morgan, "Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga does little to address the franchise's frustrating attitude towards Australia's dark past" <https://theconversation.com/furiosa-a-mad-max-saga-does-little-to-address-the-franchises-frustrating-attitude-towards-australias-dark-past-230932>, *The Conversation*, 29 May 2024.

VII

CHAPTER SEVEN

Kinetic Liturgy

Pure Cinema, the Chase as Rite, and the Afterlives of the Wasteland

Liturgy in Motion: Form as Argument 7.1

The preceding chapters have read the saga's argument: its mythic structure, its political theology, its ethics of conversion. This chapter turns to its form, on the premise announced in Chapter One—that Miller's kinetic cinema is not a vehicle for the saga's meaning but a constituent of it, and that the chase functions in these films not merely as spectacle but as liturgy. The claim requires a distinction that the performance theorist Richard Schechner drew in *Performance Theory* (1977; revised 1988) between efficacy and entertainment. All performance, Schechner argued, is braided from the two. Efficacious performance, of which ritual is the paradigm, aims to transform—to heal, to initiate, to found—and its audience participates; entertaining performance aims to please, and its audience watches. No performance is purely one or the other; their proportions shift with history, and the theatre of an age can be read by the balance it strikes.

The commercial action film belongs, by its institutional situation, to the pole of entertainment. The argument of this chapter is that the Mad Max saga, and *Fury Road* above all, pulls the action film back toward the pole of efficacy: that its audiences do not merely watch a chase but undergo one, and that the undergoing is the form in which the saga's myth is made present to them. The liturgical claim was introduced in Chapter One through its etymology. A *leitourgia* was the public work by which an Athenian citizen financed the festivals of the polis, and the *choregia* that staged the *Oresteia* was its most prestigious form. A liturgy is the public work through which a community makes its myth present to itself; the modern cinema, in its rare moments of ritual efficacy, is such a work.

The claim is pursued in four movements. The first traces the saga's formal genealogy to the silent cinema and the cinema of attractions, whose legibility without words Miller has sought throughout his career (7.2). The second follows the evolution of the saga's grammar of velocity, from the crash zoom of 1979 to the centre-framed montage of 2015 and the expanded durations of 2024 (7.3). The third reads the chase as rite, through the anthropology of ritual and the theory of play (7.4). The fourth considers the saga's colour, sound, and voice, and the monochrome editions in which its maker has recast it (7.5). The chapter then follows the saga's afterlives —in comics and animation (7.6), in games and festivals (7.7), and in the speculative literature and cinema with which it forms a constellation (7.8). Its conclusion is that the saga is not only a member of that constellation but its history: the one work in which the speculative imagination of the end of the fossil age travels, across its own duration, from the pole of fire to the pole of seed.

7.2 Before Words: Keaton, the Phantom Ride, and the Cinema of Attractions

Miller has repeatedly located the source of his cinematic ideal in the silent era. The chase comedies of Buster Keaton and Harold Lloyd, he has said, showed what cinema could do when it communicated through motion alone—a visual music, legible to any audience in any language. The ideal has governed the saga's development. The first film was conceived as an action picture whose drama would be carried by vehicles and bodies rather than by speech; *Fury Road* was designed as a sequence of storyboards before it possessed a screenplay, and its dialogue is famously sparse; and Anya Taylor-Joy has observed that she speaks only some thirty lines in *Furiosa*, a film of nearly two and a half hours in which she plays the title role. Alfred Hitchcock, in his conversations with François Truffaut (1966), called this ideal pure cinema: the construction of meaning by the juxtaposition of images rather than by the recording of talk. The Mad Max films are among the purest cinema the industrial blockbuster has produced.

Keaton's *The General* (1926) is the saga's formal ancestor. A feature-length chase on and around a locomotive during the American Civil War, it generates its narrative, its characters, and its comedy entirely from the logistics of motion: who is pursuing whom, on what track, with what fuel, around which obstacle. The locomotive is fed with wood, which pursuers and pursued alike must cut and load as they go, so that the chase is an economy of fuel as well as of speed. *The General* is the first great cinematic meditation on the motive power of fire, and *Fury Road* is its

grandchild: a chase out and back along a single route, whose characters are defined by what they do with vehicles, and in which the fuel that drives the pursuit is also its stake.

Behind Keaton lies the earliest cinema, which Tom Gunning, in an influential essay of 1986, named the cinema of attractions: a cinema not yet organised around narrative absorption, which addressed its spectators directly with displays of novelty, motion, and shock. Among its most popular forms was the phantom ride, in which a camera mounted on the front of a train carried audiences into the landscape at speed, and the travel attractions such as Hale's Tours, which from the middle of the century's first decade seated audiences in mock railway carriages before projected scenes of motion. The founding myth of the medium—that the first audiences of the Lumière brothers' film of a train entering a station fled in terror from the screen—is apocryphal, but its persistence records a truth about what audiences came for: the sensation of a machine bearing down upon them. *Fury Road* returns to this origin with a fully industrial apparatus. Its camera rides the vehicles, hangs from cranes above them, and races alongside them, and its address to the audience is as direct as the phantom ride's. Gunning observed that the attraction never disappeared from cinema but went underground into certain genres; in Miller's films it surfaces again as the organising principle of the whole.

The attraction received its revolutionary theory in Sergei Eisenstein's "The Montage of Attractions" (1923), which defined the attraction as any aggressive moment that subjects the spectator to a calculated sensual or psychological impact, and proposed to assemble such moments into a montage that would produce in the audience not passive reception but an active shock of thought. Eisenstein's attraction was political; its purpose was to move the masses toward revolution. Miller's attraction is mythic; its purpose is to carry the audience through a rite. But both rest on the conviction that cinema's power lies not in representation but in impact, and that the order of impacts can be composed like music. Miller's figure of visual music is, in this sense, Eisensteinian. The montage of *Fury Road* is a score of impacts, arranged in movements, with tempi, crescendi, and rests.

The silent heritage has one further consequence, which bears directly on the saga's myth. A cinema that communicates without words is a cinema that can travel without translation, and the saga's worldwide reception—the reception that led Miller to Campbell—was made possible by its relative independence of language. The first film's Japanese, Scandinavian, and French audiences could recognise their own heroes in Max because the film did not require them to understand his speech; there was almost none to understand. Myth, in the form the saga gives it, is precisely what survives translation: the pattern of action that every audience can read. The

saga's silence is the condition of its universality, and its universality is the condition of its being received, everywhere, as myth.

7.3 The Grammar of Velocity: From the Crash Zoom to Centre-Framing

The saga's formal history is a history of the grammar of speed. The first film, made on a budget that precluded elaborate effects, developed a vocabulary of improvised intensity: cameras mounted low on vehicles, inches above the bitumen; undercranked footage that accelerated the action on projection; and crash zooms into the faces of drivers in the instant before impact, culminating in the extreme close-ups of widening eyes that Chapter Two read as the casualty officer's gaze. Brian May's score, in the tradition of Bernard Herrmann's orchestral suspense, supplied the pulse. The grammar was crude and it was new. It established the road as a space of terror experienced from inside the vehicle, at the height of the wheel.

Mad Max 2 refined this vocabulary into a classical form. Dean Semler's anamorphic photography of the plains around Broken Hill gave the Wasteland its scale; the climactic chase, sustained for the better part of a reel, established the template of the action sequence as an extended, continuous movement through space; and the cutting, rapid for its time, preserved geographic clarity. By one published count, *Mad Max 2* contains some 1,200 cuts. *Fury Road* contains more than 2,700, assembled by Margaret Sixel from roughly 480 hours of footage over a post-production that occupied years—the work of an editor whose previous experience lay not in action cinema but in documentary and in Miller's family films. The figures measure an acceleration, but they do not explain why the later film, cut more than twice as fast, remains legible.

The explanation lies in a principle of composition that Miller imposed upon the shoot, and that the editor Vashi Nedomansky's widely circulated analysis, "Mad Max: Center Framed" (2015), made famous. Miller instructed his operators to keep the point of interest in each shot at the centre of the frame—in the crosshairs, as he put it—so that the spectator's eye, arriving from one shot at the centre of the screen, would find the object of attention already there in the next, without needing to search for it. Centre-framing allowed shots to be cut short, at a velocity that would otherwise produce confusion, without costing the spectator orientation. The principle is the formal correlate of the saga's ethics of witness. The War Boys cry to be witnessed; Max is the witness who cannot stop seeing; and the film's grammar

is designed so that the spectator can always see—so that, at the highest speed that popular cinema had yet sustained, the eye is never lost.

The principle sets *Fury Road* against the dominant tendency of the action cinema of its decade. David Bordwell's "Intensified Continuity" (2002) described the stylistic transformation of American popular film since the 1960s—faster cutting, closer framing, a more mobile camera—as an intensification rather than an abandonment of classical continuity. The critic Matthias Stork's video essays on "chaos cinema" (2011) argued that in the action films of the 2000s this intensification had tipped into incoherence: rapid cutting, shaking cameras, and fragmented space producing the sensation of action without its comprehension. *Fury Road* is the refutation of chaos cinema from within the intensified style. It cuts faster than most of the films Stork analysed, and it is almost never spatially confused. Its velocity is legible because its maker treated legibility as an obligation to the spectator—the obligation, in the terms of this thesis, not to make the audience a blind participant in the violence it watches.

The colour of *Fury Road* completes its grammar. The film's days are graded toward saturated oranges and teals that make the desert a furnace; its nights, filmed in daylight and graded to a deep artificial blue, make the darkness a dream. The grade abolishes naturalism in favour of legibility and myth. The desert of *Fury Road* is less a place than a palette, a space in which the elements of the action stand out against a ground simplified to essentials.

Furiosa alters the grammar again, and the alteration is significant. The film spans some fifteen years rather than three days; it is divided into chapters; and its rhythm alternates long movements of pursuit with passages in which time, rather than space, is traversed. Miller's collaborators have described his search for a different style—Tom Burke recalled that Miller wished to film a scene in which Dementus taunts Jack and Furiosa in a single take—and the film relies far more than *Fury Road* on digital compositing, much of its desert having been built in post-production. Its great exception is the "Stowaway" sequence, the assault on the War Rig, which took seventy-eight days to film with close to two hundred stunt performers working each day. But the film's centre of gravity has shifted from velocity to duration. If *Fury Road* is the action-image raised to its limit, *Furiosa* is the saga's turn toward the time-image that Chapter One anticipated: a film about how a person is made over years, whose climax is not a crash but a growth.

7.4 The Chase as Rite: Liminality, Effervescence, and Play

If the chase is liturgy, it must possess the structure of rite, and the anthropology of ritual supplies it. Arnold van Gennep's tripartite rite of passage, introduced in Chapter Two, was developed by Victor Turner into an account of the liminal phase: the threshold condition, betwixt and between, in which the participants of a rite have left their former status and not yet assumed their new one, and in which there arises among them what Turner called *communitas*, an intense and egalitarian bond that suspends the ordinary hierarchies of social life (*The Ritual Process*, 1969). The road in the Mad Max saga is the liminal zone par excellence. It lies between the settlements; it suspends their laws; and on it bonds are formed that the settlements could not permit—between the Imperator and the fugitive Wives, between the blood bag and the War Boy, between Max and Furiosa. The War Rig in flight is a capsule of *communitas*: a vehicle in which an Imperator, five escaped breeders, a captive, and a defecting War Boy become, for the duration of the passage, equals.

Turner also proposed that social life is punctuated by what he called social dramas, which unfold in four phases: a breach of the norms governing social relations; a crisis in which the breach widens; redressive action, often ritual or legal, by which the community attempts to repair it; and, finally, either reintegration or the recognition of an irreparable schism. *Fury Road* is a social drama in Turner's precise sense. The breach is the Wives' escape; the crisis is the pursuit; the redress is the turn on the salt and the return; the reintegration is the refoundation of the Citadel and the release of its waters. That the film's form follows the anthropologist's schema so exactly is not a sign of derivativeness but of depth. The chase has been shaped, as rites are shaped, to carry a community through the passage from one order to another.

The audience is drawn into the rite. Émile Durkheim's *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912) described the collective effervescence that seizes a gathered group in ritual—an exaltation in which individuals feel themselves carried by a force greater than any of them, and which Durkheim took to be the origin of the experience of the sacred. The cinema of attractions has always traded in a diluted version of this effervescence, and *Fury Road* concentrates it. Within the fiction, the Doof Warrior—a blind musician strapped before a wall of amplifiers on a speeding truck, playing a flame-throwing guitar while drummers pound behind him—is the war party's engine of effervescence, descendant of the trumpeters of the Roman triumph, of the drummers of armies on the march, and of the pipes and tambourines of the Dionysian procession. Outside the fiction, the audience receives the same rhythm

through the score and the sound design. The film's music is not a commentary upon the rite but a participant in it.

The rite of the chase is also a form of play, and Roger Caillois's *Man, Play and Games* (1958) supplies its taxonomy. Caillois distinguished four fundamental forms of play: *agon*, the contest; *alea*, the game of chance; *mimicry*, the play of masks and simulation; and *ilinx*, the pursuit of vertigo, the voluntary disruption of perception by speed, spinning, or falling. The saga is an encyclopaedia of Caillois's categories. Thunderdome is *agon* in its purest form; Bartertown's wheel is *alea*; the War Boys' cult, with its chrome, its scarifications, and its ritual cries, is *mimicry*; and the chase itself is *ilinx*—vertigo sought and sustained, the deliberate abandonment of stable perception to speed. Caillois warned, moreover, that each form of play has a corrupted form when it escapes the bounded space of the game into ordinary life: *agon* becomes violence, *alea* superstition, *mimicry* alienation, *ilinx* intoxication. The Wasteland is the world in which play has escaped its bounds—in which the contest, the lottery, the mask, and the vertigo have become the conditions of everyday existence. The saga's afterlife in games and festivals, examined below, returns them to the bounded space from which they escaped.

The ideology of the chase has a precise modern origin, and it begins with a crash. "The Founding and Manifesto of Futurism," published by Filippo Tommaso Marinetti on the front page of *Le Figaro* in February 1909, opens with a narrative: the poet and his friends race their automobiles through the dawn, swerve to avoid two cyclists, and overturn into a factory ditch full of muddy water, from which Marinetti emerges reborn, hailing the ditch as maternal and its sludge as nourishment. The manifesto that follows proclaims a roaring motor car "more beautiful than the Victory of Samothrace," glorifies war as the world's only hygiene, and celebrates speed, aggression, and the destruction of museums. The War Boys are Marinetti's Futurists made flesh: young men reborn from the crash, worshipping the machine as more beautiful than any goddess, glorifying war, and seeking their apotheosis in a death at speed. Walter Benjamin, as Chapter Six recalled, quoted Marinetti's later celebration of war in the epilogue to his essay on the work of art, as the clearest instance of the aestheticisation of politics. The War Boys are the Futurist manifesto's last readers, and Furiosa its most decisive refutation.

Paul Virilio's *War and Cinema: The Logistics of Perception* (1984) argued that the histories of cinema and of war are entangled at their roots—that the camera and the gun, the projector and the searchlight, the film and the reconnaissance photograph developed together, and that modern war is conducted as much through the management of perception as through the destruction of bodies. *Fury Road* stages this entanglement in its central ritual cry. "Witness me" is a demand addressed to a

gaze; the War Boys' deaths are performances designed to be seen, and their value lies entirely in their being witnessed. The camera is the War Boys' god before Immortan Joe is. The film's ethic of centre-framing, read in this light, is a counter-logistics of perception: a form that makes the spectator see clearly, and therefore see what the spectacle costs.

7.5 Black, Chrome, and Sound

In 2016 Miller released a monochrome version of *Fury Road*, the "Black & Chrome" edition, which he has described as his preferred version of the film; in 2024 he gave *Furiosa* the same treatment. The monochrome editions are not curiosities. They recast the saga's most spectacular films in the visual register of the archive—the register of the newsreels with which *Mad Max 2* opened, of the silent cinema whose legibility Miller has always sought, and of the photographic record of the twentieth century's wars. In black and white the furnace-orange desert becomes a field of greys, the blue nights become silver, and the vehicles become forms of chrome and shadow. The effect is to historicise the films: to transform them from spectacles of the present into documents of a legend.

The edition's title makes a further point. Chrome is the War Boys' sacrament: the paint they spray upon their mouths before death, the promise of a Valhalla in which they will ride "shiny and chrome." In the monochrome edition everything is chrome. The whole world of the film takes on the metallic sheen that the War Boys' theology reserved for the afterlife, and the effect is not glorification but estrangement. Walter Benjamin's analysis of the aura—the unique presence of the work of art in time and space, which technological reproduction withers—suggests one reading: the monochrome edition restores to the film, by subtraction, an auratic distance that its colour version, with its overwhelming immediacy, had abolished. The chase is held at the distance of memory, and the spectator watches it as one watches the legend of a world already gone.

Sound in the saga follows the same trajectory as image, from immediacy toward myth. Brian May's orchestral scores for the first two films supplied the conventions of the suspense thriller; Maurice Jarre's score for *Beyond Thunderdome*, with Tina Turner's songs, reached for a broader epic and popular register. Tom Holkenborg's score for *Fury Road*, which he has called an over-the-top rock opera, fused orchestral and percussive forces with the diegetic music of the Doof Wagon, so that the film's music seems to arise from the war party itself; the film's sound editing and sound mixing won two of its six Academy Awards. For *Furiosa*, Holkenborg has said,

Miller wanted a far more restrained score, told from its protagonist's perspective, and asked him not to reuse a celebrated cue from *Fury Road* during the Bullet Farm sequence, so that the audience's attention would remain on Furiosa's sacrifice of her best chance of returning home. The progression from the war party's percussion to the score of a single consciousness parallels the saga's movement from the collective rite of the chase to the inner history of a person.

Within this soundscape the human voice is scarce, and its scarcity is meaningful. The saga's soundtracks are dominated by engines—the roar of the V8, the whine of superchargers, the drone of motorcycles—which function as the voices of the machines that rule the Wasteland. Against them the human voice is rare. Max speaks little in any film; Furiosa speaks barely more; the Wives speak most eloquently when they write. When a human voice does carry decisive weight in the saga, it is the voice of a narrator—the aged Feral Kid, Savannah's Tell, the First History Man, the History Man—speaking over the images from a time after them. The saga's acoustic theology is the inverse of the War Boys'. The engines are loud, but the voice that tells the story is quiet, and it is the quiet voice that survives. The last words of every film after the first belong not to the machines but to the teller.

The point can be put in the terms with which this thesis began. The Erinyic economy is an economy of noise: combustion is audible, and its sound is the sound of energy irreversibly spent. The economy of replenishment is an economy of the voice and of silence: of the story told, the seed planted, the water falling. The saga's soundtracks move, across forty-five years, from the scream of the engine toward the voice of the chronicler, and in that movement they enact acoustically the conversion that its narratives enact in plot.

Afterlives in Image and Print: From Moebius to Tank Girl 7.6

The saga has been imitated more widely than almost any other body of popular cinema, but its relation to the visual culture around it runs in both directions. Before *Mad Max*, the Franco-Belgian magazine *Métal hurlant* had published, from 1975, Moebius's *Arzach*, a sequence of wordless stories in which a silent rider on a pterodactyl crosses desert landscapes of eerie emptiness; Alejandro Jodorowsky's *El Topo* (1970) had made the desert the setting of a gunfighter's mystical pilgrimage among masters, cripples, and the deformed inhabitants of a cave; and the British weekly *2000 AD* had sent Judge Dredd across "The Cursed Earth" (1978), the irradiated wilderness beyond the walls of Mega-City One. These are relations of convergence.

In the same decade, the European comic avant-garde, the Latin American underground cinema, and the British adventure weekly arrived, independently of one another and of Miller, at a shared imagination of the desert as a space of silent, violent, and metaphysical journeying—the landscape that the saga would make its own.

After *Mad Max 2*, the influence is direct. *Fist of the North Star* (*Hokuto no Ken*), written by Buronson and drawn by Tetsuo Hara for *Weekly Shōnen Jump* from 1983, transposed the saga's world—the post-nuclear desert, the leather-clad gangs, the mohawks and spiked shoulders, the lone wanderer who protects the weak—into a martial-arts epic whose hero, Kenshiro, owes much of his iconography to Max; through its manga and its animated adaptation it carried the Road Warrior's look across East Asia and beyond. Katsuhiro Otomo's *Akira* (manga 1982–90; film 1988) made the biker gang the protagonist of a post-catastrophic Neo-Tokyo, its youths bound, like the Toecutter's gang, by machines and loyalty, and its plot, like the saga's, a meditation on what happens when buried power is released.

Hayao Miyazaki's *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (manga 1982–94; film 1984) offered the most profound counter-myth that the saga's wasteland has received from another medium. Its world, a thousand years after a war called the Seven Days of Fire, is being overgrown by the Sea of Corruption, a toxic forest of fungi and giant insects that human beings fear and try to burn. Nausicaä discovers that the forest is not destroying the world but healing it: its trees draw the poison from the soil and, dying, leave pure water and clean sand beneath them. The decay that humans fear is the earth's purification. *Nausicaä* is the humic-chthonic made into an epic, and its heroine's refusal of the logic of burning—her insistence on understanding the corruption rather than incinerating it—anticipates by three decades the Eumenidean turn of *Fury Road* and *Furiosa*. Where the saga's sovereigns hoard the clean water of the depths, Miyazaki's forest manufactures it from decay; where the War Boys seek apotheosis in fire, Nausicaä seeks reconciliation with what grows in the rot.

One further afterlife demands attention, because it anticipated Furiosa so precisely. *Tank Girl*, created by Jamie Hewlett and Alan Martin for the British magazine *Deadline* in 1988, follows a shaven-headed, anarchic young woman who lives in a tank in a post-apocalyptic Australia, in the company of a mutant kangaroo, and wages a punk guerrilla war against the authorities. Tank Girl is the road warrior refigured as a woman, more than a quarter of a century before *Fury Road* and in the same Australian desert. Her irreverence is the opposite of Furiosa's gravity, but the figure—the woman who commands the war vehicle in the wasteland—was available to the culture long before the saga claimed it. Rachel Talalay's film adaptation (1995), set in a drought-stricken future in which a single corporation controls the world's

remaining water, made the anticipation more exact still: a hydraulic despotism, a desert, and a shaven-headed woman driving against it.

The saga has also extended itself in print. The comic-book prequels to *Fury Road* published by DC's Vertigo imprint in 2015, co-written by Miller with Nico Lathouris and the artist Mark Sexton, supplied backstories for Nux, Immortan Joe, Furiosa, and Max, and Miller has spoken of the larger body of lore written in preparation for *Fury Road*, from which *Furiosa* grew and from which a further film, provisionally titled *The Wasteland*, may yet be drawn. The saga's myth is surrounded by an apocrypha of its own—a penumbra of texts in which its variants multiply, as the variants of any living myth do. The comics, like the films, disagree with one another in detail, and the disagreement is, once again, the signature of a legend still being told.

Afterlives in Play and Festival: The Wasteland as Game and Habitus 7.7

The saga's most extensive afterlife is in play. The computer role-playing game *Wasteland* (Interplay, 1988) and its spiritual successor *Fallout* (Interplay, 1997) made the post-nuclear desert the most enduring setting of the interactive medium. *Fallout* acknowledged its debt with a canine homage: its companion dog, Dogmeat, could be recruited by a player wearing a leather jacket, in tribute to the dog that follows the leather-clad Max in *Mad Max 2*. The series' famous opening refrain—that war never changes—makes the saga's premise of a world consumed by its wars into the axiom of a franchise, and its retro-futurist vision of an America whose nuclear optimism ended in nuclear fire extends the saga's petro-eschaton into the atomic register that *Beyond Thunderdome* had already invoked.

The saga's own game, *Mad Max* (Avalanche Studios, 2015), released in the year of *Fury Road*, contains the most explicit theology of combustion in the entire corpus. Its hero is accompanied by Chumbucket, a hunchbacked mechanic whose religion centres on a feminine deity he calls the Angel Combustion. He calls his workshop his tabernacle, fills it with an iconography that blends cave-drawing with engineering blueprint, and believes that Max has been sent to him as a saint to help complete the car he regards as the Angel made steel, the Magnum Opus. The figure is a startling commentary upon Henry Adams's opposition of Dynamo and Virgin. Chumbucket has fused them: he worships the dynamo as a Virgin, the engine as an angel, combustion as a woman. Adams lamented that modernity had learned to worship the dynamo and been ashamed of the Virgin; Chumbucket solves the

problem by making the dynamo the Virgin. The character returned, in the flesh, in *Furiosa*, as a mechanic of the Citadel. He is the saga's purest image of the dynamo-cult: a religion in which the force of fertility has been so completely absorbed by the force of the machine that the only Virgin left to pray to is the engine.

Against this theology the interactive medium has also produced its counter-myths. Hideo Kojima's *Death Stranding* (2019) opens with a passage from the Japanese novelist Kōbō Abe's story "The Rope," which observes that the stick and the rope are among humanity's oldest tools—the one to keep bad things away, the other to bring good things close—and it builds an entire game around the second. Its protagonist is a porter who carries cargo on foot across a ruined America to reconnect isolated communities; the player's labour is the labour of carrying, balancing, and delivering, and the game's highest value is connection. *Death Stranding* is the carrier-bag theory of fiction made into a game mechanic: Le Guin's container set against the hero's spear, Abe's rope against the stick. Guerrilla Games' *Horizon Zero Dawn* (2017) imagines a far-future America in which a matriarchal people, the Nora, who revere an All-Mother, live among the ruins of a machine apocalypse, and whose heroine discovers that the world's restoration was the work of a terraforming intelligence designed to remake life after the machines consumed the biosphere. Both games occupy the pole toward which the saga moved in its last films: from the logic of combustion toward the logic of carrying, connecting, and regrowing.

The saga has passed, too, from the screen into the field. At Burning Man, the annual gathering in Nevada's Black Rock Desert, a recreation of the Thunderdome has for many years staged bouts between harnessed combatants before crowds clinging to its frame. Wasteland Weekend, held each year since 2010 in the Mojave Desert of California, gathers thousands of participants in costumes and vehicles modelled on the saga's for several days of collective inhabitation of its world. In Australia, the town of Silverton, near Broken Hill, where *Mad Max 2* was filmed, maintains a museum devoted to the film; and in the 1980s a professional wrestling tag team took the name The Road Warriors and carried the saga's spiked shoulders and painted faces into another arena of ritualised combat. These are not mere fan practices. They are the saga's myth undergoing the process every living myth undergoes: re-enactment by communities who use it to organise their own collective experience. In Caillois's terms they are *mimicry* and *ilinx* returned to the bounded space of play; in Durkheim's, effervescent assemblies; in Turner's, liminal festivals, temporary communities of *communitas* in the desert. The Wasteland has become a habitus in Pierre Bourdieu's sense: a set of durable dispositions that its participants embody, perform, and transmit.

The saga's name has also become a figure of public discourse. In debates about energy security, climate breakdown, and civil disorder, a "Mad Max scenario" names the collapse of the social order into a violent competition for resources; the saga's title has become, like Orwell's name, an adjective for a political fear. That the saga itself moved, across its last two films, from the depiction of that collapse toward the imagination of its conversion has not yet altered the meaning of the phrase. The culture has learned the saga's first lesson, and not yet its last.

The Speculative Constellation: Fire-Carriers and Seed-Carriers 7.8

The saga belongs to a constellation of speculative works across literature and cinema that, since the oil shocks, have imagined the end of the fossil world and its aftermath. The constellation can be organised along a single axis, which this thesis has traced through the saga itself: the axis that runs between fire and seed. At one pole stand the fire-carriers, works in which the meaning of survival is the preservation of a flame—the light of civilisation, of goodness, of the human—through a darkness that threatens to extinguish it. At the other stand the seed-carriers, works in which survival means not the preservation of the old fire but the planting of something new.

Cormac McCarthy's *The Road* (2006) is the definitive work of the first pole. Its father and son walk south through a burnt, ash-covered America, among cannibals, toward a coast that offers no rescue, and the father tells the boy that they are "carrying the fire": the moral flame of the good that must be kept alive in a world that has lost it. The image is magnificent, and its relation to the saga is instructive. McCarthy's fire is the flame of human goodness, and it must be carried. The saga's fire is combustion, and it must be buried. McCarthy's novel closes with a vision of the brook trout of the mountain streams of the world before, a beauty that cannot be restored; the saga closes with a peach tree that can be planted. The difference is not between hope and despair but between two theologies of survival: one that preserves what was, and one that converts what was into what will grow. Emily St. John Mandel's *Station Eleven* (2014), whose travelling troupe performs Shakespeare among the survivors of a pandemic beneath a motto declaring that survival is insufficient, belongs to the fire-carriers too. Its flame is art, carried from settlement to settlement as the Tell is carried among the lost children of *Beyond Thunderdome*.

The cinema of the fire-carriers includes the films with which the saga is most often compared. Bong Joon-ho's *Snowpiercer* (2013), adapted from the French graphic novel *Le Transperceneige* (1982), imagines the last of humanity circling a frozen earth

aboard a train whose engine is revered as sacred and eternal, and whose maintenance, it emerges, depends upon the labour of children small enough to replace its worn parts—a theology of the engine as exact as the War Boys'. Its revolution proceeds car by car from the tail to the engine, a linear chase toward the sovereign; and its ending, in which the train derails and two survivors step out into the snow to see a living animal, discovers, like *Fury Road*, that the only future lies outside the machine. Alfonso Cuarón's *Children of Men* (2006), adapted from P. D. James's novel of 1992, imagines a world without births, in which a burnt-out man as reluctant as Max escorts the first pregnant woman in eighteen years toward a ship called *Tomorrow*. Its sovereign order is sterile rather than possessive, but its pregnant refugee is a sister of the Wives. And David Michôd's *The Rover* (2014), shot in the South Australian outback and set a decade after an unexplained collapse, follows a laconic man pursuing the thieves of his car across a desert of decaying towns. When the car is recovered, its secret is revealed: it carries not fuel or money but the body of the man's dead dog, which he wishes to bury. *The Rover*, the saga's most austere Australian descendant, ends in a burial—the fire-carrier's narrative turning, at its last moment, toward the ground.

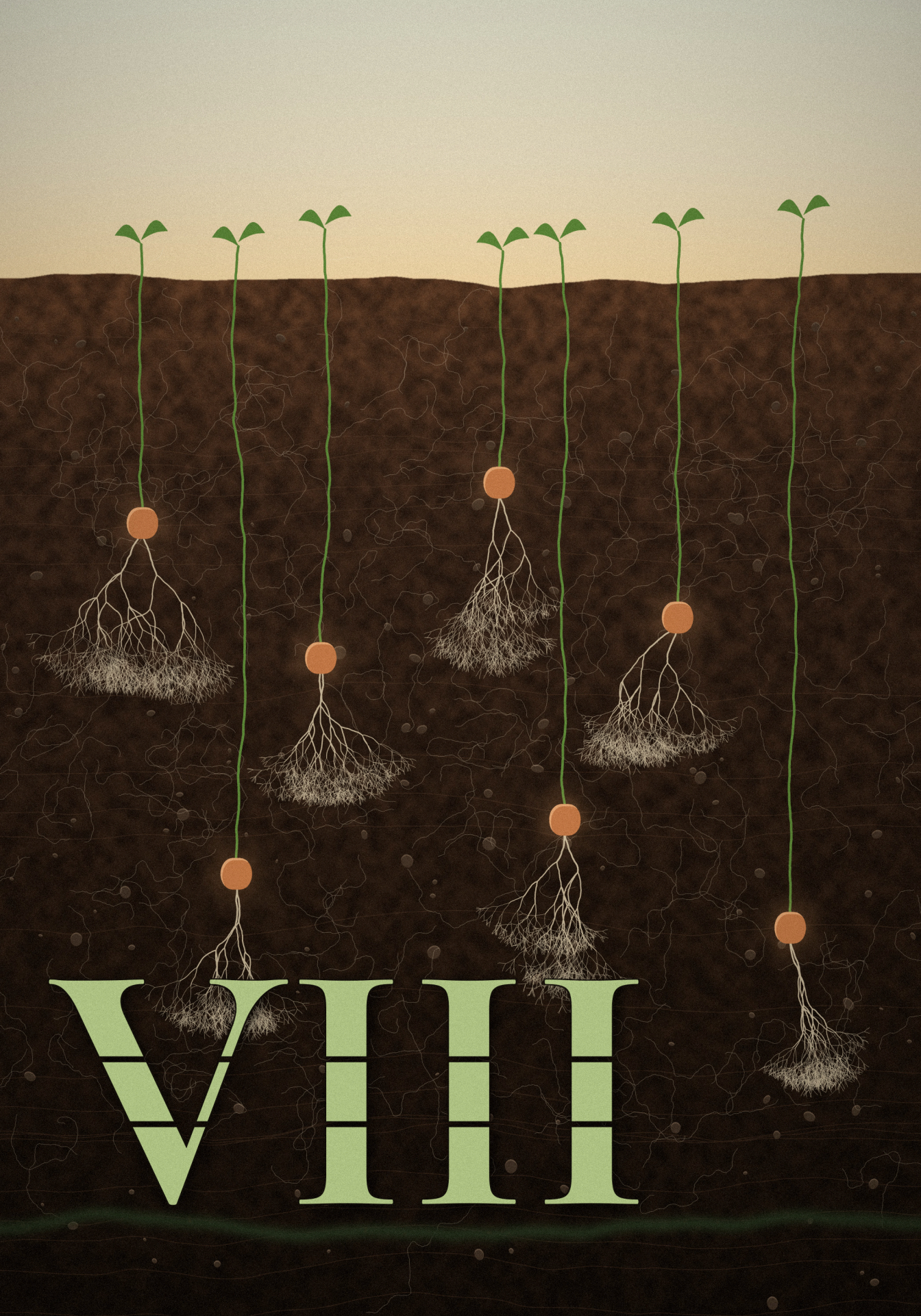
At the other pole stand the seed-carriers. Octavia E. Butler's *Parable of the Sower* (1993) and *Parable of the Talents* (1998) follow Lauren Olamina, a young woman in a collapsing California of the 2020s, who leads a band of refugees north along the highways and founds as she goes a new faith she calls Earthseed, whose central teaching is that God is Change and whose destiny is to take root among the stars. Butler's novels are the closest literary counterpart to Furiosa's arc: a woman's journey along a road of violence and scarcity toward the foundation of a community whose name and theology are a seed. Le Guin's *Always Coming Home*, discussed in Chapter Four, belongs to this pole, as does Herbert's *Dune*, with its ecologist's dream of a desert made green, and Miyazaki's *Nausicaä*, with its forest that heals the poisoned earth, stands at its furthest point. The speculative mode that the twenty-first century has named solarpunk—an optimistic genre imagining societies reconciled with ecology and renewable energy—has defined itself explicitly against the dieselpunk aesthetic of which the Mad Max saga is the canonical example, even as the saga, in the opening minutes of *Furiosa*, offered a glimpse of the solarpunk world that the Wasteland destroyed.

The saga's place in this constellation is unique in one respect: it traverses the axis. It begins at the pole of fire, in a first film whose only value is the combustion of vengeance; it passes through films in which the fire is carried in the form of legend and story; and it arrives, in its last two films, at the pole of the seed. No other work in the constellation makes the journey from one pole to the other across its own

duration. The saga is not only a member of the speculative imagination of the end of the fossil age. It is that imagination's history, compressed into five variants of a single myth, moving—haltingly, ambiguously, at great cost—from the fire that must be carried to the fire that must be buried, and from the burial of the fire to the planting of the seed.

The final chapter of this thesis draws these threads together into a theory of the saga's ultimate horizon: a humic eschatology, which imagines the end of the fossil world not as an apocalypse to be survived, nor as a loss to be mourned, but as the Eumenidean labour of returning the chthonic powers to the ground.

Sources for Chapter Seven. Editing statistics and centre-framing: Margaret Sixel (Wikipedia) <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Margaret_Sixel>; the Golden Globes interview with Sixel and Miller (goldenglobes.com <https://goldenglobes.com/?p=93087>), which gives the comparative cut counts for *Mad Max 2* and *Fury Road*; John Seale on centre-framing and Vashi Nedomansky's "Mad Max: Center Framed," via Newsshooter <https://www.newsshooter.com/2015/06/05/filming-mad-max-fury-road-with-dp-john-seale-acs-asc-and-2nd-unit-cinematographer-david-burr-acs/>. The 2015 game and Chumbucket's Angel Combustion: Mad Max (2015 video game) (Wikipedia) <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mad_Max_(2015_video_game)>; "Chumbucket: the unsung hero of Mad Max," Thumbsticks <https://www.thumbsticks.com/chumbucket-the-unsung-hero-of-mad-max/>. *Furiosa*'s production, score, black-and-white edition, and Taylor-Joy's dialogue count: Furiosa: A Mad Max Saga (Wikipedia) <https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Furiosa:_A_Mad_Max_Saga>.


VIII

CHAPTER EIGHT

Burying the Furies

Toward a Humic Eschatology

The Argument Recapitulated 8.1

THIS THESIS BEGAN from an inaugural problem: that the Mad Max saga is a mythology without a scripture, a cycle of variants in search of the myth that would make sense of them. It has proposed that the missing scripture is the *Oresteia* of Aeschylus, and that the saga is that trilogy's most sustained modern variant—a petro-Oresteia, a tragedy of retaliation whose Furies are the unburied dead of geological time, raised from beneath the earth as fuel and returned to the air as fire. The claim was homological rather than genetic. The trilogy and the saga address a single deep problem—how a community ruined by retaliation may transmute fury into order—under radically different material conditions. What the saga added to the problem was the specific condition of fossil modernity, in which the energies requiring conversion are geological as well as psychic, and in which the exhaustion of fuel, of law, and of narrative converge.

The argument proceeded through the saga's variants in the order of their making. Chapter Two traced the saga's descent from the clinic and the workshop, the oil shocks, the antipodean apocalypse, and the cinema of wheels, and found in the year 1979 the convergence of those lines. Chapter Three read the first film as the saga's *Agamemnon* and *Libation Bearers*: a curse of infrastructure rather than of blood; a law split into a juridical form without force and a force without juridical form; a crisis of distinctions in which the Patrol and the gang became doubles; a Dionysian cult whose energies would return as a state; an officer turned revenger, mad again in the Waste Land; a founding catastrophe of mother and child; and a *lex talionis* executed as rite by a Fury with no community left to purify. Chapter Four read the second and third films as the saga's anatomy of the economy of fire: the refinery besieged, the

catastrophic expenditure of the accursed share, the tanker of sand, the myth of barter inverted, the underworld that fuels rather than sows, the arena that stages violence in order to contain it, the face that interrupts the arena's law, and the scapegoat carried out as Death into the green of the lost children.

Chapter Five, the thesis's centre, read *Fury Road* as the saga's *Eumenides* and as a counter-*Eumenides*. It found in the film Henry Adams's opposition of Dynamo and Virgin; the Fisher King of the Grail romances and his healing question turned into an indictment; the War Boys' resurrection in chrome and Nux's death into soil; the Wives' refusal of the Apollonian embryology; an Exodus that becomes a revolution at its turning point on the salt; a Fury whose rage becomes grief and whose grief is answered by persuasion; and a settlement in which blood, water, and seed are given, released, and carried into the city. Chapter Six read *Furiosa* as the genealogy of the Fury and the completion of the Eumenidean turn: a saga of feud that ends beyond vengeance, an abduction of Persephone from a Peach Blossom Spring, a demagogue who demands an epic and receives a georgic, a mutilated woman who builds her own arm and the vessel of liberation, a chronicler who chooses among the variants the myth that can be planted, and a tyrant made the root of a fruit tree. Chapter Seven read the saga's form as a kinetic liturgy and its afterlives as a constellation, and found that the saga, alone among the works of that constellation, traverses the axis from the fire that must be carried to the fire that must be buried, and from the burial of the fire to the planting of the seed.

This final chapter does four things. It reconsiders the five analytical instruments in the light of the whole argument, and proposes that their movement yields a new conception of political order (8.2). It situates the saga's eschatology among the eschatologies of the religious traditions and of the climate present (8.3–8.4). It confronts the limits of the saga's settlement—its silences, its exclusions, its complicities (8.5)—and, through the thought of the Australian philosopher Val Plumwood, the ethical demand that the saga's last image makes upon its audience (8.6). And it gathers its conclusions into eleven theses on what this study calls humic eschatology (8.7), before closing with a coda on the burial of the Furies (8.8).

8.2 The Five Instruments Reconsidered: From the Post-Nomic to a Humic Nomos

The five concepts introduced in Chapter One were designed to name structures that the saga articulates in images and motion before any theory articulated them in

words. Read across the whole saga, each turns out to describe not a static structure but a movement—a conversion that the saga accomplishes over forty-five years.

The *Erinyic economy*—the isomorphism of combustion and vengeance as regimes of irreversible expenditure—governs the first film absolutely and the second and third structurally. In *Mad Max* it is the whole of the world: the motive power of fire and the motive power of rage drive the same machines along the same roads to the same crashes. In *Mad Max 2* it becomes the fuel war, the catastrophic potlatch of the accursed share; in *Beyond Thunderdome* it becomes an institution, the arena that stages the economy in order to contain it. In the last films it is converted. *Fury Road* transforms its emblematic fluid, blood, from an extracted resource into a gift, and its emblematic death, the War Boy's martyrdom, from a spectacle of combustion into a seed falling into the ground. *Furiosa* transforms vengeance itself into cultivation. The economy of irreversible expenditure is answered by an economy of germination, in which the irreversibility of growth is set against the irreversibility of destruction.

Chthonopolitics—sovereignty founded upon the control of what lies beneath—appears in its larval form in the refinery of *Mad Max 2*, in its market form in the methane Underworld of Bartertown, and in its perfected form in the hydraulic despotism of the Citadel. Its conversion is the release of the waters: the moment at which the chthonic resource ceases to be hoarded and becomes common. The Citadel does not cease to stand above its aquifer, and its new rulers do not cease to rule; but the relation between sovereignty and the underground has been reversed. What was withheld is given. What was extracted flows.

The *pharmakos-witness*—Max as scapegoat and as the witness who refuses martyrdom—moves from the first film's failed scapegoating, in which a marginal gang member is destroyed with no community to purify, through the second film's expulsion by deception and the third's expulsion by law, to *Fury Road*'s transformation of the *pharmakos* into the *pharmakon* freely given: the transfusion that saves the founder of the city and the name spoken as the seal of the gift. The witness who could not stop seeing becomes the donor who gives what he was harvested for. He still departs; the scapegoat's structural fate does not change. But his departure is no longer an expulsion. It is a withdrawal, chosen, from a city that he has helped to found and has no need to rule.

Kinetic liturgy—the chase as rite—moves from the terror of the first film's crash zooms, through the classical choreography of the second, to *Fury Road*'s ring-composed social drama, in which an audience undergoes with the fugitives the passage from flight to return, and finally to *Furiosa*'s turn from velocity to duration. The saga's form converts itself as its content does: from the spectacle of combustion to

the rite of passage, and from the rite of passage to the slow time in which a person, and a tree, are grown.

The *Eumenidean turn* names the whole of this movement, and its political content can now be stated with precision. Carl Schmitt, in a short essay of 1953, "Nehmen / Teilen / Weiden," argued that every social and legal order rests upon three primal acts, expressed in the three senses of the Greek *nemein* from which *nomos* derives: to take, to divide, and to pasture—appropriation, distribution, and production. For Schmitt the founding act was always the first. There is no dividing without a prior taking, no producing without a prior division, and the origin of every nomos is a *Landnahme*, an appropriation of land. The Wasteland's sovereigns are Schmittian through and through. Each founds his order by taking—the refinery, the methane works, the aquifer, the wombs—and divides what he has taken according to his power. The post-nomic condition of the first film is the exhaustion of a nomos founded on taking; the chthonopolitical regimes of the middle films are new nomoi founded on new takings.

What the Eumenidean turn proposes is a nomos founded otherwise: one whose primal act is not taking but pasturing—*Weiden*, cultivation, the tending of what grows. Schmitt's sequence is inverted. The Many Mothers do not begin by seizing; they begin by tending, and their order distributes what their tending produces. The peach tree in the Citadel's garden is the emblem of such a nomos: an order whose foundation is not an appropriation of the earth but a return to it. This thesis calls it the humic nomos, and it is the political content of the humic eschatology that the remainder of the chapter elaborates. Its claim is not that taking and dividing can be abolished—every order takes and divides—but that the order of priority can be reversed, so that the first question a polity asks of the ground is not what can be seized from it but what must be given back to it for anything to grow.

8.3 The Last Things and the First: Comparative Eschatologies

Eschatology is the doctrine of the last things, and every eschatology discloses, in its image of the end, what a culture takes to be ultimate. The saga's final images—water pouring from a fortress upon a thirsting multitude, and a fruit tree growing in the fortress's garden—invite comparison with the last things of the religious traditions, and the comparison is most illuminating precisely where it fails.

The Christian Bible ends with a city. In the twenty-second chapter of the Book of Revelation, the seer is shown "a pure river of water of life, clear as crystal," flowing

from the throne through the street of the New Jerusalem, "and on either side of the river, was there the tree of life, which bare twelve manner of fruits, and yielded her fruit every month: and the leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations" (Revelation 22:1–2). The canon that began in a garden, with a forbidden tree and an expulsion, ends in a city with a river and a tree whose fruit is freely given. The saga's final images are the Apocalypse's final images: a city whose waters flow, and a tree whose fruit is carried to the captives. The correspondence extends to the structure of the whole. The saga, too, begins with a garden—the Green Place, glimpsed at the opening of *Furiosa* and lost to an intrusion over fruit—and ends with a city-garden in which water and tree have been restored. Its arc from Eden to the New Jerusalem is the Bible's own.

The difference is decisive. In Revelation the holy city descends "out of heaven from God" (Revelation 21:10): the new world is a gift from above, consequent upon the destruction of the old by divine judgement. In the saga the city's waters are released by human hands, and its tree is grown from the ground—from a seed carried by a woman and planted in the body of a tyrant. The renewal does not descend; it rises. The saga keeps the Apocalypse's final image and replaces its mechanism: not descent but germination, not a gift from heaven but a labour in the earth. This is the first meaning of the phrase humic eschatology. The last things are not above but below. The eschaton lies in the soil.

The Norse eschatology examined in Chapter Five offers a closer mechanism. In the *Völuspá*, after the fire and flood of Ragnarök, the earth rises green from the waves and unsown fields bear grain: renewal comes from below, without a sower. The Zoroastrian tradition, which Norman Cohn's *Cosmos, Chaos and the World to Come* (1993) identified as a probable fountainhead of Western apocalyptic, imagines at the end of time a final renovation of the world, the *frashokereti*, in which existence is made wonderful; in the account preserved in the *Bundahishn*, a flood of molten metal passes over the earth, through which all humanity must walk, and to the righteous it will feel like walking through warm milk. The image is uncannily apt to a saga whose War Boys spray their mouths with chrome and whose Citadel is fed with mother's milk. In the Zoroastrian end, molten metal and milk are the same substance experienced by different souls; in the saga, the age of metal must be passed through, and what lies on its far side tastes of milk.

Not every tradition has an eschaton. The Aboriginal traditions of the continent on which the saga was made organise time otherwise. The anthropologist W. E. H. Stanner, in his essay "The Dreaming" (1953), coined the word "everywhen" for a conception of time in which the ancestral events that shaped the land are neither past nor future but perpetually present, inscribed in Country and renewed in ceremony.

In such a cosmology there is no end of the world to await, because the world is not a story moving toward a conclusion but a ground continually sustained by obligation. The saga, a settler mythology, does not share this conception, and section 8.5 will argue that this is among its limits. But the humic eschatology toward which the saga moves stands nearer to Stanner's everywhen than to Revelation's descent: an end that is not an event but a ground, not a catastrophe to be awaited but a relation to be sustained.

The modern philosophy of history offers two final terms. Walter Benjamin, in the second of his theses "On the Concept of History," proposed that every generation has been endowed with a weak messianic power, to which the past has a claim; the messianic, for Benjamin, does not arrive in glory but is woven into the smallest moments of time, any of which may be the strait gate through which redemption enters. The seed is the image of weak messianic power: small, slow, unspectacular, and capable of transforming everything. Ernst Bloch's *The Principle of Hope* (1954–59) distinguished abstract utopia, the compensatory dream of an elsewhere, from concrete utopia, a hope grounded in the real tendencies and latencies of the present. *Fury Road* stages the passage from one to the other. Max tells Furiosa at one point that hope is a mistake—that one who cannot fix what is broken will go mad—and Furiosa's hope of the Green Place proves, as the film reveals, an abstract utopia, the dream of a place that no longer exists. On the salt her hope is converted. It ceases to be the hope of an elsewhere and becomes the hope of the Citadel: a concrete utopia, grounded in the water and the green things that are already there, waiting to be taken from the tyrant and given to the people. The saga refutes Max's maxim not by restoring the Green Place but by relocating hope from the place that was lost to the place that can be transformed.

8.4 2015 and 2024: The Saga in the Climate Present

The saga's last two films appeared at moments that the history of the climate crisis will remember. *Fury Road* had its premiere at Cannes in May 2015. Within weeks, Pope Francis issued the encyclical *Laudato si'*, on care for our common home, which declared access to safe drinkable water a basic and universal human right and diagnosed the ecological crisis as the consequence of a "technocratic paradigm" that treats the earth as an object of limitless extraction—a diagnosis that converges, in a theological idiom, with Heidegger's analysis of enframing and with the Citadel's regime of the standing-reserve. In the same spring, a group of scholars associated with the Breakthrough Institute published *An Ecomodernist Manifesto*, which

proposed to resolve the crisis by intensifying humanity's technological mastery of nature—through nuclear power, agricultural intensification, and the decoupling of human welfare from environmental impact. In the same year the *Guardian* ran a campaign urging institutions to divest from fossil fuels under the slogan "Keep it in the ground," and in December the nations of the world adopted the Paris Agreement, committing themselves to hold warming well below two degrees and to pursue efforts to limit it to one and a half.

The saga's mythic structure clarifies the alternatives that year presented. The ecomodernist programme is a techno-messianism: the hope that a new and better fire—cleaner, more powerful, more fully mastered—will deliver humanity from the consequences of the old. In the saga's terms it is the War Boys' theology rationalised: resurrection through the machine. The divestment slogan, by contrast, is Eumenidean in its very wording. To keep it in the ground is to leave the chthonic powers below, honoured rather than consumed; it is the settlement Athena offered the Furies, translated into the language of climate policy. And the encyclical, with its insistence on water as a common right and its critique of the paradigm that makes every being a resource, articulates in a religious idiom the release of the Citadel's waters. *Fury Road* appeared, in other words, in the year in which the global culture debated, in practical terms, the choice between the Dynamo and the Eumenides.

Furiosa appeared in 2024. In January 2025 the World Meteorological Organization, consolidating six international datasets, reported that the global mean surface temperature in 2024 had been about 1.55 degrees Celsius above the pre-industrial average of 1850–1900, making it the warmest year on record and probably the first calendar year above the 1.5-degree threshold named in the Paris Agreement. A single year's excess does not in itself signify the failure of the agreement's long-term goal, which is measured over decades; but it marks a symbolic passage. The saga's last film —a film about the destruction of the last green place and the planting of a tree in the ruins—was released in the first year of a world beyond the line that the nations had drawn nine years before. Its commercial failure in that year, examined in Chapter Six, is a small datum. Its timing is not.

The novelist Amitav Ghosh argued in *The Great Derangement* (2016) that climate change had proved largely unthinkable for the serious literary fiction of the industrial nations, which, bound to the probable and the everyday, had relegated the improbable events of a destabilised planet to science fiction and fantasy, where they could be safely discounted. Ghosh's diagnosis was just, but the saga suggests a corollary that he did not draw. The genres to which the climate was relegated were not merely its place of exile. They were also its myth-making apparatus—the place in which the culture's deepest images of energy, catastrophe, and renewal were

worked out in a form that could reach the widest audiences. The Mad Max saga is the demonstration. Excluded from the realism Ghosh describes, it took up the oldest form of thinking about the unthinkable, which is myth, and over forty-five years it thought its way from the burning of the world toward the planting of it.

Two contemporary fantasies define, by opposition, what the saga's humic eschatology is not. The first is petromelancholia, Stephanie LeMenager's term for the grief that attends the loss of an oil-saturated way of life: a mourning for the car, the road, and the freedom of mobility that can coexist with knowledge of their destructiveness, and can even become a form of continuing attachment to them. The first trilogy was in part petromelancholic; its spectacle of engines was also a lament for them. The second fantasy is the escape of the rich, which Douglas Rushkoff's *Survival of the Richest* (2022) documented among technology billionaires preparing bunkers, compounds, and island refuges against "the Event," the collapse they anticipate and in part produce. Immortan Joe's Citadel is that fantasy's image: a fortified summit with its own water, its own gardens, its own guards, and a multitude below. The saga's last films reject both fantasies. They neither mourn the fire nor escape its consequences. They turn back toward the Citadel and open its gates.

8.5 The Limits of the Settlement

A thesis that has argued for the saga's achievement must state, with equal clarity, the limits of that achievement. Four are fundamental.

The first and gravest is the saga's silence about the continent's first peoples. In his Boyer Lectures of 1968, *After the Dreaming*, W. E. H. Stanner named "the great Australian silence": a cult of forgetfulness practised on a national scale, by which Australian historiography had excluded Aboriginal people from the nation's story as though by a structural habit of looking elsewhere. The Mad Max saga participates in that silence. Its deserts are empty of Aboriginal presence across five films and forty-five years; its imagery lends Indigenous iconography to settler children and grants the honorific of female eldership to a figure of global celebrity; its humic utopia is an orchard of introduced fruit. Chapter Six recorded the criticism, made at *Furiosa*'s release, that the franchise had done little to address the country's colonial past, and this thesis has argued that the criticism is just. The saga's emptiness is not an accident of genre. It is the cinematic form of *terra nullius*, the founding legal fiction that the High Court repudiated in 1992 and that the saga's imagination has never ceased to rehearse.

The limit reaches deeper than omission, because it touches the saga's very premise. The Potawatomi philosopher Kyle Powys Whyte has argued, in "Our Ancestors' Dystopia Now" (2017), that for Indigenous peoples the dystopian and post-apocalyptic futures that settler culture imagines are not speculative. Colonialism was already the end of their worlds—already the environmental and social catastrophe that settler fiction projects into the future—and Indigenous communities have spent centuries living in its aftermath and devising forms of survival and renewal within it. From this perspective the Wasteland is not Australia's future but its colonial past and present: the dispossession of land, the poisoning of Country by the atomic tests at Maralinga and Emu Field, the assault upon the social orders that had sustained the continent for tens of thousands of years, seen through the eyes of the settlers' descendants, who imagine their own dispossession as the end of the world. The saga's apocalypse is, in this light, a settler's anxiety dream: the fear of suffering what the settlers inflicted. Meaghan Morris's reading of the films as expressions of white panic, noted in Chapter One, anticipated the conclusion.

What follows for humic eschatology is not that it must be abandoned but that it must learn from those who have lived after the end. Deborah Bird Rose, in *Nourishing Terrains* (1996), described Aboriginal understandings of Country as a living entity to which people are bound by reciprocal obligation—a place that nourishes those who care for it and is nourished by their care. Bill Gammage's *The Biggest Estate on Earth* (2011) documented the scale and sophistication of Aboriginal land management by fire. These are not models that the saga may appropriate, and this thesis does not propose that it should. But they indicate the direction in which a humic eschatology, true to its own logic, would have to move: from the orchard planted on seized ground toward reciprocal care for Country whose custodians never ceded it. The Eumenidean settlement installed the Furies beneath a city founded on conquest. A settlement equal to the saga's own insight would have to begin by acknowledging whose ground the Furies are buried in.

The second limit concerns gender. *Fury Road*'s reversal of the Apollonian embryology is the saga's most celebrated achievement, and Chapter Five defended it. But the reversal risks preserving the dualism it inverts. The saga's women are defined, to a striking degree, by reproduction and nurture—Wives, breeders, milkers, Many Mothers, a Keeper of Seeds—and its men by machines and violence; the Eumenidean turn is figured as a passage from a male principle of combustion to a female principle of fertility. The Australian philosopher Val Plumwood's *Feminism and the Mastery of Nature* (1993) warned against precisely this move: against an ecological feminism that, in valorising the feminine and the natural against the masculine and the rational, accepts the very dualism through which women and nature were

together subordinated. Furiosa, the cyborg who builds her own arm and drives the war machine, is the saga's partial answer to the danger—a figure belonging to neither side of the dualism. But the saga's imagery of salvation remains heavily maternal, and its liberation of women remains closely bound to their capacity to bear.

The third limit is the spectacle's complicity. The saga's critique of the combustion economy has been produced by one of the most combustion-intensive art forms ever devised. *Fury Road*'s practical stunts burned fuel and wrecked vehicles on a scale that its own story condemns, and its production in the Namib drew allegations, disputed by Namibian authorities, of damage to a fragile desert. The saga's audiences have taken pleasure in the very spectacle of engines that its argument indicts; LeMenager's petromelancholia is not only a theme of the films but a condition of their reception. This complicity is not a reason to dismiss the saga's argument—every myth is told in the materials of its age—but it is a reason to recognise that the saga's conversion is, in part, one it asks of its audience rather than one it has accomplished in its own making.

The fourth limit is the persistence of the hero. The saga has laboured for four decades to render Max unnecessary, and within its stories it has largely succeeded. It has not succeeded in its titles. Every film bears his name; the last is called a Mad Max saga though its hero appears for seconds; and the culture continues to use the name as a byword for the very collapse that the late films sought to convert. Brecht's warning, examined in Chapter Three, applies to the saga's own market. An industry in need of heroes cannot easily release a myth whose lesson is that heroes are not what is needed.

8.6 Being Food: Plumwood, Compost, and the Ethics of Return

Val Plumwood is the saga's most fitting philosophical interlocutor in another respect, which bears directly upon its final image. In February 1985, canoeing alone in Kakadu National Park, Plumwood was seized by a saltwater crocodile, dragged three times into the water, and survived, gravely injured. In her essay "Being Prey," in "Tasteless: Towards a Food-Based Approach to Death" (2008), and in the writings gathered after her death as *The Eye of the Crocodile* (2012), she reflected on what the experience had taught her: that Western culture refuses to see the human being as food—as a body that is, like every other living body, part of the circulation of matter and energy through which life sustains itself. The refusal is expressed, she argued, in funerary practices designed to remove human bodies from the exchanges of the

living world, sealing them in heavy coffins and concrete so that they nourish nothing. An ethics adequate to the ecological crisis would have to begin, for Plumwood, by accepting that we too are food, and by imagining forms of death that return the body to the community of life rather than withdrawing it.

Furiosa's last image is the most literal cinematic rendering of Plumwood's thought. The tyrant is not removed from the circulation of life; he is made its root. The audience's horror at the image is real, and appropriate: it is the horror of a culture that has refused to see the human as food, confronted with a human body that feeds a tree. But the horror is also instructive. The image forces upon its audience the recognition that Plumwood's ordeal forced upon her—that the human body belongs to the earth, and that the refusal of this belonging, the fantasy of a humanity exempt from the cycles of decay and return, is continuous with the fantasy of a civilisation exempt from the consequences of its combustion. The Immortan's name is the name of that refusal. The peach tree is its end.

The oldest traditions already knew what Plumwood rediscovered. In Genesis the first human is formed from the dust of the ground—*adam* from *adamah*, the earth-creature from the earth—and sentenced, after the expulsion from the garden, to return to it: "for dust thou art, and unto dust shalt thou return" (Genesis 3:19). The burial service of the Book of Common Prayer commits the body to the ground, "earth to earth, ashes to ashes, dust to dust." The Latin *humus*, soil, belongs to the same family of words as *homo* and *humanus*, and as *humilis*, humble—the low, the near-to-the-ground. Donna Haraway's insistence that we are compost rather than posthuman draws upon this family, proposing that the human be understood neither as the master of the earth nor as its technological successor but as one of its composting creatures. Humic eschatology takes its name from this cluster of words. It is the eschatology of the earth-creature who knows that its end is a return to the ground, and that the return is not only a sentence but a gift: the condition upon which other lives are nourished.

The Furies of the *Oresteia*, installed beneath Athens, are honoured as the givers of fertility; their dwelling is in the earth, and their blessing rises from it. Plumwood's ethics of being food, Haraway's compost, and the saga's peach tree are three modern versions of the same settlement. The powers below are not to be extracted and burned, nor sealed away and forgotten, but honoured as the ground of life—a ground into which every living thing, the tyrant and the Fury and the witness alike, will in the end return, and from which, in the end, something will grow.

8.7 Eleven Theses on Humic Eschatology

In the tradition of the numbered theses through which Marx, Benjamin, and Chakrabarty compressed arguments too large for continuous prose, the conclusions of this study may be gathered into eleven propositions.

I The end of the fossil world is a chthonic event.

Fossil fuels are the remains of the ancient dead, raised from beneath the earth and burned. The climate crisis is the return of what was raised: the powers of the underworld turned against the world above, as the Erinyes threatened to blight the land that dishonoured them. Any account of the end of the fossil age that forgets where its energies came from will misunderstand what is ending.

II Combustion and vengeance are one economy.

Both convert stored quantities—carbon, grievance—into heat and motion by irreversible transformation; both propagate themselves; both end only in exhaustion or in conversion. A politics that would bring the one to an end must reckon with the other, for a civilisation that burns its past to drive its present will also burn its grievances to drive its wars.

III The Wasteland is post-nomic, not pre-political.

It is not the state of nature from which the covenant delivers, but the afterlife of an order that has consumed its own foundations. Its violence is not original but residual; its law survives as form without force, and its force as power without law. Hobbes describes its symptoms. Aeschylus diagnoses its cause.

IV Sovereignty in the age of exhaustion is chthonopolitical.

It rests upon control of what lies beneath—aquifer, oil seam, ore—and it treats every body as a reservoir. Its emblem is the Citadel: a fortress above an aquifer, with gardens at the summit and a multitude below, which counsels the thirsty not to grow addicted to water. Its contemporary forms are the cartel, the chokepoint, and the bunker.

V The Furies cannot be defeated, and should not be burned.

Every attempt to end the cycle of retaliation by victory renews it. The cult destroyed in one generation returns as the state of the next; the tyrant slain is succeeded by

the slayer. The Furies can be neither abolished nor consumed. They can only be converted.

Conversion begins in grief. VI

Fury that finds no object becomes mourning, and mourning, unlike fury, can be answered. The founding of the city begins with the scream in the dunes, when the Fury learns that what she fought to return to is gone. A culture that cannot grieve its losses will go on burning them.

Conversion requires persuasion. VII

The decisive act is not violence but speech: the argument that turns the fugitives from exodus to return, from the dream of an elsewhere to the transformation of the place they fled. Athena owed her settlement to Persuasion; the saga's silent hero performs his greatest deed in his only argument. The hero's highest act is to persuade, and then to depart.

The vessel replaces the spear. VIII

Liberation is carried, not conquered: in a tanker, a seed-bag, a womb, a war rig whose cargo is the future. The story adequate to the end of the fossil age is the carrier-bag story, in which the decisive acts are gathering, holding, and bringing home—not the hero's story, in which the decisive act is the kill.

The georgic replaces the epic. IX

The tyrant demands that vengeance be made epic; the Fury answers with a harvest. The genre adequate to the end of the fossil age is the poem of cultivation written in the aftermath of civil war, in which the ploughman turns up the rusted weapons of the battle and plants the field.

The eschaton lies in the ground. X

Renewal does not descend; it rises. The New Jerusalem's river and tree are not received from heaven but released and grown by human hands from the earth. The last things are seeds, and the end of the world, if it is survived, will be accomplished as a planting by those who return what was taken to the soil from which it came.

XI

The myths have only burned the world, in various ways; the point is to plant it.

Every culture chooses, among the variants of its stories, the myths by which it will live. The chronicler of the Wasteland chose the tree. A civilisation facing the end of its fire is responsible for the stories it keeps, and the saga, at the last, has told it which one to keep.

8.8 Coda: Burying the Furies

The *Oresteia* ends with a procession. Athena, having persuaded the Furies to accept a home in her city, summons the women who serve her shrine to escort them, by torchlight and in crimson robes, to their dwelling beneath the hill of Ares, and the citizens are bidden to keep holy silence and then to raise the cry of joy as the August Goddesses go down into the earth. The trilogy's last sounds are the sounds of a burial celebrated as a festival: the Furies, honoured, enter the ground from which they will bless the land.

The Mad Max saga does not end with a procession, but it ends with a burial. Its last-made film closes with a tyrant planted in a garden and the first fruit of his body carried to the captives who will go free; the film before it closes with the waters of the underground released upon the people and the wanderer withdrawing into the crowd. Between them, the two films enact the settlement that the first film's world had lost the capacity even to imagine: the chthonic powers returned to the ground, honoured rather than consumed, and made the source of the city's life rather than the instrument of its destruction.

Chapter One closed with the question that *Fury Road*'s epigraph, attributed to the First History Man, poses after the restoration of the waters: where must we go, we who wander this Wasteland in search of our better selves? The thesis can now state the saga's answer. Not elsewhere: the Green Place is gone, and the salt offers only a hundred and sixty days of white void. Not upward: the Citadel's summit is the sovereign's fantasy of escape, and the platform that rises toward it carries the risk of a new sovereignty. The answer is downward—toward the ground; toward the aquifer that must be shared, the soil that must be tended, the seed that must be planted, and the Furies that must be buried with honour. The Wasteland is not escaped. It is composted.

Max, at the end of *Fury Road*, slips into the crowd and is gone, and the saga's last glimpse of him, in *Furiosa*, is a figure watching from afar. He has been, through five films, the *pharmakos* and the witness: the one who sees, who is expelled, who gives

his blood and his name, and who departs. Benjamin's angel of history, with whom Chapter One closed, sees the wreckage pile at its feet while the storm of progress drives it backward into a future it cannot face. The saga's last image proposes another figure for the angel's place: not a being driven by a storm but a tree rooted in a ground, its back turned to no future and its face to no ruin, bearing fruit in the garden of a city that has stopped burning its dead.

The Furies cannot be defeated, and should not be burned. They must be buried with honour, so that they may bless the soil. That is the argument of the *Oresteia*, and it is the argument of the saga that has rewritten it for the age of fire. It is also, for the civilisation that has watched these films for forty-five years, the argument of its own present: the powers it raised from the ground must be returned to it, and the end of the fossil world, if it is to be survived, must be accomplished not as an apocalypse but as a planting.

Source for Chapter Eight. Global temperature figures for 2024: World Meteorological Organization, "WMO confirms 2024 as warmest year on record at about 1.55°C above pre-industrial level" <https://wmo.int/media/news/wmo-confirms-2024-warmest-year-record-about-155degc-above-pre-industrial-level>.

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Keywords

Mad Max; George Miller; Byron Kennedy; *Fury Road*; *Furiosa*; *Beyond Thunderdome*; *The Road Warrior*; petro-Oresteia; Aeschylus; *Oresteia*; Erinyes; Eumenides; Eumenidean turn; Erinyic economy; chthonopolitics; pharmakos-witness; kinetic liturgy; humic eschatology; post-nomic order; petro-chthonic; humic-chthonic; Apollonian embryology; matricide; mother-right; feminist classical reception; energy humanities; petroculture; petrofiction; petromelancholia; fossil fuels; entropy; thermodynamics and history; Georgescu-Roegen; Henry Adams; general economy; Georges Bataille; mythic violence; Walter Benjamin; mimetic violence; René Girard; scapegoat; pharmakon; hydraulic despotism; nomos of the earth; carbon democracy; standing-reserve; biopolitics; necropolitics; dromology; Paul Virilio; war machine; nomadology; asabiyya; Ibn Khaldun; monomyth; Joseph Campbell; comparative mythology; structural anthropology; Lévi-Strauss; bricolage; Nachleben; Pathosformel; Aby Warburg; Roland Barthes; ring composition; ritual and liminality; Grail myth; Fisher King; Norse eschatology; einherjar; Exodus; Gilgamesh; dema deity; carrier bag theory; Ursula K. Le Guin; Chthulucene; compost; Donna Haraway; metabolic rift; post-apocalyptic cinema; speculative fiction; Australian cinema; Ozploitation; Australian Gothic; road movie; action cinema; pure cinema; terra nullius; settler colonialism; ecocriticism; ecofeminism; Anthropocene; climate fiction.